

A Hundred Flowers



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF GAIL TSUKIYAMA

Gail Tsukiyama was born in San Francisco to a Japanese father from Hawaii and a Chinese mother from Hong Kong, who was a painter. She attended San Francisco State University. Originally a film studies major, she turned to English literature and creative writing when she decided they allowed more artistic freedom for the kind of storytelling she wanted to do. Her literary career began with poetry, later transitioning to the publication of short stories and, to date, nine novels. Many of these focus on the emotional lives of Chinese, Japanese, and Asian-American protagonists. She teaches at San Francisco State University and writes for journals like *Ms. magazine*.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The main context for *A Hundred Flowers* is the history of the Chinese Communist Revolution and the Maoist era, when the country was under the sway of Communist Party Chairman Mao Zedong. The Chinese Communist Party formed in 1921, and it grew more powerful during the years of the Chinese Civil Wars until it captured control of the country in 1949. Under Mao, the country devolved into fascism and a personality cult centering around Mao. It engaged in brutal campaigns to imprison or execute wealthy landowners, capitalists, intellectuals, and anyone who disagreed with its policies; increase agricultural and industrial production; and purge traditional practices from Chinese culture. These campaigns often led to tragic suffering, such as the Great Chinese Famine of 1959–1961, in which the Party's foolish and ill-informed policy decisions led to a 70 percent drop in agricultural production and the deaths of 15–55 million people. Soon afterwards, the Party launched the Cultural Revolution, which began in 1966 and ended only with Mao's death in 1977. This period was characterized by chaos and violence. Mao's call for young revolutionaries to rebel against anyone and anything accused of failing to support the Party or its aims (even Party members) led to multiple massacres, the destruction of priceless cultural artifacts, mass incidences of public humiliation, and the exile of scholars, professionals, and intellectuals to the countryside to perform manual labor.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The years leading up to and following the Chinese Communist Party takeover in 1949 were full of political upheaval and social turmoil in China; they have provided rich fodder for authors of fiction and non-fiction alike. While *A Hundred Flowers* looks at a narrow slice of this period, just a few months in 1958, it also

refers back to the time before Communist Party rule, and it hints at the impending crackdowns and failed policies that marred its rule in the 50s and 60s. Jung Chang's 1991 *Wild Swans: Three Daughters of China* covers this broad sweep of time and its massive changes through the lives of the author's grandmother, who grew up in the 19th century's warlord era and had bound feet; her mother, who joined the Party during its early years; and the author herself, who came of age during the Cultural Revolution of the 1960s. Chinese author Yu Hua's novel, *To Live*, published in 1994 and translated into English in 2003, follows Fugui, the indolent son of a wealthy landowner, as the Communist takeover forces him into the life of an impoverished peasant. Despite facing unimaginable tragedies, often thanks to the cruelty and short-sightedness of Party policies, Fugui's suffering transforms him into an honest and caring man who learns to find hope and strength even in the darkest of circumstances. Vanessa Hua's 2021 novel, *Forbidden City*, also examines the cruelties and shortcomings of the Communist Revolution, through the eyes of Mei, a true believer who later becomes disillusioned and flees not just the Party but the country and her own history.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** A Hundred Flowers
- **When Written:** 2010s
- **Where Written:** California, United States
- **When Published:** 2012
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary period
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction
- **Setting:** Guangzhou, a city in southern China, during the Hundred Flowers and Great Leap Forward campaigns
- **Climax:** Wei finally gets to speak with Sheng at the labor camp.
- **Antagonist:** The Chinese Communist Party
- **Point of View:** Third-person limited, rotating through multiple characters' perspectives

EXTRA CREDIT

The Basics of Life. Tsukiyama is an executive director of WaterBridge Outreach: Books + Water, a charity that brings what it deems “the basics of life”—clean drinking water and books that encourage multicultural literacy—to communities around the globe.

Deep Roots. *Bombax ceiba*, or the kapok tree, has been cultivated in southern China for centuries, with historical

records indicating that the Han Chinese emperor received one as a gift from a neighboring king in the 2nd century B.C.E.



PLOT SUMMARY

A year before the story begins, Tao watched as Communist Party police arrested his father, Sheng. What his mother Kai Ying and grandfather Wei have not told him is that the Party suspected Sheng of writing a letter critical of the government during its Hundred Flowers Campaign. After his arrest, they sent Sheng to a labor camp 1,000 miles away in the city of Luoyang. The family has not heard from him in six months.

Now in the present, in July of 1958, Tao climbs the kapok tree in the courtyard of his family's villa. He misses Sheng, and a dream told Tao to climb the tree and look for his father on the peaks of distant **White Cloud Mountain**. But near the top of the tree, he loses his grip and falls 30 feet to the ground below. When Wei and Kai Ying bring Tao to the hospital, Kai Ying notices a pregnant teenager (Suyin) staring at her across the waiting room. Suyin has been living on the streets since her family discovered her pregnancy and kicked her out.

When Tao returns home after several weeks in the hospital, the family struggles to find a sense of normalcy. Tao anxiously waits for his cast to come off, while Kai Ying worries about Sheng and Tao. And Wei confronts his guilt over the fact that *he* wrote the letter for which Sheng was arrested—the authorities confused father and son because they share the same name.

On the eve of the Autumn Moon Festival, Suyin catches a glimpse of Kai Ying at the market. Taking it as a good omen for her and her baby, she quietly follows Kai Ying home. Later that day, the cast comes off Tao's leg, though it will take time and effort for him to recover his strength and for his limp to go away. The day after the Moon Festival, Suyin bursts into the courtyard in labor. Kai Ying and Wei carry her inside, where she delivers a baby girl. Kai Ying decides to nurse Suyin back to health and secretly names the baby Meizhen.

Soon after the Festival, Tao returns to school and finds that everything has changed since his injury. His friend Little Shen has taken his former spot as second student, and the other children tease Tao about his limp. When class bully Lai Hing tells everyone that Sheng was arrested because he was a counterrevolutionary, Tao confronts Kai Ying and Wei. Realizing that it's time to take responsibility, Wei confesses that he wrote the letter. Kai Ying and Tao feel betrayed by Wei's confession, but Kai Ying tries to pretend that things are normal. Throughout the month of October, Wei becomes more and more anguished. He frequently leaves the house for long, restless walks. Finally, he decides to try to make things right by traveling to Luoyang to check on Sheng. Although he hasn't left the city in 25 years and has barely left his house in the last decade, he boards a northbound train on the last day of

October for the days-long trip. On the way, a young man named Tian befriends and guides Wei, a lucky turn of events since Wei is unprepared for the journey. Tian is traveling to Luoyang because he used to love a young woman named Ai-li, but she abandoned him for the Communist Party after she became deeply invested in its ideology. As Tian helps Wei navigate the Communist Party bureaucracy in his attempt to visit Sheng, he finally makes peace with his own past.

Meanwhile, back at home in Guangzhou, Suyin recovers her strength and worries that Kai Ying will kick her out. She cannot go home; she became pregnant after her stepfather raped her and she cannot face her family again. But she becomes an integral part of the family during the weeks Wei is away, taking on the role of an older sister to Tao and becoming Kai Ying's valued helper and then her full-fledged herbalist's apprentice.

Finally, Wei learns that Sheng is alive and receives permission to visit him. Wei begs for Sheng's forgiveness for writing the letter, for letting Sheng take the blame, and for the distance that has characterized much of their relationship. But Sheng tells his father that he doesn't need to apologize for speaking the truth. Instead, he's proud that Wei finally took a stand for his beliefs, something that has always come more naturally to Sheng. Then, their too-brief visit ends. With a letter from Sheng for Kai Ying safe in his pocket, Wei returns to Kai Ying and Tao, who welcome him with forgiveness and open arms.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Wei Lee – Wei is an aging scholar of ancient Chinese art and history who lives an isolated life with his family in the early years of Communist Party rule in China. Although his wife, Liang, has passed away, Liang's friend Song, Wei's son Sheng, his daughter-in-law Kai Ying, and his grandson Tao love and care for the old man. Wei grew up in privilege, since his father was a merchant with enough wealth to support four wives. Wei has always been insular, completely absorbed in his work, even at the expense of family responsibilities and political involvement. When he realizes, belatedly, how the Party is destroying the Chinese culture he loves and reveres, Wei writes a prideful letter critical of the government. But when the authorities arrest Sheng, believing that he wrote the letter instead of his father, Wei realizes, with a crushing sense of guilt, how out of touch he has been and how his inability or refusal to understand the changing world around him has endangered his family. Ultimately, Wei proves himself to be a responsible, rather than selfish, man—when he can no longer bear the guilt he feels over Sheng's arrest, he confesses his responsibility for the letter and leaves his hometown for the first time in decades to travel north to visit and check on Sheng. On the way, he befriends Tian and learns how to adapt himself to

circumstances rather than trying to force the world to conform to his vision of how it ought to be. Over the course of his journey, Wei not only learns about himself, but he learns how strong the people around him are. Their strength inspires him to become a better person and to take more responsibility for himself and his actions in the world.

Kai Ying Lee – Kai Ying is Sheng’s wife and Tao’s mother. She is the center of the family, the person who brings everyone together and who helps to balance out everyone’s different personalities. Kai Ying came to Guangzhou from a rural village as a teenager to study herbalism with Herbalist Chu; it was in his shop that she first befriended Auntie Song and then met Sheng. Kai Ying is a skilled herbal practitioner who supports her family by prescribing herbs to many people in the neighborhood. She is a diligent worker and is devoted to her family, working hard to make sure that they have enough food to eat, and even to purchase luxuries to make their lives sweeter on occasion. She is kind and generous; she takes Suyin off the streets and cares for her and Meizhen even though she has no idea who the girl is or anything about her past. Kai Ying has strong opinions, but she mostly keeps them to herself. She refuses to criticize the Communist Party for fear of retribution, and she encourages Sheng to keep quiet as well. She also has a strong sense of right and wrong. She feels betrayed when she learns of Wei’s responsibility for Sheng’s arrest, but she continues to treat her father-in-law with respect and demands that Tao do the same. Kai Ying depends on deep inner reserves of strength, but her refusal to acknowledge her own suffering takes a great toll on her spirit. Over the course of the book, she learns to rely on others, like Song and Suyin, for help. As she begins to teach Suyin the herbalist’s art, she discovers that she, like her husband and her father-in-law, loves being a teacher.

Tao Lee – Tao is Sheng and Kai Ying’s seven-year-old son and Wei’s much-adored grandson. A bright, curious, and fearless little boy, Tao thrives at school, where he is ranked second in the class. But he cannot understand what has happened after his father is arrested for opposition to the Communist Party. Tao experiences the family’s trials from the limited viewpoint of a child and his reactions demonstrate both immaturity and his growing self-reliance. He decides to take matters into his own hands when he climbs the **kapok tree** to look for his father and when he runs away to the park, but in both instances, he suffers for this choice, realizing that he still needs others to help take care of him. But he also refuses to let his limp or the slow recovery of his injured leg defeat him, and he stands up for himself when he experiences bullying from Little Shan and Lai Hing. Tao loves his parents and adores his grandfather; he eagerly soaks up all the lessons Wei offers to teach him. And although he initially resents Suyin and Meizhen for taking up too much of his mother’s attention, he grows to love Suyin as a sister. As he grows and matures through a difficult period in his life, Tao begins to come of age and learns to think more

compassionately about others.

Sheng Lee – Sheng is Wei and Liang’s adult son. He’s married to Kai Ying, with whom he has a son, Tao. Like his father, he taught Chinese history. He loves his country passionately and longs for it to achieve greatness, something he thinks is impossible under the Communist Party. During the Hundred Flowers Campaign, he becomes more involved in political activity despite Kai Ying’s fears and protests. When he is blamed for the letter that Wei wrote criticizing the Party, Sheng accepts the punishment—being sent to a labor camp in Luoyang—to protect his father from harm. He thus shows himself to be a conscientious man and a respectful son. His letters home show him to be a loving and kind father and husband, too.

Liang Lee – Liang was Wei’s wife, Sheng’s mother, and Kai Ying’s mother-in-law. She died before Tao was born. In childhood, she and Song became best friends at school; when Old Hing died, she invited Song to come live with the family at the villa. A wealthy and well-educated woman, Liang made a greater impression on those around her for her sense of humor, generosity, and kindness. She rarely expressed anger or disappointment. In her later years, she wanted to take a principled stand against the Communist Party but was foiled by Wei’s unwillingness to participate.

Suyin – Suyin is a 15-year-old girl who grew up in the poorer neighborhood of Old Guangzhou with her mother and two younger brothers. After Suyin’s father abandoned them, her mother married again. Suyin’s stepfather abused and raped her, leading to her pregnancy with Meizhen. She runs away from home when her pregnancy becomes apparent and lives as a beggar on the streets. When she crosses paths with Kai Ying for a second time—the first was at the hospital after Tao’s fall—Suyin follows her home. When she shows up at the villa in labor, Kai Ying takes her in not just for the delivery but for the weeks of recovery afterwards. As Suyin recovers, she begins to find a place in the family, taking on the role of an older sister to Tao and an assistant to Kai Ying; even Wei develops a grudging affection for her. Despite the traumas she has endured, Suyin remains a curious, hopeful, and kind soul who longs to be surrounded by people who love her and whom she loves.

Auntie Song – Song lives at the villa as an adopted family member to Wei, Sheng, Kai Ying, and Tao. She and Liang were best friends as schoolchildren, despite their difference in class and life experience. But Song’s parents pulled her from school at the age of 16 and married her off to Old Hing. Old Hing abused Song physically and emotionally during their marriage, nearly driving her to suicide. When she murders Old Hing with a dose of poison, no one suspect her—or if anyone does, no one blames her. Soon afterwards, Liang invites her to live in the villa’s old, unused servants’ quarters. Song remains ever grateful for the opportunity to live at the villa, where she has a garden for the first time in her life. After Liang’s death, she does her best to care for the family in honor of her friend’s memory.

She treats Kai Ying and Suyin as daughters and takes as much delight in Tao as if he were her grandson. Auntie Song's favorite place is her garden, and she nurtures the family with the food she grows there year-round. She feels deeply connected to the rhythms of nature, and her trust in life makes her far more optimistic than other members of the household.

Tian – Tian befriends Wei on the train from Guangzhou to Luoyang. Tian grew up in Guangzhou, but he began to travel regularly to Luoyang years earlier, because his girlfriend, Ai-li, lived and attended university there. She became increasingly involved in the Communist Party, ultimately abandoning Tian for failing to match her political fervor. This loss haunts Tian and he struggles to find closure. He shows himself to be a wounded but open-hearted man when he takes Wei under his wing on the trip north, helping the older man to navigate his first trip away from the villa in more than 25 years. He returns to Guangzhou before Wei, but with the promise of continuing their friendship after Wei gets home.

Chang'e – Chang'e is a character from Chinese mythology, whose story forms an important part of the Autumn Moon Festival. According to the myth, she swallowed a magic pill in order to keep it from falling into the wrong hands. It made her immortal and turned her into the moon goddess but separated her from her husband, Huoyi, who is associated with the sun. They see each other only once a year during the festival.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Huoyi – Huoyi is a character from Chinese mythology, whose story forms an important part of the Autumn Moon Festival. According to the myth, his wife, Chang'e, lives on the moon while he lives on the sun; they only see each other once a year during the festival.

Ai-li – Ai-li was Tian's girlfriend. The two met when they were students and they shared a long-distance romance for years, until her increasing involvement in the Communist Party eventually led to a rift between the two. She then disappeared without a trace from Tian's life.

Mr. Lam – Mr. Lam owns a sweetshop patronized by the Lee family.

Mr. and Mrs. Chang – After the Communist Party takeover, the Changs move into an apartment carved out of the villa where Wei, Sheng, Kai Ying, Tao, and Song live.

Herbalist Chu – Herbalist Chu is the family friend with whom Kai Ying came to study in Guangzhou as a teenager. He was also Auntie Song's friend and cared for her during the years of her marriage to Old Hing.

Old Hing – Old Hing was Auntie Song's abusive, much older husband. He died in his 80s, after she poisoned him.

Little Shan – Little Shan is Tao's best friend at school. After Tao's injury, Little Shan befriends Lai Hing and becomes Tao's

rival for a time. But he asks for a truce with Tao in the end.

Lai Hing – Lai Hing is a classmate who befriends Little Shan while bullying Tao. He is the one who first tells Tao why the police arrested Sheng.

Comrade Cheng – Comrade Sheng is a corrupt Communist Party official in Guangzhou from whom Kai Ying tries to get information about Sheng's whereabouts.

Sun – Sun was the family cook when Wei was a boy. She could never agree with the housekeeper, Moon, but cared for Moon devotedly after she fell ill. Sun died soon after Moon, and Wei believes they haunt the villa still.

Moon – Moon was the family housekeeper when Wei was a boy. She frequently disagreed with the cook, Sun, but enjoyed Sun's care after she fell ill. Wei believes her ghost haunts the villa still.

Suyin's Stepfather – Suyin's stepfather came into her life a few years after her biological father abandoned the family. He raped Suyin, and he is Meizhen's father.

Clerk Hu – Clerk Hu is a Communist Party official who works in Luoyang. He locates Sheng for Wei.

Meizhen (The Baby) – Meizhen is the infant daughter of Suyin and her stepfather.

TERMS

Autumn Moon Festival – The Autumn Moon Festival, celebrated in China, Japan, and other countries throughout East and Southeast Asia, marks the first full moon after the autumnal equinox. It is the second-most important Chinese holiday, after the New Year. Its celebration emphasizes themes of gathering and thanksgiving, and its practices include moon worship (which is related to the story of **Chang'e** and **Huoyi**), lighting lanterns, feasting, and enjoying mooncakes. It has long been a favorite time to celebrate marriages and family bonds.

Chinese Communist Party – The Chinese Communist Party, founded in 1921, seized control of the government at the end of a civil war in 1949. Led by Chairman Mao Zedong until his death in 1977, the Chinese Communist Party expressed an ideology of open, violent revolt against ruling classes; a constant state of struggle against traditional cultural values; and a focus on an agrarian, rather than industrial, society. It ruled with an iron hand, imposing many ill-conceived and sometimes dangerous policies on the country and silencing dissenters with punishments that ranged from public shaming to forced labor to death.

Hundred Flowers Campaign – In early 1957, the Chinese Communist Party announced a new initiative with a poem that said, "Let a hundred flowers bloom; let a hundred schools of thought content." It was an appeal to the Chinese people to voice their criticisms, concerns, and ideas about the Party and

its direction openly, something that they had not been allowed to do in the eight years since the Party came to power. Historians still debate whether the campaign was a ploy to draw out and persecute dissenters, or if it originated in a real desire for input from the people. In either case, once it became clear how much public opinion had turned against the Communist Party, the campaign was cancelled and many of those who spoke up were punished.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



REDEMPTION

When *A Hundred Flowers* begins, elderly Wei is grateful for the relationships he has with his son, Sheng, his daughter-in-law, Kai Ying, his grandson,

Tao, and his friend Song. But he takes them for granted and does little to care for those around him. Instead, he loses himself in his own world of history and academic research. When Sheng selflessly takes the blame for his father's criticism of the Communist Party, Wei's world collapses. Far too late, he sees how little responsibility he has shown towards those he claims to love. To redeem himself, he decides to travel north to Luoyang to check on Sheng. On the way, he befriends Tian, a man whose own painful past haunts him. At first, neither man can escape their personal ghosts. But they find solace in sharing their stories and in their deepening friendship. Tian helps Wei navigate his journey to Sheng, while Wei offers the younger man the wisdom and experience of his years. Each man leaves Luoyang having accepted responsibility for their rash actions and having found hope for the future through purposeful action and their friendship.

Suyin and Song find redemption through relationships, too. Married to an abusive old man as a teenager, Song never had a stable family of her own. But after Old Hing died, she moved to the villa and became an honorary member of the Lee family. She atones for her own past by caring for them and in return finds the love she never had when she was young. Suyin also finds a home and a future for herself and her daughter, Meizhen, when Kai Ying takes her in and helps her recover from the horrific abuse she suffered at the hands of her stepfather. Crucially, Suyin's healing happens not just when she receives love and support from Kai Ying, but as she starts to love and support family members like her daughter and Tao. Redemption may be an individual experience, but the novel suggests it can only come when a person takes responsibility for the way their own actions affect those around them.



JOURNEYS AND GROWTH

For generations, the Lee family has lived in the same villa. When he was a boy, elderly Wei explored the city of Guangzhou with his nanny, but for the past decade—since he retired from his University position to avoid the attention of the Communist Party—he has barely left its walls. When his son, Sheng, is arrested and sent to a labor camp in Luoyang, 1,000 miles to the north, the family struggles to comprehend the distance. But the book suggests that while being rooted in one place can certainly provide stability, it can also cause a person to stagnate. Only by leaving home and striking off on one's own, *A Hundred Flowers* suggests, can a person mature and discover who they truly are. This journey need not be long—Song and Suyin, for instance, each make a relatively short journey from their girlhood homes in Old Guangzhou to the Dongshan neighborhood. But growth requires movement.

Kai Ying demonstrated this when she came to Guangzhou as a teenager from her own village outside of Zhaoqing. Away from home, she learned to care for herself and to navigate the world independently, skills she leans on in the present to keep her family afloat. Tian's trip between Guangzhou and Luoyang helps him to put his past grief to rest. And, of course, Wei's lifechanging trip north helps him to become a version of loving, supportive father he wishes he had been when Sheng was young. In the process, he learns that many of the things he once valued mean little to him now. And, crucially, he learns to live his life in a better, more selfless way than before. When he walks through the villa's gates at the end, changed for the better, he offers the hope that growth is available to all who will risk striking out on their own.



SUFFERING, STRENGTH, AND RESILIENCE

Suffering touches the lives of everyone in *A Hundred Flowers*, yet ultimately no one succumbs to despair. Instead, the novel suggests that suffering has the ability to reveal a person's strengths and to teach them wisdom. For instance, when Tao falls from the **kapok tree**, he imagines himself flying instead of falling. He wishes he could fly away from the realities of his life and return to the time before his father, Sheng's, arrest. But, of course, Tao cannot fly. He falls, and he must learn to deal with what life hands him.

Tao's experience does not suggest that people are entirely helpless in bad circumstances: Song and Suyin both take matters into their own hands to escape physical and sexual abuse, and both are rewarded for their efforts by finding security and peace within the walls of the villa. But, the book suggests, there are limits to what a person can do. No one can rewrite the past or fix all the mistakes they made. But everyone, from little Tao to elderly Wei, can learn from these experiences

and turn their discovered wisdom into action and hope for the future. As Tao learns to stand on his own two feet again, both literally and figuratively, and as Wei learns to take ownership of his actions and choices, their actions gradually bring the family back into alignment. And they model resilience, the combination of strength and flexibility needed to face whatever life throws at a person. Through this process, they find grace, the ability to forgive themselves and others, and the strength to go on despite pain and suffering.



HOME AND FAMILY

As *A Hundred Flowers* explores the changing shape of the Lee family, it describes the power of a family to provide love, healing, forgiveness, and sanctuary

in the midst of a chaotic and sometimes painful world. Importantly, the book highlights that a family is not limited to blood relations but can be found in any relationship that involves mutual care and loyalty. Wei and Song grew up before the Communist Party takeover, and their experiences reflect a world (and family structures) that no longer exists by the 1950s: Wei's father practiced polygamy and Song's parents sold the right to her hand in marriage to the abusive Old Hing. The book—and the Communist Party, which abolished these practices—illustrate that these circumstances do not necessarily make strong families.

Instead, *A Hundred Flowers* argues for the power of mutual affection to bind people together as family, even among those not related by blood or marriage. Song and Suyin both benefit individually from being adopted into the Lee family, but their inclusion enriches the whole family in turn. Song nurtures the garden that nourishes them all and mothers Kai Ying and Tao, even though she never had children of her own. Suyin—who runs away from her family when her pregnancy, the result of being raped by her stepfather, begins to show—becomes like a big sister to Tao, helping him to weather a turbulent and painful period of his life without judgment. Thus, the book suggests, when mutual affection becomes the standard for familial relationships, the idea of family expands in ways that create more resilient and powerful networks.



THE PROMISES AND FAILURES OF COMMUNISM

A Hundred Flowers is set in 1958, nearly a decade after the Communist Party seized control of the

Chinese government. Kai Ying recalls the Party's claims that it wanted to set the people free from the abuses of the past, including a punishing landlord system that disenfranchised many poor Chinese people. But the novel shows that by 1958, the Party has failed to deliver on many of its promises. Vital supplies like food and fuel are running short. And when the Party encouraged people to offer suggestions, and then

arrested those who complained about its policies during the Hundred Flowers Campaign, it showed itself to be just as oppressive as the previous regime. Its demands for absolute loyalty drive wedges in relationships, as Tian's history with Ai-li shows. Perhaps most importantly, while the Party can and does declare an end to polygamy or bride-selling, it cannot stop individual acts of abuse. Suyin's trauma in the present shares many similarities with elderly Song's abusive marriage to Old Hing, even though the Communists have been in power for most of Suyin's life.

Ironically, although they dislike and oppose the Communist Party (quietly, for the most part), the Lee family embodies the best of its idealism. They generously welcome Song and Suyin into their home and family, even though the women come from lower, working-class backgrounds. Wei and Sheng love China fervently, respecting their country's long history and deep culture. They do not hoard wealth or live decadent lifestyles. But they long for the freedom to think for themselves and follow their consciences. In this way, the book suggests that not all of the Communist Revolution's ideals were misplaced, while nevertheless criticizing its brutal, repressive nature.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



KAPOK TREE

The kapok tree which stands in the courtyard of the Lee family villa represents strength and resilience.

Wei tells Tao that it's over a hundred years old, meaning that it has weathered many difficult times before and implying that it will do so again. Even after Wei attacks the tree with a meat cleaver, it thrives, providing a reminder of nature's strength and serenity to the family members. Sheng, for instance, draws strength from remembering the tree in his faraway labor camp. It also provides for the family, giving its flowers and leaves as ingredients for Kai Ying's herbal medicines. Ironically, although a fall from this tree caused Tao's injuries, medicine from its leaves helps him to heal, offering a reminder that trial and difficulty can help a person to become stronger and more resilient.



PEARL

The pearls that Kai Ying loves stand for beauty, fragility, and hope. Herbalist Chu stocked them in his shop and used them to create precious, expensive skin creams in part because of their natural, beautiful luster. When she struggled with homesickness in a strange city, Kai Ying took one pearl from his stock each week, stashing them away to

count the time until her apprenticeship ended. They represented her hope for a happier future, even as that hope shifted from returning home to staying in Guangzhou and marrying Sheng. But in their fragility, the pearls also offer a reminder that both bad and good things happen in life, such as Kai Ying's traumatic miscarriage, Sheng's arrest, or Tao's injury. These events threaten to destroy Kai Ying's hope, but the arrival of Suyin and her daughter rekindle it. It's for this reason that Kai Ying names Suyin's daughter Meizhen, or "beautiful pearl"—the baby girl herself represents the entire family's hope for a happier, brighter future.



WHITE CLOUD MOUNTAIN

Because his father's stories about it are one of the most important memories Tao clings to after Sheng's arrest, White Cloud Mountain represents Tao's wish for the past to return, and his desire for things to return to normal. But White Cloud Mountain has always been barely visible at best—something Tao could glimpse on a clear day from a second-story vantage point. Tao's fall from the **kapok tree** while trying to see the mountain dramatically indicates that it isn't just impossible to return to the past, but that it's dangerous to try to do so.

A Hundred Flowers suggests that looking too much toward the past, as Tao and Wei tend to do at the beginning of the book, blinds a person to the present moment, in which life must be lived. Only by living through present trials and difficulties can a person thrive and find happiness in the joys of family and community at home.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the St. Martin's Griffin edition of *A Hundred Flowers* published in 2013.

The Kapok Tree, July 1958: Kai Ying (I) Quotes

☞ Kai Ying would never forget the sight of her pale little boy lying on the courtyard pavement, his leg twisted beneath him. A broken branch, she thought, a crushed leaf. He wasn't moving. At that moment, she realized he might never move again and a feeling of terror overwhelmed her, stopping her abruptly and rooting her in place. [...] She stood there while her heart raced so fast her whole body shook. *He can't be*, she thought, *he can't*. And try as she might, Kai Ying couldn't think of one tea or soup that could bring the dead back to life. Her father-in-law, who was usually calm and in control, turned back to her, his eyes wide and frantic, his hands waving wildly in the air as he yelled for her to get help from Neighbor Lau, who had the only flatbed pedicab in the neighborhood.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 11

Explanation and Analysis

Tao Lee, bereft after the Chinese Communist Party arrests and sends his father away to a labor camp for dissent, climbs the kapok tree in the family courtyard in an attempt to look for Sheng on distant White Cloud Mountain. But he falls from the tree, breaking his leg. He cannot erase the painful fact of his father's arrest any more than his mother Kai Ying will be able to erase the memory of seeing his mangled body on the courtyard tiles. Nor, as she realizes in her panic, can either her motherly love or her skills as an herbal healer overcome death. No one escapes suffering, the book thus suggests, and running from it rather than facing it tends to make things worse. Only by living through trials and learning from them can a person find peace and growth.

Importantly, Kai Ying captures the idea of rootedness and stagnation in her body in this moment. The idea that Tao might be dead freezes her in place and makes her unable to process the scene unfolding before her. But Tao will only be helped with purposeful movement, like Wei's as he tries to get help carrying the boy to the hospital. Similarly, only by facing the consequences of the Sheng's arrest and Tao's injury will the family or anyone in it find resolution and peace.

☛ It didn't take long for Kai Ying to realize that they were both prisoners of the past, though each pursued his desires and preoccupations differently. While Wei's sole interest was in preserving China's past through its art, Sheng believed that if the Chinese were going to forge a stronger nation with a vibrant future, they would have to move past their history and learn from their mistakes.

Sheng never shied away from [...] politics and [...] problems. [...] Kai Ying had often heard Wei counsel her headstrong husband, "You should always look for the quiet within the storm, and then you'll find the answers to your questions." Afterward, she watched Sheng turn away from his father with an almost imperceptible shake of his head. She knew what he was really thinking. *No, no, you'll only find the answers to your questions by walking straight into the storm.*

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 16-17

Explanation and Analysis

As Kai Ying and Wei wait at the hospital for news of Tao, she considers the different temperaments of her husband and father-in-law. Superficially, Sheng and Wei are quite different in their approaches to life, with Sheng taking challenges head on and Wei avoiding them. But current circumstances suggest that each man could learn from the other's approach to life. With the Party on the lookout for dissent, caution and circumspection seem appropriate. But Wei's tortured sense of guilt over his failure to take care of the family members who love him suggests that inaction can be harmful, too. Kai Ying, who marries into the family, sees the similarities between the two men better than they do themselves. But their relationship cannot be healed until they see their similarities themselves.

Just like neither Wei's nor Sheng's approach to life is perfect, neither Wei's nor the Communist Party's approach toward history ends up being quite right. Wei idolizes the past and wishes to preserve it intact; the Communist Party wishes to reject it. Both approaches, the novel suggests, are too extreme: Wei's fails to address the inequalities and injustices of the old ways, but the Communist Party's tries to squelch not just these injustices but everything. And in the process, it risks destroying beautiful and powerful ideas and works of art. Like Wei and Sheng, the past and the future must find balance to bring glory back to China.

The Kapok Tree, July 1958: Wei Quotes

☛ [H]is grandson was alone somewhere in the hospital and there was nothing he could do but wait. Wei wondered if it was some kind of retribution for his years of self-absorption. He had always been too involved in his own work, never taking into consideration how it might affect those around him. Rather than going into business as his father had wished [...] he concentrated on his art history studies, preoccupied with teaching and research. He was thirty when he finally married Liang, and [...] Sheng came along unexpectedly almost ten years later. Through it all, Wei continued to work long hours [...] He told himself that his work was a part of all their legacies, but was it? By the time he paused long enough, Wei had missed so much of Sheng's childhood that he had little memory of what his son was like as a boy.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee, Liang Lee

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 23

Explanation and Analysis

As Kai Ying and Wei wait for the doctors to tell them anything about Tao's injuries or his likelihood of recovery, Wei falls into reflection. In this passage, he thinks about how much he values his family, but how he has failed to show his love and respect with his actions. Even though he was the only son, he chose not to carry on his father's legacy as a businessman, and he didn't make any attempts to carry on the family name with a child of his own until after his father's death.

The regret Wei feels for the ways in which he failed his father, his wife, and his son sets up his redemptive arc. In the past, he excused his selfishness and self-absorption with the idea that everyone—not just his family but the whole country—benefitted from the shared cultural heritage he sought to uncover. But he's beginning to suspect that this heritage doesn't have much value at all compared to relationships. Now that he recognizes his selfishness and pride, now that he can see how they affected those around him, Wei has a chance to make better choices going forward and to redeem himself by learning to value what truly matters: the relationships he shares with the people around him.

The Falling Boy, August 1958: Tao (II) Quotes

☞ What Tao would never tell anyone, including his father, was what he really felt the day he fell from the kapok, how for just a moment he was flying instead of falling, and how happy it made him feel. Even now, he envisioned soaring through the gates and beyond the Ming garden wall, high above the narrow, crowded alleyways where he used to run and over the wide, tree-lined streets that led to far-off places he'd never seen. Tao felt so certain that if he had just kept on flying, he'd have reached White Cloud Mountain.

Related Characters: Tao Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 47-48

Explanation and Analysis

When Tao climbs the kapok tree in hopes of seeing his father standing on the peaks of distant White Cloud Mountain, he wants desperately to regain the sense of normalcy and wholeness his family lost with his father's arrest and exile. He believes that if he can just figure out the right action—climbing the tree, flying to the mountain—he can magically return things to the way they used to be. But of course, neither Tao nor anyone else can change the past. His fall proves that he, like everyone else, remains subject to the laws of time and gravity. Thus, his only hope of peace lies in facing pain and suffering and developing wisdom and strength through surviving.

Importantly, despite the failure to fly, Tao already understands an important truth: growth requires movement. He intuitively sees that bringing Sheng home requires someone going somewhere, even though it's not his journey to make. Later in the book, Wei will finally see this truth and will make the journey north. But, in smaller ways, Tao will discover the power of movement to unlock growth himself as he recovers from his broken leg. On trips to and from school and on an ill-advised quest across the park, he will gain important insights about himself and the world around him.

The Falling Boy, August 1958: Wei Quotes

☞ Now he sat down at his desk and flipped through the worn pages, the book opening naturally to the poems where the spine was broken. He read the first stanza of a poem aptly titled "Thinking of My Boy," written for the poet's favorite son.

*Comes spring once more,
Pony Boy, and still we
Cannot be together; I
Comfort myself hoping
You are singing with
The birds in the sunshine...*

Wei stopped reading, suddenly angered. He knew Sheng wasn't where he could be singing with birds in the sunshine [...] Two months [after his arrest] they received word that Sheng had been sent to be reeducated in Luoyang in the western Henan province [...] more than a thousand miles away by train, another world away.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Sheng Lee, Liang Lee

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 66

Explanation and Analysis

Nearly every day since Sheng's arrest, Wei reads a poem from a book that Sheng gave him as a gift many years earlier. On this day, the poem makes him angry, because it reminds him of the Communist Party's disdain for Chinese civilization and culture, their carefully calibrated cruelty, and his own feelings of guilt. The poet, Tu Fu, lived in the middle of the Tang Dynasty. This period was a high point of Chinese culture thanks to a flourishing of literature and visual arts, scientific and technological advances, and extensive trade with Europe and the Middle East. In many ways, this period represents the opposite of China under the brutal and repressive rule of the Communist Party, which condemns literature, art, free thought, and international trade as symptoms of elite decadence. Those who disagree with their ideology face family separation and brutal punishment in labor camps that aim to "reeducate" dissenters by breaking their spirits.

Wei preferred the glorious past to the present, even before the Communist Party takeover. When he was younger, his studies absorbed him to the point that he often missed opportunities to spend time and build relationships with his wife, Liang, and his son, Sheng. Thus, some of the anger he feels points back toward himself as he realizes his choice to live in the past meant that he never was present enough to enjoy his relationships with his family. In contrast to Tu Fu,

who seems incapable of controlling his separation from his son, Wei realizes all too keenly how his own actions pulled him and Sheng apart.

☞ The lines were burned into his memory. *If China is to become a stronger nation, the Party must open its eyes and see that power comes from free expression. What freedom we do have in a Communist society if artists and intellectuals are tortured for following their hearts? What freedom do we have if art and ideas and politics can't be appreciated and openly discussed? How can there be strength in suppression?*

Wei had written his thoughts with such truth and clarity, as if a light had suddenly flooded a long-darkened room. Now these very same ideas had turned to needles pricking his skin, and the truth he'd written had condemned his son to hard labor. After a lifetime of keeping to himself and remaining closemouthed, what made him write the letter and sign his name? A moment of vanity and conceit, a need to feel important again [...]

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 67-68

Explanation and Analysis

Not long after Tao comes home from the hospital, Wei stands in his room, tortured by feelings of guilt as he rereads the letter that *he*—not Sheng—wrote and sent to the government during the Hundred Flowers Campaign. In it, Wei criticized party policies and appealed to alleged Party ideals, which emphasized the freedom and flourishing of the Chinese people. Yet, Sheng receives a punishment more in line with the angry dissent on display at rallies against the “Privileged Party.” The fact that the Party interprets even Wei’s calm letter as dangerous enough to warrant arrest and hard labor shows how they have traded idealism for absolute power over their citizens.

In rereading the letter, Wei charges himself with arrogance and vanity. This suggests the regret he feels over his actions—writing the letter, of course, but also missing out on developing his relationship with Sheng when he had the chance. This realization will finally push him into growth and change. Wei’s attempt to atone for his mistakes becomes the central story of the book. But it also shows how effective the Communist Party’s thought policing and repression could be. Wei experiences no direct punishment for his letter, yet perfectly learns the lesson that speaking up against the Party is bad and wrong.

Moon Festival, September 1958: Tao (II) Quotes

☞ The beginning of the story always remained the same: Huoyi was commanded by the Emperor Yao to use his archery skills to shoot down nine of the ten suns to keep the earth from burning up. Upon completing the task, the emperor gave the famed archer a pill that granted him eternal life. Knowing its value, Huoyi left the pill at home with Chang’e when he was sent away on another mission for the emperor. From there, their story of why Chang’e swallowed the pill of immortality splintered off into different versions. So far, Tao’s favorite account was Chang’e having to protect the pill from Peng, one of Huoyi’s apprentice archers, who forcefully tried to take the pill from her. Knowing that she was unable to fight him off, her only choice was to swallow the pill herself.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee, Suyin, Auntie Song, Chang’e, Huoyi, Suyin’s Stepfather

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 85

Explanation and Analysis

The Autumn Moon Festival celebrates the myth of Huoyi and Chang’e, which Wei tells Tao every year. In this passage, Tao recalls his favorite version of the story. The fact that the beginning of the tale never changes offers a reminder that the past cannot be changed—Chang’e cannot unswallow the pill any more than Wei can call back the letter he wrote, or Tao can reverse his fall from the kapok tree. But the existence of different versions also reminds Tao that the future remains unwritten. The mistakes and traumas of the past can be redeemed in the present and future if people have the courage and strength to face up to their challenges.

Chang’e’s story emphasizes the idea that no one can escape from suffering, no matter how hard they try. She swallows the pill and must accept the consequences with grace rather than resistance, finding hope in the small mercies allowed to her, like her annual reunion with Huoyi. In the Lee family, Chang’e’s story mirrors Kai Ying’s, since she has no choice but to support the family while waiting to be reunited with her own husband. And it mirrors Tao’s story, since he cannot escape the consequences of his fall but must patiently wait and exercise until he’s recovered. Additionally, it mirrors Suyin’s and Song’s lives, too: neither woman will ever be free of the scars from the abuse they suffered in their families. But Chang’e and Huoyi’s example promises that by living through pain and suffering, a person can survive and

become stronger.

Moon Festival, September 1958: Tao (III) Quotes

☞ “Do you want to hear the story of Huoyi and Chang’e now?” his grandfather asked.

Tao turned around and shook his head. “There’s no moon,” he answered.

“There’s still the story.”

“It’s not the same without the moon.”

His grandfather stroked his whiskers. “But we know the moon is still up there, beyond the rain and clouds.”

What good was the moon if you couldn’t see it? Tao thought. If it wasn’t there to help his *ba ba* to find his way home again? But, he nodded and limped back to the table and sat down, no longer caring which version of the myth his grandfather was going to tell him.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Tao Lee (speaker), Sheng Lee, Chang’e, Huoyi

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 102-103

Explanation and Analysis

On the evening of the Autumn Moon Festival, rain obscures the sky, driving home Tao’s painful realization that his life will not go back to the way it used to be. His father is still gone; his leg is not magically healed. According to myth, Huoyi and Chang’e only get to see each other once a year. In a childlike way, Tao seems to take this literally, even though he knows it is a myth; without the moon visible, he frets that their reunion will not take place. And, by extension, he worries that his father will never come home, that his leg will never heal, and that his life will never go back to normal.

However, the book makes it clear that of course Tao’s life will never go back to the way it was before, as this is impossible—just like his fantasy that he could fly to White Cloud Mountain instead of falling from the kapok tree. But in rejecting the story, Tao misses key lessons it offers. First, the myth speaks of how circumstances constrain all people and how everyone must live with the consequences of their actions—and other’s actions, too. In Tao’s life, the family must all face the consequences of Wei’s critical letter, Sheng’s imprisonment, or even his own fall. But the myth also focuses on the moon, which waxes and wanes each

month. This suggests symbolically that life changes constantly. By embracing change and movement, people find strength, solace, and growth. And so in Tao’s case here, it suggests that just because Sheng’s path home is obscured tonight, this doesn’t mean that it will always be.

Moon Festival, September 1958: Song Quotes

☞ This young woman had eased her pain, made her feel human again. Then, for the first time, Song told a perfect stranger about her husband, Old Hing, calling him a violent monster, an angry pig, a festering tumor. Once Song began to talk, she couldn’t stop, even with the pain.

Related Characters: Kai Ying Lee, Suyin, Auntie Song, Herbalist Chu, Old Hing

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 110

Explanation and Analysis

As Song visits the kitchen, hoping to soothe Kai Ying’s suffering, she remembers when they first met years ago. Kai Ying was still an apprentice in Herbalist Chu’s shop on the day that Song came in, intent on committing suicide. But Kai Ying’s kindness reminded Song of her own humanity and gave her enough hope to endure her terrible circumstances until she could escape them. And, because the two women have known each other for so long, their history gives Song the chance to reflect on the power of a chosen family. Song’s parents married her off to Old Hing—an abusive man more than twice her age—when she was just 16 years old and still needed their love and protection. Neither her blood relatives nor her husband recognized or respected Song’s humanity.

But Kai Ying, a perfect stranger, did. Kai Ying’s kindness suggests that it isn’t hard to treat people well, thus criticizing Song’s actual family even more sharply for failing to do so. But their bonds of mutual affection provide mutual support, strength, and resilience. Kai Ying seems to have a particular gift for forging a supportive, generative chosen family. Her history with Song foreshadows the way she will soon take Suyin under her wing.

Moon Festival, September 1958: Wei (II) Quotes

☞ Wei felt suddenly vigorous and confident again as he hurried off to fetch Mrs. Lu. As he fought against the wind and rain, slowly making his way down the street, the line had returned to him again, *Even so, the world intrudes*. It must have been a line from some famous Tang dynasty poem he had long ago memorized. It bothered him even more that he couldn't remember the lines that followed. When Wei returned home, he would scour his books of poetry until he found the poem. He'd spent most of his life avoiding the world, but ironically, it had landed right there at their doorstep.

By the time he returned with Mrs. Lu, the baby had already come into the world.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Sheng Lee, Liang Lee, Suyin

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 115

Explanation and Analysis

When Suyin appears in the Lee family villa in the throes of labor, everyone springs into action to help her. Kai Ying sends Wei to fetch Mrs. Lu, the midwife, to assist in the birth. For most of his life, Wei has rarely left the villa, and even then, he takes familiar paths to familiar places, like to Tao's school or toward his old office at Lingnan University. But although Wei's deep roots in the villa and his family have provided a sense of safety and security throughout his life, they also allow him to become stagnant and selfish. The time is coming for Wei to leave the villa, to face his fears and his mistakes. And, foreshadowing that impending journey, he realizes that even on this small (yet important) errand, leaving the villa gives him a fresh perspective. Even the line of poetry that he remembers here suggests that he cannot continue to stay at the villa and stagnate—the world will continue to “intrude,” or push him into situations where he must leave and do something rather than escaping into his books. Still, this passage also highlights that Wei is at the beginning of his journey, as most of his inner monologue is taken up by thinking about returning home and figuring out what this poem is rather than the task he's currently trying to accomplish.

Being sent for the midwife also makes him responsible for the wellbeing of another person, offering an important lesson about how he can atone for his past failures to honor and reciprocate the relationships that sustain him. Up to this point, he has received far more support and care than he has offered to others. For instance, he loved Liang and Sheng but paid less attention to them than his work. He

loves Tao but also desperately needs the boy's affection to let him know that he's doing a better job as a grandfather than he did as a father. And finally, he respects Kai Ying but also needs her to fulfil the role of family breadwinner in Sheng's absence. Only when he begins to behave responsibly towards those who love him will he redeem himself.

The World Intrudes, October 1958: Kai Ying Quotes

☞ Cheng paused for a moment and looked her up and down. “Your husband is a lucky man to have a wife so devoted to him. Of course, I too am a family man, and I hate to think of your son so upset. You must be very lonely with your husband gone; perhaps we can find a way to make this situation work, while helping each other at the same time?”

It took a moment for Kai Ying to understand what he was saying [...] She felt sick to her stomach and wanted nothing more than to run out of the hot, suffocating room. Instead, [she] steadied herself and ignored his question. She held out a red envelope, which contained a hundred yuan she had saved. She knew it was the way things were done, and hoped it would be enough for this vile man.

Related Characters: Comrade Cheng (speaker), Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee, Suyin, Auntie Song, Meizhen (The Baby)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 133

Explanation and Analysis

When Kai Ying goes to the public security bureau to see if she can find out any news about Sheng, she meets Comrade Cheng, a Communist Party official who clearly feels comfortable abusing his position and the power he holds over people to his own benefit. Kai Ying brings up Tao in a misguided attempt to appeal to the Comrade's sense of family responsibility, only to discover that he has none. Cheng's attitude contrasts sharply with the way the Lees love and protect each other and extend their family to include outsiders like Auntie Song, Suyin, and Meizhen.

This exchange also shows how the Communist Party has failed to establish a system of government that is any better or fairer than the one it replaced, despite its promises to free the people from tyranny. Not only does Cheng proposition Kai Ying for sex, but he accepts bribes from her—and, the book implies, anyone else who needs his help.

Using Party affiliation to gain power, wealth, and status over others suggests that the Communist Party has merely replaced the previous corrupt and despotic government with its own form of corruption and despotism without materially changing the lives of the common citizen for the better.

The World Intrudes, October 1958: Wei (II)

Quotes

☝ He glanced out to the courtyard and the kapok tree. When he turned back to Tao, he saw Sheng again at the same age, always so formal and closemouthed around him. He remembered all the times he heard Sheng talking to Liang, joking and laughing, but as soon as he entered the room, it was as if the air had changed. He and Sheng hadn't learned to be friends until late in his life. Now he only wanted his son home again.

"I know..." Wei began, realizing the words that followed would change all of their lives forever. "I know because it was *me*. I was the one to write the letter, not your *ba ba*."

Wei felt as if he'd been falling for the past year and had finally hit the ground. He stared down at the table and couldn't look at either Kai Ying or Tao.

Related Characters: Wei Lee (speaker), Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee, Lai Hing

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 143

Explanation and Analysis

When Tao comes home crying from school because one of his classmates, Lai Hing, has told everyone that Sheng was arrested for his counterrevolutionary views, Wei realizes that the time has come to confess that he wrote the critical letter that precipitated Sheng's arrest. While he gathers his courage, he realizes that his confession will leave a scar in the family like the scar he left in the kapok tree earlier. But avoiding responsibility hasn't kept him from suffering—instead it has left him adrift in a sea of his own guilt. Only by facing the facts and confessing can he learn his lessons and redeem his past mistakes.

Wei sees Sheng's face superimposed on Tao's as he thinks back to his son's childhood. The physical distance between Sheng and Wei in the present moment mirrors and reenacts

the emotional distance between the two of them when Sheng was child. Because Wei's scholarly pursuits consumed his time and energy, he ignored his wife and son and took them for granted. He didn't reciprocate the affection and attention he enjoyed from his family members, and as a result, he didn't have the same close relationship with Sheng that Liang did—or the intimate bond that Sheng shares with Tao. In both the deep past and the recent past, Wei's self-centered approach to life hurt people he loved. Only now does he realize how much it hurt him, too. This leads him to realize that he must take responsibility for himself and his choices, which he does here by confessing that he wrote the letter.

☝ Wei pulled at his tunic collar and felt the room spinning, but he didn't look away [... Kai Ying's] dark eyes were unrecognizable, filled with something worse than anger: disappointment. [...]

Outside came the singsong voice of the fruit peddler calling out "Bananas! Oranges! Mangoes!" [...] He wanted to run out and buy all the fruit in the peddler's basket as an offering, although he knew the sweetest fruits in all of Guangzhou couldn't buy him forgiveness.

[...] Tao had stayed seated at the table. His grandson was no longer crying, but watching him with the distant gaze of a stranger. Wei hoped the boy would understand that he never meant for any of this to happen. But before he could say anything, Tao scraped back his chair and stood up.

"Tao, I'm sorry," Wei said.

[...]

"I hate you," Tao said, "I hate you."

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Tao Lee (speaker), Kai Ying Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 144-145

Explanation and Analysis

In the anguished moments after Wei's confession, both Kai Ying and Tao struggle to accept the revelation. His confession has alienated his family in exactly the way he expected, showing why he kept quiet in the first place. But this moment also highlights how much more harm he caused by keeping everyone in the dark for so long. Sheng has borne not just the legal punishment for Wei's act, but also some of the emotional consequences, even if he doesn't

know it: both Kai Ying and Tao have, up to this point, blamed him for abandoning them. Wei's selfish cowardice didn't just risk his own relationship with Sheng but Sheng's relationship with his wife and child, too. In fact, Wei has come dangerously close to turning his son into the exact same kind of absentee parent Wei himself was in Sheng's childhood.

Of course, Wei wishes to redeem himself—both for the act of writing the letter and for his earlier and perhaps more consequential emotional abandonment of his family. The fact that he madly, desperately considers buying the fruit vendor's wares shows how far he has drifted from the reciprocal bonds and obligations that make up the family's relationships. He can only repair the harm by taking responsibility for his choices, by actions that demonstrate his respect and love for the people around him. But, unaccustomed to doing this at any point in his life, he cannot yet imagine what these actions may be.

After, October 1958: Kai Ying Quotes

☝☝ Kai Ying saw it all so clearly now, the guilt that had to be consuming Wei each day as he retreated more and more into himself. As difficult as it was, Kai Ying understood why Sheng had taken her father-in-law's place when the police came; Wei would have never been able to survive outside of the villa, much less at a reeducation facility. But why hadn't Wei told her the truth? Why did he allow her to suffer for over a year, not knowing if there really was a letter, letting her believe that Sheng was the one to jeopardize everything they had? And how was she ever going to forgive a man who would let his pride betray his family?

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 149-150

Explanation and Analysis

Hours after Wei confesses his responsibility for writing the letter criticizing the Chinese Communist Party, Kai Ying stands in the kitchen, her mind racing as her hands quietly prepare the family's supper. As she considers the implications of the letter, her thoughts reveals how Wei's failure to take responsibility impacted Sheng's relationships, not just Wei's. By letting Kai Ying and Tao believe for months that Sheng did, in fact, write the letter—that he irresponsibly risked his own safety and the integrity of his family—Wei potentially undermined Sheng's relationships

with his wife and child.

But Sheng's actions also show the way that the family can heal. A family becomes strong, the novel suggests, when its members take responsibility for their actions and support one another. Sheng did this when he took on the punishment for Wei, a decision that Kai Ying understands. Wei didn't necessarily abuse his relationship with Sheng by allowing him to do that, but he did show a stunning lack of respect for his son's sacrifice—and Kai Ying's and Tao's losses—when he then refused to tell the truth about why Sheng was imprisoned. By letting Kai Ying assume that Sheng wrote the letter, Wei has made his own life easier while causing others pain. Now that everyone knows, Wei can take steps to make things right by continuing to show that he can be responsible and care for his loved ones.

After, October 1958: Song (I) Quotes

☝☝ "I've been such a fool," he said, his voice barely a whisper.

"My father used to say that the only fool is the man who can't admit he's one," Song said. "Can't you see Sheng knew what he was doing? It was his choice."

"And my weakness," Wei said. "I stood by and allowed him to be taken away in my place."

"He knew what he was doing," she repeated.

"I should never have put him in that position!"

"You know nothing about your own son [...] and that should be your biggest regret. You've lived in the past for so long you can't see what's right in front of you. You make a mistake, an unintentional mistake. Who in this life hasn't crossed that bridge? [...] Sheng would never have allowed them to take you. He's young and strong, he'll survive."

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Auntie Song (speaker), Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 152-153

Explanation and Analysis

Soon after Wei confesses to Kai Ying and Tao that he wrote the letter, Song finds out. She looks for Wei in the courtyard and, in this passage, attempts to ease his feelings of guilt by talking sense into him. As an honorary member of the family, Song knows Wei and Sheng very well, and this intimacy gives her insight into the characters and temperaments of both men. Due to Wei's lifelong reticence, Song likely knows more about him than his own son. And she certainly knows

more about Sheng than Wei does. This allows her to do what she does here and explain to Wei his own shortcomings and Sheng's strengths—she has this insight thanks to knowing both men better than they know each other.

Crucially, this passage delves into the complex and linked layers of the guilt and regret Wei feels. Of course, he feels remorse for writing the letter and for allowing Sheng to take responsibility. But he also feels regret for his decades of isolation and inaction—a regret which elsewhere he understands as part of what motivated him to write the letter in the first place. And underneath it all, he feels ashamed of how he allowed his isolation to extend to his family relationships. He worries he cannot make up for his errors with Sheng gone. But in his focus on his own guilty feelings, Wei fails to see the love and respect Sheng showed him when he chose to protect his father. Only when Wei learns to look toward the present rather than the past will he understand—and begin to honor—the relationship he does have with Sheng.

After, October 1958: Wei (I) Quotes

☞ Wei avoided the crowded main boulevards, instead turning onto the smaller side streets as he walked in and out of the narrow alleyways. He found himself following the same route he had walked for over forty years of teaching and Lingnan University. Old habits were a way of life for him. He knew the maze of intimate streets by heart and couldn't bear the large crowds and bicyclists that used to push him along in directions he didn't want to go. Wei was never comfortable being around too many people outside of the classroom, and over the years, he'd found ways to avoid them and move along at his own pace while remaining as inconspicuous as possible.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 158

Explanation and Analysis

Driven from the villa by his overwhelming feelings of guilt and regret, Wei spends days wandering the streets of Guangzhou, considering his life, and trying to find insight. This passage describes a typical route, one that illustrates Wei's tendency to stick to the comfortable, the quiet, and the familiar. It's this aspect of Wei's character that will cause his family the most worry when he leaves on his quest to find Sheng, since he has never demonstrated the strength,

flexibility, and resilience necessary to face the chaos and constant change of the world beyond his small corner of Guangzhou.

But walking does begin to give Wei insight, in keeping with the book's argument that growth requires motion. He sees clearly how his desire to stay safe and comfortable, to be quiet and inconspicuous, failed to protect him in the end. No matter how small he made himself, life still brought him not only joys but also trials. Until he learns to accept that life has both in store for everyone—and to accept the lessons his trials can teach him—he remains stuck trying to reach the past. His feet still trace the familiar walk to the University, where he hasn't worked in over a decade. Until he escapes the gravitational pull of the familiar, the comfortable, and the safe, his insights—and personal growth—won't be enough to bring him relief.

☞ When Wei came to the darkened walkway under a bridge, he stopped to watch a lone middle-aged woman practicing some sort of dance. Unlike everyone else, who was dressed in the drab gray or green tunics of the Party, she wore a bright red flowing outfit, lifting her leg high into the air and sharply snapping a red fan open in perfect unison [...] Still, Wei was intrigued with her precise movements, her total concentration; the effectiveness of the red fan as it opened and closed in unison [with her legs]. She paused once and glanced in his direction before she began the next set. Wei watched with admiration and wondered what it must feel like to be that agile, to move with such ease and grace through life, unafraid to perform a dance she loved, a remnant of bourgeois decadence.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 158-159

Explanation and Analysis

On one of Wei's walks around the city, he comes upon a woman dancing under a bridge. Her freedom of motion and bright clothing make her instantly noticeable. In contrast, Wei has tried to make himself inconspicuous, especially since the Communist Party took over and began to persecute scholars and academics. But hiding himself away didn't stop harm from coming to his country or his community. And ultimately, unable to remain silent, Wei wrote the letter arguing that freedom of speech and expression form the foundation of a flourishing society. The dancer's boldness contextualizes Wei's criticisms, since she

does what he said the Party should allow people to do. Not only do her actions not harm anyone, but she also brings beauty and vibrancy into a world that has become otherwise harsh, drab, and gray.

Although Wei claimed in the letter that China could never recapture its strength or vibrancy without the Party respecting free expression, he has not followed his own arguments to their logical conclusion. Instead of continuing to speak out against the Party's repression, he—like most others following the Hundred Flowers Campaign—has tamely allowed the government to silence him and others. In contrast, the woman in red openly defies the regime; although she dances under a bridge, Wei finds her with little effort, implying that she does not fear arrest—or at least, she values her physical freedom less than her right to express herself. Her example inspires Wei to look within for his own courage. And it reminds him that he made just and true arguments in the letter, even if the Party rejected them.

Stories, November 1958: Kai Ying (II) Quotes

☝☝ Wei told her Sun and Moon had worked for his family ever since they were young women. Before then, they'd been silk workers from the village of Shun-de. When Wei was a boy of nine or ten, Sun and Moon were already middle-aged, and had been working for his family for over twenty years. "They were as different as the sun and moon," her father-in-law said, and laughed. "There was hardly a time when they didn't disagree about something. They would have argued about the time of day if they'd had the time!"

When Wei was not yet fifteen, Moon fell ill. Sun devoted herself to taking care of her until she died, six months later. Afterward, Sun stayed on until she became too old, but she was never the same.

Related Characters: Wei Lee (speaker), Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee, Liang Lee, Auntie Song, Sun, Moon

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 190-191

Explanation and Analysis

One day not long after Wei leaves for Luoyang, Kai Ying thinks she hears footsteps on the second floor. She remembers Wei telling her that the ghosts of his family's old cook and housekeeper haunt the villa, and in this passage, she recalls the stories Wei told her about the two women, Sun and Moon. Despite their evident differences of personality and temperament, they depended on each

other. They thus provide another example of chosen family, since circumstance and affection dictated their bonds, not blood or law.

They also illustrate an important truth about the resilience of family bonds, which the novel suggests become stronger through strife, not weaker. Sun and Moon argued—a lot. But they nevertheless needed each other to survive. Their arguments in fact seem to have been a display of affection, since they frequently drew the women together. This story thus implicitly criticizes Wei's attempts to hide his failures and weaknesses from Liang, Song, Sheng, Kai Ying, and Tao. It suggests that he did so not because he believed them to be untrustworthy or incapable of loving him despite his flaws, but because of his own lack of courage and trust in himself. Realizing how little he has contributed to his relationships throughout much of his life, Wei cannot trust these relationships to sustain him—yet. But the story of Sun and Moon—as well as the degree to which Song, Kai Ying, and Tao show concern rather than anger in his absence—highlight how badly he has misjudged his family. Their reactions to his journey north suggest that they will always love him, no matter how much he messes up.

Stories, November 1958: Tao (II) Quotes

☝☝ For as long as he could remember, his *ma ma* had always been the one to teach him about what was right and wrong [...] Even when he was a very little boy, she reminded him it was important that he always be able to take care of himself. Tao had wondered why, when she and *ba ba* and *ye ye* were there to take care of him. "Because there will be a time when we aren't [...] Not now [...] "but a very, very long time from now."

[...] Tao wanted to tell her that he wasn't ready to take care of himself yet. Instead, he pressed his lips together and held the words in [...]—*I'm still a little boy and it hasn't been a very long time like you promised, so why are both ba ba and ye ye gone?*

Related Characters: Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee (speaker), Wei Lee, Sheng Lee, Suyin, Auntie Song, Meizhen (The Baby)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 215

Explanation and Analysis

As he waits for his mother to read him a bedtime story one evening while Wei is on his trip to Luoyang, Tao thinks about how much he still needs his family to take care of him. Everyone in his family plays a different part in supporting little Tao: his mother teaches him how to behave and how to

be responsible, while his father and grandfather tell him grand stories and myths from Chinese history and Auntie Song teaches him about gardening and the rhythms of the natural world. If his mother teaches him how to live, the others show him the beauty in the world that makes life worth living. But the past year has torn the family apart, forcing Tao to rely on his own resources more and more. He knows how to take care of himself in the way his mother has taught him, but while that helps him to survive, it doesn't allow him to thrive.

Earlier, Tao compared himself to Suyin and her baby, Meizhen, who both needed nearly full-time attention and care. Then, he was proud to think about how well he can take care of himself as a seven-year-old. But after weeks of trying to face difficulties alone—the pain of his still-recovering leg, the social changes that happened at school in his absence, the loneliness he feels since losing his father and then his grandfather—Tao realizes that he isn't ready to face the world outside the villa walls. He still needs the love and support of his family to mature and flourish.

for the companionship, although as he clearly indicates here, he prefers to spend time with Suyin to Auntie Song. As he thinks about why, it becomes clear just how much of a member of the family Suyin has become in the space of a few short weeks.

Suyin still bears the signs of the rough life she lived before she came to the villa and began living with the Lees; Tao can still see how thin and sallow she is. But her neat clothes and clearing skin promise that she will recover fully, given enough time and support from the family. And it's likely that she will have both; the fact that she wears Kai Ying's sweater shows the degree to which the older woman has already adopted Suyin as an honorary daughter. Likewise, Tao falls easily into a brother-sister relationship with Suyin, who treats him as an equal rather than a young child. Her age and maturity allow her to see that Tao needs help. But her natural kindness allows her to extend help to him naturally, in a way that acknowledges his own independence and autonomy. Tao is still a child, but the fracturing of his family and his leg have given him a new perspective that separates him from the other children in his class. Suyin sees and honors this growth.

Waiting, November 1958: Tao (III) Quotes

☝☝ He was secretly happy Suyin was waiting for him after school. She wasn't so sickly-looking anymore and her skin had cleared. Walking next to her, he realized she was almost as tall as his mother and thin all over. [...] She usually wore a dark cotton tunic and pants and he recognized one of his mother's sweaters that she was wearing.

Tao liked walking home with Suyin; it made him feel older. He liked the way she nodded at him without saying a word, without making a fuss the way Auntie Song did trying to help him with his books or forcing him to put on his jacket as the days grew cooler. Suyin kept things simple and to the point. If he didn't feel like talking to her, she never pushed.

"Ready to go?" she said.

Tao nodded that he was.

Related Characters: Suyin (speaker), Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Auntie Song

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 235

Explanation and Analysis

In Wei's absence, Auntie Song and Suyin share the responsibility of walking Tao to and from school. This passage comes just after Tao's ill-advised attempt to walk across the park by himself, and he feels particularly grateful

Waiting, November 1958: Suyin Quotes

☝☝ Dongshan appeared different now that she was actually living there, the villas behind the tall walls no longer a mystery. They were filled with families and problems just like in Old Guangzhou. But instead of the multitude of voices screaming all at once from the crowded apartments, there was a quiet seething just below the surface in Dongshan. Upon closer scrutiny, she saw the cracks in the stone walls, the big houses crumbling slowly behind them in need of repair or paint or new tiles. All Suyin's illusions of grandeur had suddenly disappeared. She would never be the same wide-eyed schoolgirl walking down the street for the very first time, and the thought brought both a sigh of relief and a moment of sorrow.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Suyin, Auntie Song, Suyin's Stepfather, Meizhen (The Baby)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 242-243

Explanation and Analysis

As Suyin becomes an ever more integral part of the Lee family, Kai Ying and Auntie Song send her on errands. Like everyone else in the family, Suyin finds solace in motion, and getting out of the villa and into the streets of the neighborhood leads her to insights about herself and the

world. First and foremost, now that she lives in this formerly affluent neighborhood rather than the cramped quarters of working-class Old Guangzhou, Suyin truly understands that wealth and status cannot protect a person from trouble or harm. The problems in Dongshan may be different than those she grew up with, but they exist, nevertheless. She learns this as she begins to see that the villas in the neighborhood aren't so grand anymore—they need repairs.

Then, as Suyin considers how much her life has changed since she left Old Guangzhou, she sees how her experiences have changed her. Suyin knows that she cannot go back to who she was before stepfather raped her and she became pregnant with Meizhen, that she cannot return to the family context in which she grew up. Her hope lies in the future. At the end of this walk, she will make an attempt to see her mother, which will confirm her realization that she cannot go back in time. Her stepfather's violence and lack of respect for the other members of the family, especially Suyin, have turned her family from a refuge into a potential trap. In contrast, although the Lee family has its own share of issues, its relationships grow from roots of respect and mutual concern. And thus, the safety and security it provides Suyin makes up for the loss of her family of origin.

Waiting, November 1958: Wei (III) Quotes

☝☝ But rather than remain antagonistic, Wei decided to change his tactics and thanked the clerk politely. "Yes, of course, I understand," he said, almost cordial.

"I see you're learning," Tian had said, leaning in close and teasing him.

It surprised Wei how easy it was to talk to Tian, who had been a stranger to him less than a week ago.

Wei cleared his throat and said, "Have you heard the saying, 'The wise adapt themselves to circumstances, as water molds itself to the pitcher'? It seems I've been the pitcher most of my life. I've forgotten how to be fluid. It feels as if I'm finally learning now," he said.

Tian smiled. "You remind me of my own father," he said, "although I'm afraid he never did learn."

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Tian (speaker), Sheng Lee, Clerk Hu

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 248

Explanation and Analysis

In Luoyang, Wei goes to the public security bureau and initiates a search for Sheng. At first, he resents the cold way in which Clerk Hu treats him, but he soon learns the wisdom of treating the man well. As Tian teases him, Wei gains insight into just how much the past days have changed him. First, he has his epiphany in Luoyang, over 1,000 miles away from the safe and narrow confines of the villa and university where he spent much of his life. Being stuck in his routines allowed him to focus on the past rather than face the present moment with all its sacrifices and difficulties. But his rigidity and avoidance added to his suffering rather than alleviating it.

Wei draws on an adage about water's ability to flexibly fill whatever vessel it finds itself in, but there's also a similarity here to the kapok tree. Although its deep roots and strong trunk give it strength to grow tall, it must also adapt to the changing seasons—budding in the spring, dropping its leaves in the fall. An inflexible tree, incapable of bending in the wind, would not stand long. And in leaving the villa and the protective shade of the tree, Wei finally gains the perspective to see that resilience requires both rootedness and flexibility.

Then, Wei reflects—yet again with wonder—on how easily he fell into his friendship with Tian. For a man accustomed to living within the confines of his family, the idea that he could trust anyone else seems revolutionary. This friendship points towards the power of chosen relationships to provide strength and support, even though they're not legal or blood ties. Tian has become like a son to Wei over the course of just a few days—and he has become a second and wiser father to Tian.

The City of Ghosts, November 1958: Tao Quotes

☝☝ Tao thought about it. Little Shan had betrayed him to be one of Lai Hing's stray dogs, and now he wanted to be friends again. Mao would have sent him away for less, just like he did his *ba ba*. He looked up and studied Little Shan's face, trying to understand what had happened during the past few months, how his entire life had been turned upside down ever since he he'd fallen from the kapok tree. Yet, here he was, standing upright. Little Shan hadn't totally abandoned him, having saved him from being pummeled by Lai Hing and his gang. *Best friends are hard to come by*, his grandfather had said. His ye ye was hard to come by. There would never be anyone else like his grandfather, and Tao wanted him back, but until then, Little Shan stood bundled up and waiting in front of him.

"Truce," Tao said.

Related Characters: Tao Lee (speaker), Wei Lee, Sheng Lee, Little Shan, Lai Hing

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 261-262

Explanation and Analysis

Unexpectedly, Little Shan approaches Tao one chilly November morning asking for a truce. Although Tao and Little Shan were best friends before Tao's fall from the kapok tree, when Tao returned to school, he discovered that Little Shan had not only taken over Tao's spot in the classroom as second student but also befriended the class bully, Lai Hing. After months of misery and confusion, these betrayals showed Tao once and for all the futility of trying to live in the past. Yet, much to his surprise, he finds himself standing on his own two feet once more, both literally and figuratively. Having survived the fall and having lived through its painful aftermath, he finds that he has grown and matured—by facing his pain, he has overcome it. When he declares a truce with Little Shan, he's also declaring a sort of peace with the world, a newfound willingness to wait until his grandfather—and ultimately his father—return.

This passage also reflects on the failures of the Chinese Communist Revolution. When Tao considers permanently banishing Little Shan from his life, he justifies this idea by pointing towards the Communist Party's tendency to punish people for perceived betrayals. Rather than freeing the people, it means they fear of reprisal for any action—any thought—that's out of line with official Party policy and ideology. As he reflects on the unnecessary and excessive cruelty of Sheng's arrest, however, Tao realizes that he wants to behave with more decency and respect.

The City of Ghosts, November 1958: Wei (IV) Quotes

☞☞ *Do you remember, he heard Liang's voice ask him, when Sheng was a little boy and he was determined to fly his dragon kite even when there was no wind? He nodded at the memory, at the calm, cool watery sound of Liang's voice, and how she had finally returned to him after so many weeks. Yes, he said. Wei could see her smile. Remember how he ran up and down the street trying to get enough wind until he finally gave up, she reminded him. And how you were the one who told him the wind would return again in no time, but he had to be patient. The wind will return again, Liang said. You've come this far, just listen to your own words.*

Wei wanted to reach out for Liang, but was afraid she would disappear if he did, and remained content to feel her there beside him again.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Liang Lee (speaker), Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 272-273

Explanation and Analysis

While sitting on the bus for his second trip to the prison where he hopes to see Sheng, Wei closes his eyes and successfully conjures up the image of his wife, Liang, for the first time since Tao's fall from the kapok tree. When she was alive, Wei depended on Liang for love and support; after her death, he realized how little he gave her in return. The recent silence of her ghostly memory impressed upon Wei how little he has given his family over the years, something that Liang's silence seems to punish him for. And it shows the extreme burden of guilt and shame he has carried for both this general failure and also the specific crimes of writing the critical letter and allowing Sheng to accept punishment for it. The fact Liang reappears now shows that Wei has already done a lot to make good on his past failures. If he can stay patient for just a little while longer, he will see Sheng and complete his journey to find redemption.

The story of Sheng and the kite also shows the importance of patience—the ability to calmly bear painful circumstances when they arise. Sheng runs himself ragged believing that he can make enough wind through his own efforts. But of course, he can't. Likewise, nothing that Wei or Kai Ying has done over the past months has fixed the rift made by Sheng's arrest. Wei tried to escape suffering through denial

and isolation; Kai Ying and Tao engaged in similar acts of denial in their attempts to hold onto the shreds of their old lives when the family was healthy and whole. But none has found peace, which only comes from accepting the circumstances and waiting patiently for difficult times to pass. If Wei can do that now, his vision suggests, then they will all find some peace.

The City of Ghosts, November 1958: Wei (V) Quotes

☞ “I should be the one in here, not you.”

Sheng shook his head.

[...] Wei continued, “[...] I’ve created a world of grief for all of us.” He swallowed.

“Ba ba, you don’t need to explain—”

Wei waved his hand to interrupt. “You’re here. I’ve seen you, touched you. At least I can bring that back to Kai Ying. But can you ever forgive me for writing the letter?” he asked. His fingers felt for the gouge in the table, following it to the edge.

“Forgive you? You don’t need to ask for forgiveness for writing the truth. I would have done the same, given time. I’m here for the both of us. We’re more alike than either of us knew.”

Wei saw the color return to Sheng’s face again as he spoke. *We’re more alike than either of us knew.* His words hung in the stale air [...]

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Sheng Lee (speaker), Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee

Related Themes:

Page Number: 280-281

Explanation and Analysis

After traveling over 1,000 miles to Luoyang and successfully navigating the Communist Party bureaucracy, Wei sees Sheng for the first time since Sheng was arrested. Sitting across a table from his son, confessions tumble from Wei’s mouth after years of harboring guilt and shame. The events of the past few months have shown Wei how his actions and choices affect others. He sees now how much he has relied on his family to insulate and protect him from consequences—with Sheng taking Wei’s punishment for writing the letter providing the ultimate example. Now, he wants forgiveness and to repair the relationships that mean so much to him.

Sheng refuses to forgive Wei for the letter because, as he says, no one should need forgiveness for speaking the truth.

But he also sees that Wei really needs forgiveness for his bigger mistakes, like the way he took his family for granted, or the way he neglected Sheng during his childhood, or the way his silence increased Kai Ying’s suffering. Coming to Luoyang to get news about Sheng began to right those wrongs. And Sheng’s acknowledgement of the similarities between himself and his father touches and begins to heal Wei’s deeper pain, because it shows that they do have a relationship, despite the years of Wei’s neglect. He still has the chance to forge a stronger bond and make up for the past. This points to the real act of forgiveness which will set Wei free from his guilt: he needs to forgive *himself* for his actions. And by proving that he can leave his safe cocoon and be the kind of person he wants to be for his family, he starts to heal and redeem himself.

The City of Ghosts, November 1958: Kai Ying (III) Quotes

☞ For the very first time since Tao had fallen from the kapok tree, she paused in front of it. It seemed as if an entire lifetime had passed in the five months since. [...] [Now] the tree stood skeletal, the branches remaining bare until [...] the spring. [...] Although Kai Ying knew it was foolish, she still dared to hope that they would all be together again by then.

Kai Ying stepped closer to the tree. At least let her hear from Wei again soon, she thought. The gash that her father-in-law had left in the trunk was a scar now, slightly deeper in color and hardly noticeable if you weren’t looking for it. Kai Ying’s fingers graced the smooth wound. She thought of it as just another example of nature’s genius; the kapok tree had healed itself. From the kitchen, she heard Tao’s and Suyin’s voices and smiled.

Related Characters: Wei Lee, Kai Ying Lee, Tao Lee, Sheng Lee, Suyin, Auntie Song

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 284-285

Explanation and Analysis

As the family waits anxiously for news of Wei and Sheng, Kai Ying finds herself drawn to the kapok tree in the courtyard. Although it symbolizes the family’s strength and resilience—it has stood in the courtyard for longer than any of the family’s current members have been alive—for Kai Ying, it also represents all the things she cannot control. Tao’s fall from the tree showed her that she couldn’t protect

him completely from pain and suffering. Wei's attack of the tree showed her that she couldn't pretend that the family hadn't been changed by Sheng's arrest. The tree's bare branches reflect Kai Ying's loneliness in this time when the family has been separated from both Sheng and Wei.

Still, as her fingers trace the scar where Wei's cleaver bit into the tree's trunk, she begins to understand that despite everything, the tree has healed. And as her thoughts turn hopefully towards spring and Sheng's eventual return, she

realizes that although this time will leave a mark in all their lives, it too will fade to become a faint scar. Likewise, the physical and emotional scars of Tao's broken leg, Song's abusive marriage, Suyin's rape, or Wei's selfish choices cannot be erased. But by living through these challenges openly and by showing one another love and forgiveness, rather than trying to avoid pain and suffering, each person and the family as a whole emerge stronger, wiser, and more resilient.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

THE KAPOK TREE, JULY 1958: TAO

Early one hot and humid summer morning, just a little shy of his seventh birthday, Tao decides to climb the **kapok tree** in his family's courtyard. He longs to see **White Cloud Mountain**—a distant peak that his father (Sheng) used to point out to him from the second-floor balcony of their house. Tao hasn't seen his father in a months, not since two policemen dragged him away in handcuffs while Tao's grandfather (Wei) and his mother (Kai Ying) protested. Neither his mother nor his grandfather would tell Tao where his father had gone or when he would be back.

Tao remembers that at first, Sheng's absence felt like a game of hide-and-seek. He looked everywhere, from the alleyways of their neighborhood to the busy city streets. He found his way to Mr. Lam's sweet shop, where Mr. Lam gave him a candy, promised his father would return, and brought him home. The candy tasted like grief. For almost a year, he has only seen his father in dreams. This morning, a dream gave him the idea to climb the **kapok tree** and look for his father on **White Cloud Mountain**.

Tao hears a door creak, but no one emerges from the red-brick villa where he lives with his family. It's too early for Kai Ying's patients—she's a well-known herbal healer—to start lining line up at the gate of the villa. Tao's great-grandfather built it many decades ago. After the Communist Party came to power in 1949, they subdivided the villas in the neighborhood. Tao's family now shares theirs with Auntie Song and Mr. and Mrs. Chang.

Wei reveres the **kapok tree**, with its brilliant red springtime blossoms and dark green, spear-shaped summer leaves. As Tao climbs upwards, he pauses to peer down into the courtyard below. Each villa in the neighborhood has a unique design based on a different era of Chinese garden architecture, but Tao thinks they mostly look identical. He imagines the scolding he will get if his Kai Ying or Wei catches him. He's almost to the top when he loses his footing and plummets to the courtyard 30 feet below. As he falls, he feels like he leaves his body, at least until he experiences the wrenching pain of impact and loses consciousness.

The kapok tree symbolizes strength and resilience; it's been the same through a hundred years and generations of the family. Tao climbs it because it connects him to his father's memory; it's as a child-like way to try to return to the happy past. White Cloud Mountain represents this unreachable past. But of course, Tao wishes for the impossible; the repression of the Chinese Communist Party (whom the two policemen are no doubt a part of) has torn the family apart. Still, Tao's upward journey starts him—and the family—on the path towards wisdom and eventual redemption, although he has no idea of this at the time.



The idea of the hide-and-seek game suggests the loving nature of Sheng's and Tao's relationship. Tao clearly adores and trusts his father, which makes his silence so painful for Tao, as he's a sheltered child and doesn't understand. Importantly, Tao responds to the loss with movement—traveling around the city and ultimately trying to climb up the tree—to learn more.



The Chinese Communist Party sought to reallocate wealth to the poorer members of society, but often did so through violent and heavy-handed means such as subdividing the villa. This highlights the immense power the Communist Party had to change everyday life for its people—it invades people's homes and forces them to embrace new living and family structures.



Tao understands his place in the world through his home and his family. While the kapok tree stays the same despite its seasonal variations, when Sheng left, Tao's family assumed a new and unfamiliar shape, which has left him feeling vulnerable and unsettled. He tries to escape this discomfort by trying to return to the past. Instead, he ends up suffering even more, suggesting that Tao can't escape his present difficulties.



THE KAPOK TREE, JULY 1958: KAI YING (I)

Tao's tiny body looks like a broken branch or a crushed leaf underneath the **kapok tree**. Kai Ying fears that he might be paralyzed or—worse—dead. Some things, she knows, lie beyond her healing skills. She watches, wide-eyed, as her father-in-law Wei yells for help from their only neighbor with a vehicle.

Kai Ying and Wei sit for hours in the hospital waiting room, surrounded by a crush of humanity. Some people seem worried, others calmly make themselves at home. She can't see a single doctor, but a poster of Chairman Mao glares at her from across the room. She imagines his accusatory voice demanding to know how she could have let her only son fall from a tree while she was asleep.

While she waits, Kai Ying worries about her patients. She is an herbalist, adept at helping keep her clients' energies balanced so they can maintain their health. She came to Guangzhou in 1947, when she was 19, to study herbalism with a family friend. She met her husband Sheng at Herbalist Chu's shop, and she married him instead of going home at the end of her apprenticeship. Tao was born the following year. After Sheng's arrest for writing a letter critical of Mao and the Communist Party, she returned to her work as an herbalist to support the family.

Kai Ying remembers that Auntie Song will stop by for herbs this morning. She's a family friend and will watch the house and tell the other patients to come back tomorrow, even if she doesn't know where Wei and Kai Ying have gone. They have been waiting for news for three hours. Wei sits, still and calm. Kai Ying knows that if Sheng were there, he'd be pacing and anxious. She tries not to imagine the worst or to dwell on past traumas, like her miscarriage three years ago or Sheng's arrest the previous summer. But she grows more and more distraught. Wei quietly holds her hand.

Kai Ying experiences success as a practitioner of Chinese herbal medicine, but as she regretfully reflects here, she cannot fix everything with a medicinal soup or tea. Loss, guilt, and fear lie beyond her abilities because growth only comes through enduring life's trials, not trying to escape them.



Mao Zedong, the despotic leader of the Chinese Communist Party from 1949 until his death in 1977, cultivated a personality cult that placed him at the center of Chinese society. When Kai Ying imagines him scolding her personally for Tao's accident, she reveals the way that the Party ruled and controlled people by fear of punishment.



Kai Ying left her hometown as a teenager to come to Guangzhou, where she ended up meeting her future husband. Her journey to learn more about her trade ended up expanding her life more than she expected. And, importantly, it means she brings an outside perspective to the Lee family, which has remained rooted in one place and largely undisturbed for generations—at least until Sheng's arrest upset its natural balance.



Tao's fall isn't the first traumatic thing to happen to Kai Ying, and although she fights against dwelling on past trials here, it's clear that they've made her stronger despite the pain they caused her. Sheng—and the financial support of his job—may be gone, but it's clear that her work as an herbalist has kept the family afloat for a year. When she and Wei hold hands, they provide moral support to each other.



Kai Ying considers Wei. He was a professor of Chinese art history for many years, only retiring after the Communist Party came to power and began persecuting scholars and intellectuals. At first, he felt certain that the Party, in distant Beijing, would leave the more cosmopolitan south of China mostly alone. His serene outlook and his tendency to find answers by looking for the calm in the storm contrasts sharply with his son's approach to life. Sheng was a teacher, too. But, more impulsive than his father, he felt that answers could only be found by braving the storm. His grand dreams for China's future and strong negative opinions about the Party scared Kai Ying, who worried that his dissident views would get him into trouble, as they did after he wrote the letter.

As Kai Ying considers Wei, she discloses to readers more of how the Communist Party takeover affected their lives for the worse. In its distrust of perceived disloyalty and dissent, it persecuted and silenced anyone critical of the Party, Chairman Mao, or their policies, and both Wei and Sheng fell victim to persecution, albeit in different ways. The differences between Sheng and Wei point towards one of the Lee family's sources of strength—it brings together people with different, complimentary perspectives—and also establishes Wei's quiet, retiring character. His tendency to avoid conflict presents a problem in the world of the book, since it keeps him locked in place. Without movement and struggle, he remains locked in the past, unable to act fully in the present.



Kai Ying squirms in her chair. She reaches out and fingers the worn sleeve of Wei's favorite padded silk jacket. She marvels at how still and calm Wei seems as she peers into his face, looking for the similarities between him and Sheng. She imagines herself as the balancing point between their two temperaments. Then, she hears a quiet cough. She looks up and meets the eyes of a pregnant, acne-faced girl (later identified as Suyin) who can't be more than 14. Kai Ying's herbalist mind goes to work, planning out a regimen to clear the girl's skin and provide adequate nutrition for her baby. But the sound of a desperate and mournful scream deep in a hospital corridor interrupts her thoughts and once more she finds herself fighting the fear rising in her throat.

This early in the book, Kai Ying respects and even envies Wei's ability to be still; this is something to keep in mind going forward, since readers don't actually know if Wei's stillness is positive or negative. Crucially, as Kai Ying thinks about the gaping hole left in the family with Sheng's absence, she catches sight of Suyin—the book not-so-subtly suggests that Suyin will play an important role in helping to make the family whole again. This brief moment also shows readers Kai Ying's essential temperament: she's perceptive and aware of the world around her, as well as kind, caring, and generous.



THE KAPOK TREE, JULY 1958: WEI

Wei's family think he is meditating when he sits still with closed eyes, but he isn't. If he waits patiently enough the noise and light will fade away and he can conjure up the image of his dead wife Liang. It feels like the only moving picture he ever saw in a theater with Sheng, not long after the Communist Party takeover and shortly before Tao's birth. Like the heroine of the movie (which was a propaganda piece about the evils of capitalism and bourgeoisie excess), Liang's hair went prematurely gray. But that didn't bother her, and she refused to color it. Wei adored his wife. He met her when she was still a student at Lingnan University, where he taught. He misses her terribly. In the noise and bustle of the hospital, he cannot hang on to her image long enough to be comforted.

Just a few pages earlier, Kai Ying envied Wei for his peacefulness. Now, readers can see that he's not peacefully accepting the realities of his current life but is instead trying to escape into his past. Tao's fall has already shown this to be a bad idea: trying to return to the past prevents—rather than allows—growth, acceptance, and peace. In his attempts to escape his pain, Wei prolongs his own suffering. The act of conjuring up Liang is inherently selfish, in its own way. She's a ghost, and he owes nothing to her, so this isn't a relationship he has to nurture and she's now a fellow person he has to care for.



Wei worries that Tao's injury might be cosmic retribution for his own selfish absorption in his own work and interests. He didn't follow his father into business and was unhurried about marrying and having children. His academic studies took up most of Sheng's childhood. And then, when he finally retired and had time for her, Liang died. Wei tries to make up for his mistakes with Tao, and he lavishes his grandson with attention. He can feel Kai Ying, the daughter-in-law who he's grown to like and respect, looking at him. He opens his eyes and sees the concern on her face. He wishes he knew what to say to her, but Liang and Sheng always were more empathetic than him.

In a way, Wei recognizes his selfishness, like his inability to connect with Sheng as a child, and the degree to which he took Liang for granted during her life. He interprets her premature death, Sheng's arrest, and Tao's injury as karmic retribution for this selfishness. But he cannot yet bring himself to make different choices. Although he pours energy and effort into his relationship with Tao, he still excuses his coldness toward Kai Ying by claiming that he just isn't as empathetic as other people.



THE KAPOK TREE, JULY 1958: KAI YING (II)

Finally, a doctor arrives to take Kai Ying and Wei to Tao's room, where the tiny, sedated boy lies in a big bed surrounded by tubes and wires. The doctor explains how lucky Tao is to have survived the fall and says that he still faces the possibility of permanent disability if the growth plates in his shattered bones fail to heal properly. As Wei thanks the doctor, Kai Ying hears the relief in his voice.

Tao's attempt to escape the pain of his father's absence, to try to return to a past in which he was happy has proved to be not just impossible but downright dangerous. He has brought more suffering to himself and his family. Yet, if he can survive this trial, the doctor's words suggest that he—and they—can find healing and growth on the other side of it.



Kai Ying kisses Tao lightly on the forehead, searching his face for Sheng's features. But at rest, he looks more like her. She feels guilty over her inability to shelter Tao completely from the endless anxiety she's felt since Sheng's arrest. She and Wei have kept most of the details to themselves because Tao is so young. She remembers the agony of the weeks between Sheng's arrest and finally learning that he was sent north to a reeducation camp. She can only wait, worry, and hope that he will return. Wei stands staring out the window at the grimy brick wall of the next building. Observing that there isn't enough sunlight in the room during the afternoon, he says he will talk to the doctor about moving Tao to a more healing room. Kai Ying agrees.

Like Tao's attempt to climb the tree, Kai Ying's search for Sheng's features in Tao's face represents an attempt to escape from a painful present into the much-missed past. The fact that she sees only herself strongly suggests the futility of this longing. Kai Ying can only rely on her own strength to carry herself and her family through this time. And although she tortures herself with a feeling of guilt over her failure to protect Tao, the circumstances strongly suggest the impossibility of this task, too. Life involves suffering, the book argues, and attempts to avoid it usually backfire and cause more pain.



THE KAPOK TREE, JULY 1958: SUYIN

At dusk, Suyin leaves the hospital and walks back towards Dongshan Park. She's 15 years old and seven months pregnant. She knows she can't take care of her baby, so she plans to leave it at the hospital, hoping that the doctors and nurses there will find it a good home. She wishes it could have a devoted mother like the woman whom she overheard fretting over an injured son in the hospital that morning (Kai Ying).

Kai Ying and Wei can only see their own (and Tao's) suffering, but others, like Suyin, suffer too. Suyin's resolve that her baby will have a better life than she has shows that her own sufferings have not destroyed her ability to have hope. And her wish contains the idea that a person can forge a family beyond the bounds of marriage and blood relations.



Suyin's own mother worked hard to support her three children after her husband abandoned her. But eventually she married Suyin's despised stepfather. Suyin left her family and her neighborhood in Old Guangzhou when her pregnancy began to show, to avoid gossip and shame. Now, she lives on the streets and misses the tiny apartment. A few weeks earlier, she realized that she could sit unnoticed in the hospital waiting room when she wanted to get off the street during the day. As Suyin approaches the park, her hunger emboldens her to ask a man directly for some money, something she usually avoids; she prefers to silently beg at the park gates. He refuses. Tears threaten to fall from her eyes, and she thinks again about the woman in the waiting room (Kai Ying), the first person in months to look at her as if she were a human being.

The book strongly suggests that Suyin's own mother abandoned her (or would have, if Suyin had stayed) as punishment for her pregnancy. In contrast, Kai Ying's gaze at the hospital reminded Suyin of her inherent human dignity. She clings to this when the man in the park treats her like human refuse. This foreshadows the important role Kai Ying will play as a surrogate mother to Suyin. And it suggests that the idea of "family" involves mutual love, support, and forgiveness—things Suyin could not find with her mother and stepfather.



THE KAPOK TREE, JULY 1958: KAI YING (III)

As Wei and Kai Ying head home from the hospital through congested streets, Kai Ying finds herself resenting every mother she sees walking with a healthy child. At home, she pauses in the courtyard for a moment, standing beneath the **kapok tree** and trying to steady herself. Wei goes into the empty house; the Changs have gone to visit their daughter in another city. Kai Ying realizes gratefully that Tao's fall left no bloodstains or other permanent marks in the courtyard. She loves the tree, in part because its living grandeur reminds her of her the countryside where she grew up. It contrasts with the bustling, hard-edged city landscape. She can't imagine why Tao tried to climb it, unless it was from the impulsiveness he shares with Sheng.

Kai Ying's relief that Tao's fall left no permanent marks suggests her own impossible desire for things to return to the way they were before. If there's no evidence of the fall and Tao recovers fully, it will be like it never happened. But of course, she cannot rewrite reality in that way. Readers know that Tao's fall—like Sheng's arrest and the family's other trials—will always be a part of their story. Only by facing these trials with bravery can they move into the future stronger than before.



Wei emerges from the kitchen with something glinting in his hand, and before Kai Ying realizes what it is, he's hacking at the trunk to the **kapok tree** with a meat cleaver. She grabs his arm. She doesn't want him to harm the tree, which is an official symbol of the city. The family doesn't need any of their neighbors turning them in for holding dissident or disgruntled opinions. As she takes the cleaver from Wei's hands, he recognizes—and shares—the fear, grief, and frustration she sees in his eyes. But she has no soothing words. She wishes for Wei's customary serenity to return as she looks up at the tree with the sense that she and Wei are falling, too.

The kapok tree represents not just strength but also resilience—apart from the seasonal cycle of flower, leaf, and bare branches, it has remained unchanged for generations. As Kai Ying looks at it, fantasizing about life going back to the way it was before Tao's fall, Wei attacks it. The wound will heal over and the tree will survive, but it will have a permanent scar. This scar suggests that only through surviving suffering can people find strength, resilience, and wisdom.



THE FALLING BOY, AUGUST 1958: TAO (I)

Tao doesn't remember much after his fall. He spends his time in the hospital in a groggy, sedated haze. But he always feels better when he wakes up to find Kai Ying and Wei in the room with him. Occasionally, he hears them talking with the doctor. He wonders if anyone has told Sheng about the fall, and if his injuries will bring his father home.

Tao's hope that news of his injury will bring his father home shows that, in the absence of the full truth, he has formed confused ideas about Sheng's absence. Although he saw the arrest, he seems to think that Sheng has the freedom to decide when to come back. Wei's and Kai Ying's attempts to shield Tao, to protect him from pain, end up causing him more confusion and anguish.



THE FALLING BOY, AUGUST 1958: SONG

Auntie Song sits contentedly in her vegetable garden, harvesting Chinese broccoli for a celebratory dinner: after two weeks in the hospital, Tao is coming home. Soon it will be time to plant fall crops, although she plans to wait, if necessary, until Tao can help her. At 68 years old, Song still spends hours working in the garden each day, finding it more effective in combating her arthritis and other age-related illnesses than Kai Ying's herbal concoctions.

Like the kapok tree, Song's garden obeys the rhythms of nature, the increase of spring and the dying back of fall. Nothing stays the same, it suggests; attempts to ignore this truth will cause unhappiness. The contrast between the elderly Song and the young Tao contributes to this sense of time's movement. But passing down traditions from adult to child ensures that, even as life changes, the lessons of the past endure.



The villa is very different from the busy streets and cramped apartments of the Old Guangzhou district where Song spent most of her life. After Song's husband died, Liang—her best friend from elementary school—invited her to move there. Song believes that she and Liang must have been sisters in a previous life, because otherwise she struggles to understand how they could have maintained their friendship despite the differences in their lives. Unlike Liang's marriage, Song's was miserable. Her husband, Old Hing, was 40 and had been married twice before. She was only 16, but her parents agreed to the marriage for an insultingly small dowry payment.

Song's past shows how tribulation can turn into strength and wisdom. Her gratitude for the garden and the simple things she enjoys in life, like friendship and companionship, seems to be sharpened by the contrast between the present and harder times in her life. Her marriage also points to some of the traditions that the Communist Party overturned, including plural marriage and bride-selling. But it's yet to be seen whether doing away with these traditional practices automatically makes life better.



Song moved to the villa before the Communist takeover, and she worried about fitting into this wealthy, privileged neighborhood. But she longed for the opportunities it presented, like the chance to have a garden and live a peaceful, quiet life. Now, she considers the Lees family, and she has looked after them protectively since Liang's death. Considering the blessings of her life, she feels certain that Tao will recover and Sheng will return, things she prays for to the goddess Kuan Yin every day.

The Chinese Communist Revolution claimed to want to overthrow the abuses of capitalism and the class system, yet it fell into its own missteps and abuses. Song's experience suggests that the best way to overcome inequality is not by government policy but through relationships. After all, Liang and Wei were happy to help Song even before the revolution sought to erase the difference in their class statuses.



THE FALLING BOY, AUGUST 1958: TAO (II)

Two days after leaving the hospital, Tao wakes up in his bedroom. Everything seems strangely unfamiliar, except the **kapok tree**, which he can see through the slit of his curtains. In the hospital, he worried that his mother and grandfather might have cut it down, punishing it for his mistake. But it was still standing when Wei carried him through the villa gate. Tao knows Sheng will understand the dream that sent him up the tree, and he can't wait to tell him. But what Tao will not—cannot—ever tell anyone is how he felt like he was flying while he was falling. He was certain that if he'd just been able to keep going, he would have soared all the way to **White Cloud Mountain**.

Now, Tao feels uncomfortable and confined; he's bedridden until his leg heals. He listens to Kai Ying and Wei moving in the kitchen. He worries about healing in time to start school—he doesn't want to lose his standing as second student—and he misses his best friend Little Shan. Tao hears his mother preparing the bitter herbal tea she gives him every day to help his body regain its balance and heal. He misses the magic of watching her work. It's strange to think of himself as one of her patients. He misses helping her deliver packets of herbs to her patients, especially Auntie Song, whom he admires for her strength and resilience. She's not unlike the **kapok tree** in that way, he realizes. He can't wait to go back to helping her in the garden.

A gust of breeze outside sends the first leaves from the **kapok tree** to the ground. Each spring, Kai Ying has Tao collect its fallen flower petals, which she later turns into a fever-calming tea. The leaves collected in the fall become poultices for injuries. Since his accident, he knows he'll look at the tree differently, with heightened awareness of its healing properties.

THE FALLING BOY, AUGUST 1958: SUYIN

Suyin cannot sleep; the humid August night and her gnawing hunger make her too uncomfortable. She knows that if she's hungry, her baby is too, and she feels anxious about her inability to protect it from suffering. It's too early to go to the park and rummage through the trash or to beg or steal food at the market. Whispering a promise to her baby that one day they'll eat nothing but their favorite foods, she chews on a handful of straw from her makeshift bed.

Not only did Tao's attempt to reclaim the past and find his father fail, but it backfired, making his life even more strange and painful. The injury, like Sheng's arrest, like everything else that has happened to him, has changed the trajectory of Tao's life even though he doesn't yet grasp all the implications. His memory of flying toward White Cloud Mountain—that is, of soaring into an untroubled version of the past—represents what he hoped the climb would achieve, but what it never could.



Despite—or perhaps especially because of—how his injury has turned Tao's life upside down, he redoubles his efforts to keep things from changing. Yet, at almost every moment, he faces reminders of his troubles: he lies in bed while his mother and grandfather eat breakfast and his mother works in the kitchen. He's not Kai Ying's son and helper anymore; he has become her patient. Still, Tao sees Song and the kapok tree as ideal models of the kind of strength and resilience he wants for himself, models he tries to emulate. And interestingly, they both change (or have changed), even as they seem constant and dependable.



The medicines provided by the kapok tree speak to the variety of accidents that can happen in a life—illnesses and injuries big (like Tao's fall) and small. But there are ways to help ease a person's way, such as through the various medicines Kai Wing makes from the kapok tree.



Suyin suffers the double indignities of being pregnant and homeless at the same time, possibly because her family failed to protect and care for her. Yet, adversity shows her strength, and instead of giving up on the idea of a family, she redoubles her efforts to provide a good one for her own baby, even though she cannot imagine at the moment how she will do this.



THE FALLING BOY, AUGUST 1958: KAI YING

Kai Ying feels grateful to have Tao at home. But he has changed: he's no longer boisterous and fearless. Instead, he has become quiet and watchful. His hospital-shaved head and sunken cheeks remind her of Sheng, and she worries about what he may be suffering at the labor camp. It's been six months since his last letter arrived. She tries not to think about what might keep him from writing.

During the day, while Kai Ying sees patients, Wei entertains Tao with stories. She hopes this time soothes Wei as much as it does Tao; since Sheng's arrest, Wei has become increasingly downtrodden and withdrawn. She avoids looking at his eyes, as she's afraid to find the anguish and defeat she saw when he attacked the **kapok tree**. She feels grateful when she hears them laughing upstairs.

Kai Ying pulls the first of Sheng's two letters from her pocket and rereads it for the hundredth time. In it, he explains that the police held him for weeks in Guangzhou before deciding to send him north to a reeducation camp near Luoyang. It leaves much unsaid; Sheng cannot risk saying anything that might make his punishment for opposing the Communist Party worse. Some people sent away to the labor camps return as shadows of their former selves. Some never return.

Kai Ying remembers the spring of 1956, when Chairman Mao and the Communist Party poetically announced the Hundred Flowers Campaign, which asked intellectuals, artists, and others to offer suggestions for ways to improve China and the Party itself. Sheng was excited at the opportunity to try to improve China's future. Kai Ying worried that the campaign was a trap designed to draw out and punish dissenters. At first, most people acted cautiously, keeping their thoughts to themselves. But after Mao and China's well-respected premier repeated the request in 1957, people began to voice their opinions, calling out the Party for its abuses. Then, when Mao and the Party abruptly grew tired of the criticism, they cancelled the campaign and arrested those who spoke up—including Sheng. Kai Ying wonders what his letter said and how the authorities traced it to him.

Earlier, Kai Ying felt relieved that there were no physical signs of Tao's fall in the courtyard, but now she realizes that even without outward signs, the experience has changed Tao. And much to her dismay, she realizes that the adversity of his imprisonment will change Sheng, too, in ways that will make it impossible for her to cling to the past.



True to her role as a healer (both in general and in the context of her family), Kai Ying hopes that Tao's recovery will also bring some relief to Wei. Readers should recall from the first section that Wei realized, far too late, how little attention he gave to Sheng when he was a boy. Wei tries to make up for this mistake by lavishing attention on Tao, but his ongoing sadness suggests that this isn't enough to make him feel better.



Sheng's letter points towards the brutal repression of the Chinese Communist Party; in many ways it simply replaced one brutal and repressive regime with another. Sheng must censor himself in his letters, highlighting how the Communist Party keeps people from connecting honestly with each other—Kai Ying knows, for instance, that Sheng certainly isn't telling her everything he'd like to. And further, it remains to be seen what state Sheng will be in when he returns—if he returns at all.



The Hundred Flowers Campaign illustrates how the Chinese Communist Party failed to live up to its stated goals of freeing and elevating the Chinese people. Instead of listening to input and justified criticism of its sometimes dangerous and harmful policies, it rejected all feedback. This highlights the government's power and reach—and how it abuses that power. And it's the country's citizens and their families that suffer the most, as illustrated by Sheng's imprisonment and the toll his arrest is now taking on his family.



In his first letter, Sheng described the flat, northern scenery and wrote about missing the **kapok tree**. He talked about his 14-hour days in a stone quarry, and the cramped barrack where he lives. He sent his love to Wei and Tao and promised to take the family on a trip to **White Cloud Mountain** when he returned. The second letter had arrived in February. It was brief, just a short, bitter announcement that he was too far away to come home for a visit during the New Year furlough. Since then, although Kai Ying and Wei have sent letters and packages, they have heard nothing back. Not knowing if Sheng has received her letters, or even if he's still alive, torments Kai Ying.

The kapok tree even provides a model of strength and resilience for Sheng 1,000 miles away from home. But although he can draw strength from his memories of the past, he still must find his strength in the present. And the harsh irony of the Party granting its prisoners leave for the holidays after moving most of them too far away to reach their families in time underlines the cruelty of his punishment—and the way it purposefully affects not just the accused but his whole family, too.



THE FALLING BOY, AUGUST 1958: WEI

After breakfast, Wei goes to his bedroom to fetch a book of mythology for Tao. The room used to belong to his parents. His mother was his father's fourth, much younger wife; wife number one had died before Wei's birth, but wives two and three lived in the house during his childhood. Since his half-sisters were all much older, he grew up like an only child. He didn't realize until he was an adult that he was once the much longed-for first son of his elderly father.

Chinese culture condoned concubinage (the sexual and social alliance of one man with multiple women who had lower status than his official wife) up to the Communist Revolution in the middle of the 20th century. Because concubines or plural wives indicated a man's wealth and status, the Party condemned the practice as a sign of elite decadence—not necessarily to improve the lives of women. Wei's reflections show how he belatedly begins to understand that familial responsibilities are mutual. Only long after his father's death does he understand how much his father longed for heirs to carry on the family legacy.



Crammed bookshelves line the walls of Wei's room, reminding him of his university office and providing a sense of security. When he was a child, the villa had a library downstairs, and he remembers feeling responsible for reading all the books it held when he was a child. After the Party subdivided the villas, the library became the Changs' bedroom. Recently, Tao asked if Wei had read all the books in his room. Wei confided that he'd read all of them and more: he has many books banned by the Party hidden away in a safe spot that he promises to show Tao after his leg has healed.

Even as a child, Wei gave himself "responsibilities" that fell in line with his own needs and desires rather than anyone else's, such as reading all the books in his father's library. And although he thinks he gets a sense of comfort from the books in his room, his eagerness to share them with Tao shows his growing but still mostly subconscious awareness that true security and comfort come from relationships, not books or ideas. The need to hide certain books points towards the repressive nature of the Communist Party.



Wei's gaze falls on a beloved book of poetry, given to him as a gift by a teenaged Sheng long ago. He reads one poem every day to feel close to his son. This morning, the poem he picks—an ode from a father to a distant son—makes him angry. It just reminds him how cruelly the Party punishes dissenters by sending them thousands of miles away from home and then trying to work them to death. Wei remembers a colleague, an outspoken critic of Mao and the Party who was sent to the mines in his 70s for dissent. They claimed he died of "natural" causes.

Books substitute poorly for people; handling this one, a gift from Sheng, makes Wei feel worse instead of making Sheng feel close. Wei shares the pain of absence just like the poem's father, but it's unclear exactly why the poem makes him angry. Is it because Sheng is currently imprisoned and may face a tortured death like the elderly colleague Wei remembers, or is there more to Wei's anger?



Tears fill Wei's eyes. He unlocks his desk and pulls out a worn leather journal that contains a copy of the letter he wrote to the Premier's Office. The words he used to argue for freedom of expression are burned into his memory. He regrets writing that letter, regrets his vanity and self-importance, regrets signing it with the name he shares with his son, Weisheng. On the morning of Sheng's arrest, he whispered his guilt into Sheng's ear. He begged the police to take him. But they ignored him, and Sheng promised that he would be alright. Wei feels heartsick; what kind of father lets his son bear the blame for his crimes?

Now, Wei can only find solace with Tao. He wants to relieve the boy's increasing restlessness but knows he will have to ask Kai Ying if he wants to carry Tao downstairs; she fears any movement that might compromise the leg's healing and leave Tao with a limp. Things have been awkward between Wei and his daughter-in-law since he attacked the **kapok tree**. He tried to apologize, but he lacks the words to explain his actions and that his fury was directed at no one but himself.

This morning, to distract Tao, Wei tells him about the four mythical creatures that surround the world: the dragon, the tiger, the phoenix, and the tortoise. Wei watches Tao studying a picture of these creatures in a book, and the boy reminds him of Sheng, standing shyly in the doorway of Wei's office as a child. Absorbed in his work, Wei neglected the opportunity to talk to his son. He regrets that now. Shaking himself, Wei explains how each creature represents a season and a direction and how they surround and protect the snake coiled at the center of the world. Tao is like that snake, resting in stillness while the world protects him. Tao smiles and asks if the creatures will protect his father, too. Wei promises they will.

The full scope of Wei's guilt finally becomes clear: when he dared to speak out against the Communist Party, he did so in a way that inadvertently endangered Sheng. Wei accuses himself of believing that his work and his ideas were more important than the safety and happiness of his family. In contrast, Sheng prioritized his father's safety and wellbeing when he took the blame for the letter. Wei realizes, belatedly, that he owes his son care and concern too. But with Sheng gone, he cannot see how to fulfil his responsibilities.



When Wei attacks the kapok tree, he scars it for the rest of its life. Similarly, although he hasn't yet openly acknowledged writing the letter, this action has irrevocably changed his life and the lives of his family in ways he could not have imagined. Even if Tao recovers as his mother hopes he will—without a permanent limp—his life will never be the same as it was before the fall, or before his father's arrest. But by avoiding responsibility and keeping his role a secret, Wei increases his own pain and everyone else's. He can only heal when—or if—he learns to honor his relationships and take responsibility for his actions.



Finally, the novel reveals that Wei neglected his relationship with Sheng when Sheng was young, which only adds to Wei's guilt now, in the present. Looking at Tao, Wei continues to see his failures with Sheng, and he works hard to make up for the mistakes he made in the past. But he misses two crucial things: first, he wants to return to a point in the past that was happier, something that cannot happen. Second, he holds himself to an impossible standard; the book pointedly suggest that only mythical creatures can provide the kind of perfect protection he wishes he could give Tao now or could go back and give Sheng in the past.



THE FALLING BOY, AUGUST 1958: TAO (III)

That evening, Wei carries Tao down to the kitchen where Kai Ying and Auntie Song are cooking dinner that includes some of Tao's favorite foods. Tao wants to wait in the courtyard, and Kai Ying allows it. The air feels good after weeks of confinement. Tao looks at the **kapok tree**, even as his grandfather tries to avoid it, and begins to feel at home once more. Tao thinks about how different—how sad and serious—his beloved grandfather has been since Sheng left. It's like a heavy weight drags him down. Tao wants to lift that weight, but he doesn't know how to. When Wei lowers him to the stone bench, Tao longs for his father's strength. When Wei picks him up to go inside, Tao sees the thin gash in the **kapok tree's** trunk. It's small, but he knows it will leave a scar.

The kapok tree continues to offer a model of resilience for everyone in the Lee family—and readers—to emulate. It is both deeply rooted and constantly changing, budding in the spring, dropping its leaves in the fall, growing taller and stronger every year. It survived the blow Wei dealt it, although that attack will mark it for the rest of its life. Likewise, the letter, Sheng's arrest, and Tao's fall will leave indelible marks on the lives of everyone in the family. But if they can stick together, remain rooted in their family context, the symbolism of the kapok tree suggests that they will survive and thrive.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: TAO (I)

On the day Tao's cast will be removed, he listens to Kai Ying slip out of the gate early in the morning to go to the market. School has been in session for two weeks, and recently Little Shan visited with the news that, in Tao's absence, he has become second student. Seeing Little Shan again made Tao realize how much life has changed since his fall.

Climbing the tree was, in part, Tao's attempt to return his life to the way it was before his father's arrest. As if to emphasize the impossibility of this wish, not only did his climb fail, but when he fell and injured himself, the repercussions of his actions shook up his life even more.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: KAI YING (I)

Kai Ying feels the change of seasons in the air and is grateful to see the end of a difficult summer. The Moon Festival is tomorrow night, and she hastens toward the market thinking of some extra money she's spent months saving to buy an expensive box of Tao's favorite mooncakes. She hopes the Party hasn't abolished this small pleasure, too.

Tao's fall destroyed what little sense of normalcy and stability Kai Ying had been able to maintain after Sheng's arrest, and she's eager to move on with Tao home. Yet, the world provides constant reminders of the ways the Communist Party has destroyed the life she used to live, from rising costs to the increasing rarity of life's small pleasures.



Away from the villa, Kai Ying can let her guard down and consider the things she refuses to contemplate at home. Maybe Tao will be permanently disabled. Wei seems to be losing energy and emotional strength. His reticence reminds her of when she first married Sheng. Wei was distant and aloof then, too, and she constantly worried that he was disappointed in Sheng for choosing her instead of a better educated, wealthier girl. When he finally introduced her as his daughter-in-law, a year into her marriage, she felt proud. But she also always suspected that Wei only accepted her as a necessity when it became clear that Liang was dying. She thinks they eventually arrived at a place of mutual respect, but she's felt that slipping since Sheng's arrest.

Importantly, Kai Ying must leave the villa—must go on a journey, even if it's just a short one to the market—to gain the insights necessary to help her grow. Her memories of the early months of her marriage point to how Wei has always held himself apart from the family, and how he has been able to get away with it because of others' willingness to accept responsibility for his actions. This selfishness leaves Kai Ying vulnerable and exhausted as she tries to support Wei with her own limited emotional resources. Of course, readers already know that Wei feels angry and disappointed in himself, not in her. But in his inability to communicate this, he alienates Kai Ying further.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: TAO (II)

In his mother's absence, Tao consoles himself by thinking about the Autumn Moon Festival, his favorite celebration of the year. He loves the tasty mooncakes, the gold and red lanterns they hang in the courtyard, and the celebratory feast. Each year, Wei tells him a different version of the festival's central myth, about Huoyi the archer and his wife Chang'e, the Moon Goddess of Immortality.

According to the myth, Emperor Yao gave Huoyi a magic pill of immortality after he saved the earth by shooting down nine of the 10 suns that threatened to burn it up. For some reason (each version of the story gives a different reason), Huoyi's wife Chang'e swallowed the pill. She flew up to the moon, where she learned she could never return to earth. Huoyi eventually settled on the sun, and now he and Chang'e only see each other once a year, on the night of the Moon Festival. In Tao's favorite version, Chang'e swallowed the pill to keep it safe from the greedy hands of one of Huoyi's apprentices.

Tao finishes his breakfast as he hears Wei in the kitchen. Outside his window, the leaves of the **kapok tree** wave at him in the breeze. He tells himself that by this time tomorrow, everything will be back to normal: he will quickly catch up at school, where he will entertain his classmates with the story of his fall from the tree. He will exaggerate the best details just a little bit, like his storyteller grandfather does. But still, he won't be able to tell it like one of the best myths, because in that version, he would have kept flying until he landed on the sun or the moon.

Tao looks forward to the Autumn Moon Festival, which celebrates, in part, love and reunions. Yet the family will celebrate the holiday without Sheng. Thus, the event becomes yet another reminder of all they have lost and how irrevocably their lives have changed in the past year.



The myth of Huoyi and Chang'e maps onto the Lee family's recent history in several ways. On one level, the separation of Huoyi from his wife mirrors the separation between Kai Ying and Sheng. But importantly, in Tao's favorite version, Chang'e's exile comes about when she tries to keep the magic pill safe from a bad actor. Likewise, Sheng self-sacrificially accepts the punishment for Wei's letter to protect the father, whom he loves and respects. The reunion of Huoyi and Chang'e offers hope that the sacrifices the family must make during these hard times might eventually be redeemed and made meaningful.



As a young child, Tao clings to the illusion that he can avoid suffering. He does not yet fully grasp the lesson of the kapok tree or his fall: no one can return to or recreate happier times in the past, and no one can escape pain and suffering. Only as he learns to incorporate the fall into his life story—something he practices in his head at this moment—will he be able to find peace.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: KAI YING (II)

Despite her attempt to beat the crowds, the market swarms with people when Kai Ying arrives. She decides to go to the herb shop and Mr. Lam's sweetshop first. As she walks, the smell of roasting chestnuts reminds her of the day she arrived in the city. At first, the incessant noise and bustle of the city made her intensely homesick for her rural village, and she rarely left Herbalist Chu's shop.

As the narration returns to Kai Ying on her errands, it continues to explore the theme of growth and movement. The longer she walks, the more she remembers her past. And in remembering her past, she can see how much she has grown and changed in response. This offers hope that she will survive these new challenges, too, and come out stronger for it.



The shop still looks the same as when Kai Ying first arrived; she suspects it hasn't changed in generations. As she steps inside, she remembers worrying that she would never learn the thousands of herbs and all their countless combinations. She wonders if Herbalist Chu hid the rarest and most precious ingredients away before the Communist Party took over the government. Certainly, none of them are on display any longer. When she started her apprenticeship, her favorite ingredient was **pearl**; she loved holding the tiny, delicate spheres in her hand. Each week she took one and hid it in a little sack, a way to count the weeks until she went home. But of course, she never went home.

Kai Ying has done hard things before, even if they were different than the trials she faces at this moment with Sheng's arrest and Tao's injury. But her apprenticeship shows that she has resilience and intelligence, two key traits that will help her navigate whatever trials life throws at her. Being in the shop provides another reminder of how much has changed since the Communist takeover; expensive medicines made from precious ingredients like pearls have become a sign of the elite decadence the Party despises. But Kai Ying knows that things of beauty have value beyond their monetary value; to her, the pearls she once held in her hand represented, above all else, hope for the future.



When Kai Ying returns to the market; it's even busier than before. She buys ingredients quickly, impatient to go home, but she finds herself waylaid by an important—and insistent—client. She can't afford to lose business, not with Sheng gone and everything from vegetables to meat becoming scarcer and more expensive. As she leaves the market, out of the corner of her eye, she catches a glimpse the girl from the hospital waiting room (Suyin).

Although the Communist Party claims to seek the freedom and wellbeing of all Chinese people, the increasing expense and dwindling supply of even staples like vegetables—not to mention luxuries like meat—show its failures to live up to its ideals. On a historical note, this book takes place on the eve of the Great Chinese Famine, and the agricultural policies which precipitated that event were already in place by 1958; the scarcity Kai Ying notices may point to that event.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: SUYIN

Suyin never thought her path would cross Kai Ying's again. It feels like an omen, especially since in that very moment she feels her baby kick for the first time in days. Lately, her pregnancy has become almost unbearable, and she no longer has the stamina to beg in the park. Instead, she wanders the market, hoping that shoppers or vendors will take pity on her and give her a little food. The thought of how little the world has to offer her or her baby sometimes makes her panicky. She feels desperately homesick. But seeing Kai Ying gives her hope. Quietly, at a distance, she follows Kai Ying home from the market.

Suyin knows that she needs to find a new place of shelter and stability if she and her baby want to survive in a frequently harsh world. Kai Ying's sudden reappearance thus seems to her like a promise from the universe that she can find the family she needs to keep her and her baby safe. And in following Kai Ying home, Suyin sets out on a journey of her own across the city—a journey that will change her life forever.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: WEI (I)

While Kai Ying prepares Tao for his trip to the hospital, Wei finds himself walking along the path to Song's rooms, almost without realizing it. They used to spend a lot of time together, reminiscing about Liang and the old days, but Wei has avoided Song since Sheng's arrest. He's certain that she will uncover the secret of the letter and reveal his shame. But although he doesn't know what to say, he feels an urgent need to talk to her again.

As Kai Ying travels across the city, Wei sets out on a much shorter, but equally important, journey across the villa's courtyard. His guilt has kept him away; finding himself on the path to Song's apartment implies that he's perhaps getting closer to working up the courage to admit his mistakes and to begin to atone for them.



Song sits in the garden, working. She teases Wei about his enduring unwillingness to get his hands dirty helping her out, and she then invites him inside her apartment for tea. She graciously acts as if no time has passed at all, although she has noticed that Wei has been avoiding her. Being with Song always reminds Wei of Liang, since the two were inseparable. After Liang's death, Song was the only woman of their age whom he didn't resent for being alive still. Fretting over how ill and frail he knows he looks, especially in contrast to Song's vitality, Wei follows her inside.

Song pours a cup for tea for Wei. They discuss Tao's recovery. Song feels certain that all will be well for the boy, and for Sheng. Wei wants to know how she can be so sure, and he tries to unburden himself of his guilt. But he doesn't get farther than saying he's made a terrible mistake before his fear overwhelms him and he freezes.

Song teases Wei like an intimate member of his family because she is one. The book suggests that a true family forms wherever people love and support one another through the trials of life. Song fits this description, even though she has no legal or biological ties to anyone else in the villa. The Lee family becomes stronger and more resilient as it grows through bonds of friendship, as well as through marriage and having children.



Song had a difficult life long before the Communist takeover, so she has a different perspective on suffering than Wei, whose sheltered life and caring family insulated him from trouble until quite recently. She understands that trials and tribulations pass and that they can leave people stronger and wiser for having endured them. Wei struggles to believe Song, even though he wants to, highlighting that he's at the beginning of his journey.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: TAO (III)

As the doctor cuts the cast from Tao's leg, Tao clings to Kai Ying's hand. He remembers a time when he was four years old, and his hand slipped from hers in a busy downtown area. He remembers trying to follow her through the crowd, getting more scared by the minute. Eventually, a stranger had to help him find Kai Ying. The memory still haunts him. As the doctor unwraps the leg, he tells Tao to avoid climbing trees in the future. Tao nods: he has no intention of climbing the **kapok tree** or getting lost in a crowd ever again—he knows his weak leg won't allow him to keep up with his mother.

The next afternoon—the afternoon of the Moon Festival—it rains. Tao stands up from the dinner table and walks, slowly but without the crutches the doctor told him to use while he rebuilt his strength, to the window. It bothers him that, after all those weeks of immobility, his leg isn't fully healed. When Wei asks if Tao wants to hear the story of Huoyi and Chang'e, Tao refuses. It's not the same without the moon. Wei says they still have the story, and besides, the moon is there, just behind the clouds. But Tao wonders to himself if the moon has a point when it's hidden. It certainly won't light Sheng's way home.

Earlier in the day, Tao lay in bed and told himself that as soon as the cast came off, his life would go back to the way it was before his fall. But his flashback to a frightening childhood experience of being lost suggests he recognizes, at least subconsciously, that this is impossible. Even before Sheng's arrest, bad and scary things happened. And all of the events that happen to Tao become part of his unfolding experience, shaping the way he looks at the world going forward. Still, he finds strength in his mother's presence, and this points yet again to the power of family to provide a place of safety and comfort.



As if to emphasize the cruel truths that life involves suffering and that things will not be going back to normal any time soon for Tao or the rest of the family, it rains on the night of the Moon Festival. According to legends, this is when the full moon brings Huoyi and Chang'e close enough together for their one reunion a year. When Tao rejects Wei's story, he's registering his disappointment at discovering that things aren't going to magically get better any time soon.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: KAI YING (III)

It rains all through the night of the Moon Festival and into the next morning, the storm's ferocity increasing until the wind howls through the courtyard. Kai Ying sleeps poorly. She's troubled by Tao's disappointment at not seeing the moon the previous night, his frustration at not being able to walk, and his impatience with his healing body. She wonders what Sheng would say and suddenly, the realization that she doesn't remember the sound of his voice—and the fear that she will never hear it again—overwhelms her.

Song enters the kitchen and asks if Kai Ying is all right. She encourages Kai Ying to cry and alleviate some of her pain and sadness. But Kai Ying claims that the steamy kitchen makes her eyes water. As Kai Ling wraps up the herbs for Song's arthritis tea, they discuss Tao's recovery and Sheng's long silence. Kai Ling fears that something bad has happened, but Song points out that there are many possible explanations. Worrying only makes it harder. She should know; she had her own share of a wife's burden. Kai Ying is one of only two people (the other being Liang) to whom Song ever confided details about her sorrowful past. Kai Ying tries to focus on her gratitude for marrying a good man like Sheng. She tries to cling to hope. But it keeps getting harder.

The tempest outside reflects—and amplifies—the unrest within the walls of the villa. It suggests the unfriendliness and cruelty of the world and the many things that happen outside of human control. And in the wake of its fury, Kai Ying realizes how fragile her connection to Sheng has become.



Song and Kai Ying model how the mutual love and support of family can create strength and resilience against life's trials. Song's troubled past gives her a different perspective on suffering, one which she tries to share with Kai Ying. She knows that bad things—the kind of things Kai Ying worries about, like Sheng's possible death—can happen in life. But good things can happen too. Song's troubled marriage gave way in time to her inclusion in the Lee family, for instance.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: SONG

Song considers Kai Ying the daughter she never had, and she wishes she could lighten the younger woman's burden. She and Kai Ying reminisce about the afternoon they first met, at Herbalist Chu's shop. It was, Song thinks, fate. Now, she makes a shocking confession: on that day, she had planned to ask for herbs to help her commit suicide. She couldn't face life with Old Hing anymore. But then she met Kai Ying, and the care and concern the young woman showed as she treated Song's abscessed tooth—the result of a beating from Old Hing—made her feel human again for the first time in years. Within six months, Old Hing had died, and Song had moved to the villa. When Kai Ying married Sheng, Song was there to teach her how to be in the Lee household. She never thought about suicide again.

Song recognizes the importance of relationships in a person's life. In treating her like a worthy and dignified human being (in sharp contrast to Old Hing's degrading abuse), Kai Ying saved Song's life. She reminded Song that life could still hold sweetness and companionship and helped her find enough hope to look toward the future again. Song finds redemption for all the lost years and opportunities of her life in adopting the Lee family as her own, and in reciprocating the love and respect she received—and still receives—from Kai Ying.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: KAI YING (IV)

The courtyard gate slams open, and Kai Ying starts toward the kitchen door, wondering if it was the wind or a patient. When she hears a cry, she rushes outside to find the girl from the hospital, Suyin, doubled over in pain near the **kapok tree**. Kai Ying tries to lead the girl inside, but Suyin's legs buckle under her, and she falls to the wet ground. Kai Ying tries to protect Suyin from the rain as Song goes to fetch Wei. Kai Ying has never delivered a baby and she worries about all the things that could go wrong with Suyin's labor. But hasn't lost a patient yet and isn't about to start. While they wait, Suyin tells Kai Ying her name.

The novel just implied that Kai Ying became the daughter Song never had, and Song in turn becomes a surrogate mother for Kai Ying after she married Sheng. No sooner has Song finished considering their mutual adoption than Suyin arrives, in desperate need of a mother of her own. Kai Ying instinctively feels driven to protect and care for the girl, showing her readiness to take on the role of adoptive mother herself.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: WEI (II)

As he helps to carry Suyin inside, a line of poetry springs to Wei's mind: "Even so, the world intrudes." He can't remember where it comes from. He asks a concerned Kai Ying how he can help, and she sends him to fetch a midwife. The mission makes Wei feel strong and important, but the line of poetry still haunts him. He plans to scour his poetry collection to find its poem as he can. By the time he returns with the midwife, the baby has been born.

Instinctively, Wei recognizes that Suyin's arrival signals the end of the precarious balance the Lee family has maintained since Sheng's arrest. But just like her painful and upsetting labor ends in the arrival of a new life, the coming upheaval will ultimately reignite hope among the family members. Going for the midwife reminds Wei of how good it feels to be engaged in purposeful action, an idea that will soon become even more important to Wei.



MOON FESTIVAL, SEPTEMBER 1958: KAI YING (V)

The rain—the first proper monsoon of the year—continues for three days after Suyin gives birth. Kai Ying listens for the baby's cries at night, recalling her terror during the delivery. Suyin, already weak from months of homelessness and begging, lost a lot of blood. She will take weeks to recover, even with the help of Kai Ying's most restorative, strengthening soups. The baby starts to fret and Kai Ying hurries down the hall to pick her up. Despite her low weight, she has strong lungs and seems alert. As Kai Ying cradles her, she realizes that Sheng has been gone for nine months—the length of a pregnancy.

Kai Ying has charitable reasons for letting Suyin and the baby stay in the villa. But she also wants to keep them close because they have given her a glimmer of hope. Despite the odds, the baby seems healthy enough to live; Suyin will recover in time, too. And as Kai Ying measures Sheng's absence in pregnancies, realizing that under different circumstances, the baby in her arms could have been hers and Sheng's rather than a stranger's, she betrays how attached she has already become to the infant.



Kai Ying carries the baby to the kitchen; she must supplement Suyin's meager milk supply with soymilk. She knows Suyin will need weeks to recover enough strength to take care of herself, much less the baby. In the meantime, the household does its best to welcome the child. Kai Ying usually adheres to the traditions her own mother taught her, like protecting a baby from evil spirits by not using its true name for the first two months of its life. But this little baby survived so much just to be born that Kai Ying trusts her strength. Secretly, she decides to call the child the name she would pick for her own daughter, Meizhen, or beautiful **pearl**.

When Kai Ying's own son was born, she followed the traditions her parents taught her. But despite her caution, the Communist Party broke up her family at least as effectively as evil spirits when it spirited Sheng away without a trace. She names the baby after the pearls that she loved at Herbalist Chu's shop because they represented hope to her then—a hope to return home to Zhaoqing. Her wish was fulfilled in an unexpected way when Guangzhou became her home. In this moment, Meizhen represents a different hope, that her family might one day be whole again.



On her way downstairs, with Meizhen drowsing in her arms, Kai Ying steps onto the second-floor balcony where she can see the waning moon shining in the sky. She regrets missing it on the night of the Autumn Moon Festival; unlike Huoyi and Chang'e, she knows her reunions with her husband must wait another year.

The storm clears as Kai Ying begins to discover hope again in the promising life of little infant Meizhen. The Moon Festival promises that things will be made right eventually.



THE WORLD INTRUDES, OCTOBER 1958: TAO (I)

Tao cannot sleep because of his excitement about returning to school in the morning. He breathes deeply, remembering Sheng's claim that if he paid attention, he could smell the changing seasons. He wonders what his father can smell where he is. Finally, Tao gets out of bed. His injured leg remains weak and unsteady, but he refuses to use his crutches anymore. He's tired of waiting for it to strengthen. Slowly and painfully, Tao paces between his bedroom door and his window. He remembers how Sheng would pace the courtyard when he was worried or upset. Tao wishes that his limp would go away; he doesn't want people to look down on him for his limp. He doesn't want to be behind. He's been studying diligently from the homework Little Shan brings him, and he intends to reclaim his second student spot as soon as possible. Suddenly, he feels tired.

Tao may be tired of waiting for his leg to recover, but there's no way to skip this painful healing process. But instead of taking the possibly easier and slower path and using his crutches, Tao chooses to face the challenge head on, limping across the room unsupported. In doing so, he follows in Sheng's footsteps—the footsteps of someone who isn't afraid to face adversity. And Tao differentiates himself from Wei, whose self-imposed isolation keeps him stuck in pain and regret. Still, Tao's injury, like everything else that happens to him, will change him in irrevocable ways.



Tao woke up every time the baby cried last night. He isn't sure how he feels about Suyin and her sudden arrival in his home. It's strange to think about her sleeping in the next room, which used to belong to his great-grandfather's second wife. His room was wife number three's. When he once asked Kai Ying why his great-grandfather had so many wives, she said that if he hadn't had so many wives, neither Wei nor Sheng nor Tao himself would exist.

Initially, Tao resents the arrival of Suyin and Meizhen, who take some of the space and attention that he himself used to enjoy. His reflection on his grandfather's family shows that the idea of "family" changes over time, foreshadowing how Tao's family will continue to grow and change in the coming months.



Tao hears the baby fussing. Kai Ying told him that Suyin is too weak to provide the kind of full-time care babies need. Tao proudly tells himself that he isn't a crying little baby needing full-time care. When Kai Ying appears in the door, he says he got up early to exercise. She embraces her "little man" with pride, then disappears to answer the baby's urgent cries.

At just seven years old, Tao still needs care, love, and attention from his family. But, by acting like a "little man" and facing adversities on his own two feet—both literally and figuratively—he takes strides toward growth and maturity.



THE WORLD INTRUDES, OCTOBER 1958: WEI (I)

Wei doesn't like having Suyin and the baby in his house. He understands Kai Ying's decisions less than he understood his parents' decisions. He remembers once asking his nurse if his mother loved his father. Her answer—that his mother felt a sense of duty, that her family had made a good arrangement for her—confused him. This was especially true after he met Liang, which happened long after his father died without a Lee grandson. Wei splashes water on his face to clear away unpleasant thoughts and prepares to walk Tao to school.

Wei continues the reflection on his father's multiple wives that Tao began in the last section. The family Wei grew up in looked very different from the one he made with Liang or the one he shares now with Kai Ying and Tao. Additionally, Song is a treasured member of the family, though she's not related by blood. Wei's experience suggests that love and sympathy form better foundations for relationships than pure duty. However, he realizes that he has perhaps gone too far the other way, ignoring the duties and responsibilities he has toward his family members.



In the courtyard, Tao says goodbye to Kai Ying, then he limps over and gently lays his hand on the **kapok tree's** scarred trunk. He wants the tree to feel better and he thinks that this will help, since it's a living entity, too. Despite Wei's concerns, Tao insists on walking the whole way to school and they arrive before the gates have even opened. But soon, Little Shan and the other students arrive and Wei leaves.

Tao offers a double example to Wei in this moment, if Wei will pay attention to it: first, Tao moves, and every step he takes brings him closer to physical and emotional healing. Second, his reverence for the kapok tree suggests a sense of mutual obligation. The tree watches over the family and now Tao watches over it as it heals, too.



THE WORLD INTRUDES, OCTOBER 1958: KAI YING

With Tao back in school, Kai Ying makes her first trip in months to the public security administration to see if she can learn anything about Sheng. She sits in the airless waiting room, fretting about the lost business this errand costs her, until a young woman shows her into Comrade Cheng's office. Cheng, a heavysset, sweaty man, pours Kai Ying a cup of weak tea and then sprawls at his desk, staring at her. Haltingly, she explains that she wants to know about Sheng, whom she hasn't heard from in nine months. Cheng says he can't do much to help her, since so many men get sent to the labor camps each day. He asks what she can give him in exchange.

Since Sheng left, Kai Ying has tried to maintain her family's precarious balance essentially by herself: she attends to her patients, earns money, runs the errands, and cares for young Tao and the aged Wei—whose sense of guilt and helplessness makes his needs child-like too. She even tries to look after Sheng from afar. It's clearly too much work for one person to do; fulfilling her obligations towards her husband in this instance pulls her away from other obligations to her patients and to supporting the family as the only breadwinner. She needs others, especially Wei, to take responsibility for their roles in the family.



Kai Ying tries to appeal to Cheng's family responsibility by mentioning Tao. Brusquely, Cheng says that Sheng could have considered his family before writing his counterrevolutionary letter. He looks Kai Ying up and down and makes a thinly veiled suggestion that he will help if she has sex with him. Kai Ying swallows her horror, then offers him an envelope of cash because that is "the way things [are] done." He takes it with the promise that his offer remains open.

The interview with Comrade Cheng points toward the many ways in which the Communist Party disrespects the idea of family, both by splitting families like the Lees up as punishment but also by disregarding the promises and obligations that bring husbands and wives together. Cheng's proposition suggests that he cares only about his own appetites—the charge that reformers made against the Party as a whole during the Hundred Flowers Campaign.



THE WORLD INTRUDES, OCTOBER 1958: SONG

Song holds the baby, afraid to put her down lest she wake up. She hasn't held a baby since Tao, and it feels bittersweet. She never had children of her own. She was pregnant once, but Old Hing punched her in the stomach, leading to a miscarriage at six months. She felt guilty for a long time, believing that she could have done more to protect her baby, a girl. But Song consoled herself with the thought that she would never have to endure having Hing as a father. Suyin wakes up, breaking Song's reverie. Song introduces herself. Suyin asks if she had a girl or a boy. Song says the baby is a girl, placing the baby in Suyin's arms. When the baby begins to fret, Suyin struggles to comfort her and begs Song to take the infant back. Song does, thinking how much Suyin still has to learn about becoming a mother.

Although Song never had her own children, she has been a mother of sorts, filling in parts of Liang's role after her death. Her time at the villa thus redeems some of the pain and suffering of her past; it gives her the loving and supportive family that her own parents and Old Hing denied her. And the story of her miscarriage suggests that, with love, support, and time, people can survive the painful things that happen in their life and also can find happiness and peace. In this moment, Song's contentedness holds out a promise that Suyin may also find a place in the Lee family and a stable, happy life for herself.



THE WORLD INTRUDES, OCTOBER 1958: TAO (II)

At school, Tao finds that much more has changed than he expected. He's ranked below nearly half the class. He struggles to pay attention as his leg grows achy and tired from trying to keep up with the other children. But when Wei asks about the day on their walk home, Tao refuses to complain, or even to answer the questions, afraid that he will burst into tears. He won't admit aloud that nothing has been the same since Sheng left. Auntie Song and Kai Ying welcome Tao with coconut tarts. He answers their questions, hoping to hide his unhappiness. But each day that week is worse than the last.

Tao knows that things haven't returned to their pre-fall normal but he's too proud (or too upset) to admit it to Wei. Consciously or not, he mirrors his grandfather's choice to avoid looking directly at the sources of his difficulty and pain. But rather than making the problems go away, Tao begins to see that this just makes them worse. The pain remains and he won't allow anyone else to help him carry his painful load.



Tao also resents Suyin and the baby, as they take up Kai Ying's time and attention. One morning, as he stands in the kitchen with his mother, Tao can no longer contain his angst. He bursts into tears. Kai Ying asks what's wrong, and he cannot answer. There is so much wrong in his life: he hates school, he hates Suyin, he hates his limp. He hates his classmate, Lai Hing, most of all. Lai Hing has been bullying Tao over his limp. Yesterday, he told everyone that Sheng was sent away as a traitor to the Communist Party. Then, when he and Tao got into a fight, Little Shan intervened—on Lai Hing's side. Tao asks Kai Ying why the police took his father away.

Avoiding the things that are bothering him, from school to Suyin and the baby, doesn't make Tao feel better; in fact, he feels worse and worse until he cannot stand it anymore. With all this going on, Tao finally asks explicitly what happened to Sheng, adding more credence to the novel's insistence that people can only grow when they face difficult things head-on. Now, he has the opportunity to learn the truth and move forward.



THE WORLD INTRUDES, OCTOBER 1958: WEI (II)

Wei senses Tao's distress before he enters the kitchen. As he enters the room, Kai Ying tries to explain what Tao heard about Sheng. Wei realizes that it's time to tell the truth. He steadies himself against the table. Then he asks Tao to explain what happened. Tao says he hates Little Shan, and that Lai Hing told everyone that Sheng was a traitor. Wei asks if Tao thinks Sheng is a traitor, and Tao shakes his head no. Wei says that Tao is correct: Sheng did not write the letter. Then, taking a deep breath and looking to the **kapok tree** for strength, Wei confesses. He wrote the letter.

Wei feels a moment of exhaustion and relief before Kai Ying turns on him. She demands to know why he wrote the letter, asking why he suddenly chose to meddle in the politics he had so scrupulously avoided. Wei has no answer. Kai Ying accuses him of conceit and pride. Then she hurls a teacup against the wall, stunning him with her anger. He's become accustomed to her being the peacemaker. He feels dizzy and breathless, and he longs for a way—any way—to earn forgiveness from her and Tao. As the baby's cries pull Kai Ying from the kitchen, Wei turns to Tao, who stares at his grandfather and says, "I hate you."

The only place Tao can find some source of stability and sure footing is in his broken family. But suddenly, his family doesn't seem so reliable when Wei confesses his dreadful secret. Wei's refusal to take responsibility damaged the family, just as Sheng's arrest did. By acting alone, Wei hurt not just himself but everyone else. He—and the family—will find healing only when Wei addresses the damage he has done.



Wei has spent his life in the villa, surrounded by his family. But he hasn't fully participated in it. First as a coddled only son, then later as an admired husband and feared father-in-law, he has received love and care without having to fully reciprocate. In many ways, his decision to write the letter represents the way he's always lived his life only half connected to his family and unwilling or unable to see the way his decisions affect others. But he cannot escape the grave consequences of his actions.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: KAI YING

That night, Kai Ying stands in the kitchen preparing the ingredients for dinner, her hands moving automatically as her mind races. She doesn't know how she can pretend that nothing has changed when everything has. She now recognizes the guilt that's been slowly consuming Wei over the past year. She understands why Sheng took Wei's place to protect his father, but she cannot forgive Wei's dishonesty, and she doesn't know how she will be able to forgive a man whose pride led him to betray his family.

Since Sheng's arrest, Kai Ying has tried to pretend things are normal to keep her family afloat. In the wake of Wei's confession, she fears she can no longer maintain this illusion. Still, the novel has already suggested that she has been maintaining an illusion: all is not well with the family. Wei's confession forces Kai Ying to accept that not all is well, and it will hopefully open her and the family up to healing.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: TAO

At dinner, Tao refuses to speak to Wei, ignoring his grandfather until his mother chastises him. After dinner, Kai Ying lectures Tao about the respect he owes adults. He wants to know how she can still talk to his traitorous grandfather, but he knows better than to ask.

Tao cannot ignore Wei out of existence any more than Kai Ying can maintain the illusion that things haven't changed. They both try to avoid facing the painful reality of their circumstances: Sheng is gone, and Wei is responsible for it. But only in facing these truths and learning to live with them will anyone find peace.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: SONG (I)

In her garden, Song harvests *yu choy* and *bak choy*, taking less pleasure than usual in the task. She hears a noise, and she looks up, hoping to see Wei coming to visit her. He hasn't come in the two days since Kai Ying told Song about his confession. Song approached Wei in the courtyard that day, chiding him for his unwillingness to forgive himself, reminding him of Sheng's strength. But when she walked away, she still saw despair and sadness in her eyes. And she hasn't seen him since.

Song sees Tao's, Kai Ying's and Wei's pain clearly. But planting and harvest teaches her a comforting lesson: life goes on. Whoever in the family chooses to face and weather the current storm will find themselves stronger and wiser because of it. She tries to offer this wisdom—as well as insight into Sheng's character—to Wei, but he cannot yet face or forgive himself.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: SUYIN (I)

Suyin can't fall asleep. For two weeks after giving birth, she existed in a sleepy haze, barely waking up for long enough to sip some soup or nurse the baby. Now, finally recovering from months of being homeless, she can think clearly. She wonders how much longer she'll be able to stay at the villa—last week, she overheard Kai Ying and Wei arguing downstairs, and she wonders if it was about her. Recently, she's started stealing and hiding away small amounts of food, so she won't starve immediately if they ask her to leave.

The villa has provided Suyin safety and security for the first time in months, if not years. But she remains acutely aware that she doesn't belong to the family and thus has no claim on their ongoing generosity. She cannot yet see the ways in which she can help and support the Lees, and so she cannot yet imagine being counted as part of their family in the way that Song is.



Suyin can still hardly believe that she gave birth to a healthy baby. She rolls onto her side in the dark room, and flashes back to the afternoon that changed her life. She was at home alone, and when she heard the apartment door open, she assumed it was her brothers. But it was her stepfather, the smell of alcohol strong on his breath. He leered at her, then pounced, pinning her to the ground and covering her mouth with his hand so she couldn't scream. When he had finished raping her, he left without a second glance. She longs to see her family again, but she knows that she cannot.

The fact that Suyin can think about her painful past in this moment shows how safe she feels in the protective care of the Lee family. The story of her rape at the hands of her stepfather adds more evidence to the book's assertion that mutual responsibility and love make a family, not just ties of blood and law. Suyin's nuclear family failed her, but the Lees—absolute strangers—could possibly become her new, chosen family.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: WEI (I)

After each long and restless night, Wei leaves the house for an aimless walk, which helps to relieve his angst. He cannot forget the look in Kai Ying's eyes when he confessed; it seemed to suddenly confirm that everything he'd spent his life building meant nothing. This morning, out of habit, his feet carry Wei through the city toward the University. On side streets and in alleyways, he passes old men and women gossiping on their doorsteps, scruffy dogs, and a group practicing *tai chi*. Under a bridge, he finds a middle-aged woman in a bright-red outfit practicing a dance. She snaps a fan open and closed in time with the movements of her feet. Wei knows she could be arrested for such decadent, bourgeoisie behavior, but he finds her precision admirable. He wonders what it would feel like to move through life with such grace and confidence. He walks on.

In the wake of his confession, Wei leaves the villa regularly for the first time in years to avoid Kai Ying and Tao. The book suggests that growth requires movement, and these walks become the first steps of Wei's path to redemption. Even though his daily path remains aimless now, distance from the villa gives him much-needed space for self-reflection, just as Kai Ying's walks to the market gave her the opportunity to consider the things she tried to avoid at home. Wei's encounter with the dancer allows the book to yet again criticize the Chinese Communist Party for its brutal repressions. In the name of rooting out "bourgeoise" or elite decadence, it has made people's lives worse by limiting their ability to express themselves and enjoy simple pleasures like dancing.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: SUYIN (II)

Once again, Suyin can't sleep. In the moonlight, she slips silently downstairs, but this time she heads for the living room. It's where she gave birth, but she didn't take in the room's details at the time. Just as she reaches out to touch a silk-upholstered couch, Wei demands to know what she's doing. In a small voice, she confesses that she is wandering the house because she couldn't sleep. Wei says he is doing the same thing. When he lights the lamp so she can take a proper look, Suyin sees a once-grand room that's now threadbare and worn.

Suyin glances at the portrait of Wei's father above the empty fireplace. Despite their physical similarities, Wei says, they were different in most ways. Most children and parents, he observes, end up feeling that way. Only the lucky find common ground. His evident sadness makes Suyin uncomfortable, and she prepares to go back to her room. But as she climbs the stairs, she reassesses her opinion of Wei. She can imagine a roomful of students held rapt by his calm voice and deep wisdom. She wanted to be a teacher, once. Now she doubts she will ever get to go back to school.

Wei confronts Suyin as if she were a burglar even though the things that make the villa truly valuable to him cannot be stolen—he has already lost Sheng and endangered his relationships with Kai Ying and Tao. The house only holds the faintest whispers of its former glory. The villa itself thus becomes a metaphor for the currently broken Lee family and for China itself as the Communist Party steals its culture and beauty.



As Wei muses on the way that children differ from their parents, he seems to be thinking about his own failures to honor his obligations to his father and his failure to protect his son from harm. In contrast, Sheng showed honor and responsibility when he accepted the Party's punishment to keep Wei from harm. But the book also suggests that families aren't limited to blood relations, and the fact that Wei reminds Suyin of her own buried dreams suggests a similarity between the two that could help them become chosen family members.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: WEI (II)

To his surprise, Wei feels more relief than anger when he finds Suyin in the living room; it's nice to talk to someone who doesn't know about the letter. He knows how much he intimidates her, and he wonders if he always has this effect on people.

Wei's walk the next morning takes him to the harbor. He thinks about the courage it must have taken the sailors of the Ming and Qing dynasties (from the 14th through the 19th centuries) to sail away from home, never knowing for sure if they would return. He thinks about the great rivers that connect the distant corners of China, how they have ferried its treasures from one place to the next for centuries. He wishes Tao were with him, so he could tell his grandson about how powerful and important China once was—and how the color has drained from it since the Communist Party takeover. He wonders if he wrote the letter in part to try to reclaim his past. But glory, wealth, and comfort mean nothing without his family to share them with.

Although he's been distrustful of Suyin thus far, in stumbling on her in the living room, Wei is reminded that relationships with strangers can improve a family—like Song has done. In this case, Suyin helps Wei to see a truth about himself that his family allowed him to ignore: he is an aloof, harsh, and intimidating man who takes more than he gives in relationships.



As Wei walks, he thinks in the terms he knows (and loves) best: Chinese art and history. He realizes that the Lee family was once strong and whole, just as China was once vibrant and powerful. Crucially, in this moment, he finally makes the connection between strength and movement: China was great because brave merchants and sailors risked their lives and livelihoods to trade, explore, and discover the world beyond their hometowns. Their bravery provides a blueprint for Wei's redemption. He cannot singlehandedly restore his country to its former glory. But he can leave his own safe walls and attempt to rebuild the Lee family.



Suddenly, Wei knows what he must do. It's time for him to leave the safe walls of the Guangzhou and the villa, to go *do* something rather than just wait for news. He will go to Luoyang to see Sheng. This won't fix things, but he hopes it will give Kai Ying some peace. For the first time in months, Wei feels a sense of peace himself. He closes his eyes and conjures up the image of Liang, something he hasn't been able to do in weeks. He no longer feels alone.

As Wei resolves to undertake his own journey—not just to help his family, but also to improve himself—he feels a sense of peace. He has grasped two key ideas: growth requires movement, and his only hope for redemption lies in learning to honor the relationships he has with Sheng, Kai Ying, Tao, and even Liang.



AFTER, OCTOBER 1958: SONG (II)

Early one morning, Song watches Wei hurry through the courtyard gate. She almost follows him, curious about where he goes each day, but, looking at her mud-splattered clothes (she's been working in the garden), she decides to stay put. She's still cutting *bak choy* when Kai Ying rushes up to show her the note Wei left, telling the family that he has gone to Luoyang to find Sheng.

Wei realizes that he has asked others to bear the consequences of his decisions for him for far too long. Now, he strives to take responsibility for himself, and by doing so, to show his care and concern for the family he genuinely loves, even if he's had trouble showing it.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (I)

On the last morning of October, Wei walks purposefully through the cool morning air towards the bus station. His life savings are split between two envelopes, one in his jacket pocket, one in his satchel. After years of standing still, it feels good to be in motion. The last time he left Guangzhou was more than 25 years ago, when he delivered a lecture on Sung Dynasty art in Shanghai. He remembers how confident he once felt, sharing his wisdom and knowledge with large audiences. But in the nearly 10 years since his retirement, he's barely left the villa. As the city wakes up, the streets fill with pedestrians and cyclists. Wei particularly delights in the sight of two riders with a mattress tied between their bikes, pedaling in perfect unison.

As Wei relishes the feeling of being in motion, he reflects on just how rooted—how stagnant—he has become. It seems that his personal growth stopped sometime in Sheng's childhood, when he became comfortable and complacent in his life and his relationships. The bicyclists balancing the mattress between them offer a not-so-subtle metaphorical reminder that relationships require balance and mutual, reciprocal action to work, something Wei now begins to understand.



The train and bus depots occupy the same building. People crowd the train side, but the bus side is quieter. Wei asks the attendant if he can take a bus from Guangzhou all the way to Luoyang. The attendant consults his book and replies that Wei can, but it will take three or four days at least, with 22 stops along the way. The train will take half that time, even if it is more expensive. Crossing back into the train station, the noisy, rushing crowds make Wei feel queasy, and he must pause for a moment to collect himself. The train ticket costs nearly a quarter of his savings. He buys it anyway.

Even before Wei leaves the city, it becomes clear that the journey will be far more complex, involved, and challenging than he expected. Only at the station does he begin to truly grasp the distance between himself and Sheng. Still, when Wei decides to spend so much of his money on the train ticket, it highlights that he now believes it's important to reconnect with his son—and the monetary sacrifice is worth it.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (I)

Kai Ying and Auntie Song rush to the train station by pedicab, but Wei's train has left by the time they arrive. Observing that he must travel his own path, Song brings Kai Ying back home. Kai Ying's emotions swing wildly between fear and anger; she worries about Wei's ability to fend for himself in the unpredictable, unsheltered world beyond the villa. She can't imagine losing him, too.

Auntie Song, it seems, has long known the wisdom that Wei has only recently discovered: growth requires movement. Kai Ying knows this, too, though her mixed emotions now prevent her from acknowledging this. Importantly, her anger at Wei arises because she cares about her family members. She doesn't want her family to be separated any more than it already has been.



At dinner, when Kai Ying tells Tao that Wei has gone to visit Sheng, he becomes upset. He wants to see his father, too. But he has school, and the trip of 1,000 miles will take at least two days. Much to Kai Ying's relief, Suyin interrupts her questions and distracts Tao with another conversation. Kai Ying likes Suyin, who has been a big help around the house and who shows interest in the herbal work. But she knows nothing about Suyin's family or her past, and she suspects that Suyin has been stealing food. Still, she finds the thought of anyone else leaving the house suddenly unbearable.

Just when Kai Ying thinks she cannot take any more, Suyin pipes up and takes on some of the burden of helping little Tao manage his emotions. She steps naturally into the role of a big sister—perhaps because she's had practice with her own brothers. But the ease and naturalness with which she steps into the conversation at dinner, or the herbal work with Kai Ying, also shows her forming affectionate ties of her own with the Lee family. Now that she's recovering, she's giving as much into relationships as she gets out of them. However, readers know she is stealing food, and Kai Ying's concern about this suggests there may be problems ahead.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (II)

Wei finds a seat in a half-full car. Across the aisle from him, a thin man sits and chain-smokes. Wei relaxes and closes his eyes, giving into the exhaustion the previous weeks of tension and anxiety have caused him. But the thin man strikes up a conversation, introducing himself as Tian, and guessing correctly that Wei hasn't been on a trip like this in a long time. Tian says he used to travel between Guangzhou and Luoyang frequently to see a girlfriend (later identified as Ai-li) whom he has since lost touch with. He hasn't been back in many years. Wei replies that he's going to see his son, who lives in Luoyang temporarily, without explaining the reason. Silently, he wonders why Tian is going to Luoyang if he lost touch with the girl. But the train brakes abruptly, interrupting his thoughts.

Like Wei, Tian has unfinished business in Luoyang even though readers (and Wei) must wait to learn what happened with Ai-li. The shared experience of loss creates a bond between the two men. In the last decade, during which he has rarely left the villa, Wei has relied on his family to tend to all his social and emotional needs. And because he has chosen not to reciprocate for so long, he now believes himself incapable of fully reciprocating their affection and care. But the ease with which he strikes up a friendship with Tian shows he's still very capable of being a caring friend and family member.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (III)

As the train approaches its first stop, Tian tells Wei that it will give them the opportunity to find something to eat before the next, longer leg. Wei follows Tian to the market gratefully, feeling lucky to have made such a knowledgeable friend. In the market, they eat noodles from a stall and Tian buys some rice alcohol. Then, someone pushes Wei to the ground and runs off. A young man helps him up, patting the dust from his jacket before disappearing into the crowd. Tian offers to share his alcohol on the train. Wei has never been much of a drinker. He used to worry about how much Sheng drank, before he met Kai Ying.

In the car, quieter now that some passengers have disembarked, Wei examines a tear in the sleeve of his jacket from his fall. He thinks how lucky he is to have Song and Kai Ying to repair it when he gets home. Then, he pats down the pocket, suddenly realizing that the young man who allegedly helped him actually picked his pocket. There's nothing he can do about it now, but the warm burn of Tian's shared alcohol takes some of the sting from being robbed. Feeling a stab of homesickness, he realizes it is 3 o'clock, when he usually fetches Tao from school. He drinks so much he feels a little dizzy and drifts off to sleep.

Wei sleeps fitfully, the uncomfortable chair making his back ache, until the next stop. It is much shorter than the first; Tian dashes down to the platform and buys dinner for himself and Wei from the station's food vendors. Wei watches him through the window, marveling again at how quickly they've forged a friendship. Something about Tian's sadness feels familiar to Wei, like they are both lost souls. Tian accepts Wei's thanks for the food, but not his money, so Wei insists he will buy the next meal. After dinner, as he watches other passengers pull pillows and blankets from their luggage, Wei realizes just how unprepared he is for the long trip. As he settles himself to try and sleep, he calculates the distance in his head. By the morning, he will have traveled well over 500 miles from home.

Wei sees only his own needs, so he focuses on what Tian does for him (helping him navigate the train journey) rather than realizing what he does for Tian: that is, providing companionship and distraction from sadness. Note that while it seems very much like Wei has been pickpocketed, he doesn't notice this. This highlights how sheltered he's been and suggests this will be a difficult trip for him.



The fact that Wei immediately imagines Kai Ying or Song repairing his jacket—even though they will be miles away by morning—shows how coddled and protected he has been in his family. His few responsibilities seem mainly to include walking Tao to and from school; he assumes that someone else will take care of everything bigger, more important, or more complicated than that. Still, he doesn't face the harsh realities of the world completely alone: his fast-growing friendship with Tian provides solace and reminds him that relationships make life's burdens easier to bear.



At first, it seems like Tian's and Wei's friendship might veer into the same unequal territory of Wei's family relationships. But while Wei feels grateful for Tian's help, he doesn't take Tian's actions for granted. The sadness he senses in Tian suggests that this man, too, has suffered great losses. And it offers hope that Wei might also learn to be a better, more generous person as he acknowledges and learns more about Tian's pain. Importantly, Wei makes it clear that he will not allow the inequality in this relationship to persist; he insists on returning Tian's generosity in kind.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (II)

Kai Ying cannot sleep because of her concerns about Wei. She worries that he's cold and achy. She hopes he brought the ginger rub she made for his sore back, and although she wants to search his room for it, this feels like too great an invasion of his privacy. She thinks she hears footsteps in the hall. This reminds her of the ghost stories Wei told her when she first arrived at the villa. He claims that it's haunted by two of his family's old servants. Kai Ying cannot imagine having servants. Of course, the Communist Party outlawed the practice as contrary to its ideology of freedom and equality. But even freed from bourgeois bondage, people don't have enough rice or oil or coal.

Despite her anger over Wei's actions—both writing the letter and letting Sheng take the blame for it—Kai Ying loves and cares for her father-in-law, and she cannot stop herself from worrying about him. She already moves towards forgiveness, something that will help her family heal. The idea of family servants points towards some of the positive changes made by the Communist Party, which outlawed servitude and slavery. But, with mismanagement and repression, the Party risks replacing these old injustices with new ones—as evidenced by the labor camp where Sheng is now imprisoned.



Wei told Kai Ying that his family's servants, Sun (the cook) and Moon (the housekeeper) lived in Auntie Song's apartment. By the time he was in school, they were middle-aged and had been working at the villa for decades. They never agreed on anything. But when Moon fell ill, Sun devoted herself to caring for the housekeeper, and she never recovered after Moon died. Wei has never seen their ghosts, but he told Kai Ying that he often felt their presence in the house. Kai Ying yawns and rolls over, trying to clear her mind. But she thinks about Tao asking if she's ever been to Luoyang. She's never been farther than her home village of Zhaoqing. She wonders if she would have been brave enough to board the train with Wei.

The story about Moon and Sun shows how disagreement and love are not mutually exclusive. Although the servants fought, they clearly shared a deep and important bond, one that sustained both. And when Moon's death broke that bond, Sun was irrevocably changed. Their names position them as opposites who balanced each other out and suggest that a family's strength comes in part from bringing together people with different strengths and weaknesses in such a way that they balance each other out—as Sheng's energy inspires Wei and Wei's reserve teaches Sheng to accept what he cannot change about his situation.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (IV)

On the train, neither Wei nor Tian can sleep. To pass the time, Tian tells the rest of his sad story. He met his girlfriend, Ai-li, in 1946 when they were both students and she visited a friend in Guangzhou. For Tian, it was love at first sight. Although the early years of their relationship were full of difficulty, the challenges of living far apart and the disruptions of the Chinese Civil War made their time together seem sweeter. But by the time Tian graduated and moved to Luoyang, Ai-li had already become deeply involved in the Communist Party. Tian resisted joining despite Ai-li's encouragement. He struggled to find work and adapt to life in Luoyang. They argued.

Tian and Ai-li's relationship bridges the time just before and just after the Chinese Communist Party took control of the government. At first, they seem to meet in an auspicious, promising moment of change and possibility. But as Ai-li becomes involved in Party politics, it soon becomes clear that Maoist China asks people to choose between the Party—and the power and status membership potentially represents—and other relationships. Instead of offering more choices to the newly freed Chinese people, the Party instead limits them.



Finally, Tian got a good job offer in Guangzhou. He was excited: it meant that Ai-li could return with him, and they could have the house and the family they'd dreamed of during their early courtship. But Ai-li now denounced those dreams as childish, bourgeois fantasies. Then suddenly, she seemed to relent. She stopped going to Party meetings and promised to follow Tian to Guangzhou as soon as she settled her affairs in Luoyang. He left to prepare for their life together. Now, Tian admits, he was foolish to believe her. But then, he was young and in love. Three months after he left, Ai-li finally sent word that she was coming to Guangzhou. But when he went to meet her train, she was not on it, or any of the ones that followed it. It took Tian hours to realize she wasn't ever coming.

Tian still doesn't know what happened but one detail about their final goodbye still haunts him: after he got on the train at Luoyang, Ai-li walked away and disappeared into the crowd without turning around for a final goodbye glance. Tian looks past Wei, as if he's searching for her through the darkened window. Although he suspects Ai-li chose to disappear while Sheng had no choice, Wei recognizes Tian's desperation all too well. He, too, knows the horrible feeling of sudden loss. Pulling his jacket around him, Wei reflects on how harsh the world can be for brokenhearted men.

Tian imagined a life with Ai-li similar to the one that Wei and Liang or Sheng and Kai Ying had, but Ai-li makes it clear that this old-fashioned—and by implication, elitist and bad—lifestyle has no value under Communist Party rule. This points to the ways that the Party takeover serves to weaken society rather than strengthen it. Like Wei, Tian suffers grief and guilt in the wake of Ai-li's disappearance, and his life is destroyed by the Communist Party. However, although facing the pain of her loss wasn't easy, Tian survived it and came out on the other side with greater wisdom about himself and others.



Even if he didn't acknowledge it, Tian realized that his goodbye with Ai-li was final when she failed to look back at him—her face was already turned towards her separate future and towards her Party loyalty. In contrast, Wei's family didn't allow him to leave without a second glance; Kai Ying and Auntie Song even followed him to the train station. Wei worries that he has lost their love and trust, though readers know he hasn't. And Tian's story makes him realize some of his own luck: Tian doesn't seem to have a soul in the world who means anything to him other than Ai-li. While Wei hasn't always treated his family the best, he still has several people who love and care about him.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (III)

When Kai Ying goes downstairs, she finds Suyin rummaging in the kitchen cupboards. She tells Suyin that she only needs to ask for what she needs. Suyin promises not to steal any more food. Kai Ying returns to her bed, where she tosses and turns, worrying now about Suyin in addition to Wei and Sheng. She likes the girl but knows that she won't be able to let her stay if she can't trust her. She hopes that giving her a second chance was the right choice.

Suyin steals food because she fears losing the villa's protection. Ironically, her actions to protect herself make that outcome more likely. Similarly, Wei's fear of his family's anger led him to keep his role in Sheng's arrest silent, making the betrayal worse when Kai Ying and Tao found out. Neither Wei nor Suyin sees family as a source of forgiveness and redemption yet. But Kai Ying's kind heart makes her generous with her second chances and offers hope that the family will find some resolution.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: SONG

Song hasn't been so stressed since Old Hing died. She never told anyone how he really died, not even Liang. But soon after she met Kai Ying at Herbalist Chu's shop, she returned and asked for something to help with her "rat problem." It was easier than she expected to poison Old Hing; she sprinkled the provided herbs on his dinner and within days he was bedridden and struggling to breathe. She remembers him staring at her, trying to figure out if she'd had the courage to murder him. She saw him conclude that she was too weak, so she whispered a confession in his ear, ensuring he died knowing it was because of her. Their neighbors all chose to accept that the 85-year-old man had died of natural causes. She waited for someone to accuse her, but no one did.

Song usually compartmentalizes feelings of dread and despair, but she cannot keep her concern for Wei under control. She prays to the goddess Kuan Yin for his safety. She chides herself for failing to stop him or talk sense into him before he left. She tells herself that he's a smart man and will find his way, but she struggles to believe it. She worries that in letting him go, she has let Liang down.

Readers now learn that Song came by her resilience and strength by surviving truly terrible circumstances. When she counsels Kai Ying or Wei to trust that things will turn out as they should, or to patiently face their current trials, she knows what she's talking about. That her marriage was so terrible that she felt compelled to murder her husband, meanwhile, highlights that marriage doesn't make a supportive family. Rather, people become family when they choose to support one another. This is why Song is now a valued member of the Lee family, despite not being related to any of them.



Song understands the importance of acting for survival and for personal growth. But she has deeper reserves of strength than Wei, who has been sheltered by his family throughout his entire life. Stuck at home, neither Song nor Kai Ying know that he has found a friend—a source of support and a means of redemption—in Tian.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (V)

Wei sleeps fretfully on the train, dreaming that he's made Liang angry. Only one of their arguments ever lasted for more than a few hours. Just before the Communist Party took over, he lied to her to avoid going to a political rally. He didn't want to risk upsetting his comfortable life of academic research. He hoped Liang wouldn't go alone and she hadn't. But she resented his unwillingness to support her. The sky beyond Wei's window lightens as dawn approaches. As he crosses the halfway point of his journey, his thoughts turn from home toward Sheng. When the train pulls into Linxiang, he and Tian disembark and eat a warm breakfast at the train station before reluctantly climbing aboard for the next leg of the trip.

By refusing to support Liang's one attempt to take a political stand, Wei failed to reciprocate the love and support she showed him. Thus, it's possible to interpret his choice to write the letter as a way to redeem himself for this mistake, to belatedly give voice to Liang's beliefs. But in doing so, he made a second, almost identical mistake. He acted alone even though his choices affected Sheng and Kai Ying. As Wei travels north, it becomes clear that he has made the same mistake over and over and that he has much to make up for with this journey.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: TAO

Tao sits in his classroom, but he can't pay attention. He thinks about Wei, worrying about his grandfather's tendency to close his eyes and withdraw into himself. Something might happen while Wei isn't paying attention. Tao pleads silently, "Don't close your eyes" over and over. He thinks about how much he hates school, where the children tease him for his limp. He thinks about how much his leg still hurts, how much he wants to be rid of the limp before Wei and Sheng come home. His only solace is tormenting Little Shan, something he can do now that he's climbed up the class ranks to sit in the third seat. He can poke Little Shan into squirming and getting in trouble with the teacher or stick mean notes on his back. He can't tell any of this to his mother, who would chide him for bad behavior. He saves his stories for his father and grandfather.

Like his mother, Tao worries about Wei's ability to survive in the world beyond the villa. His concern contradicts his claim to hate his grandfather; the strong family bonds of the Lee family create space for forgiveness and love, no matter what mistakes a member makes. In fact, the more things change in Tao's world, like the loss of his former place at school, the more he clings to his family for stability and security. With both Sheng and Wei gone, Tao must wait for the support he needs to work through his emotions in this trying time of his life. Still, despite their physical distance, their shared love of stories unites Tao to his father and grandfather.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: SUYIN

Suyin puts her baby down for an afternoon nap. It frightens her to think about where they would be without Kai Ying's generosity. She feels stupid and angry with herself for threatening her security by stealing food. Nervously, she fingers her cheeks. The angry acne that once covered them is drying up, thanks to a special cream Kai Ying made for her. Suyin remains fascinated with Kai Ying's skills as an herbalist, the way she calls forth the magic power of nature with an expertly blended soup or tea. Suyin knows she must find a way to make things right again.

Like Wei—and like all people, as Song pointed out earlier—Suyin makes mistakes. Problems arise, the novel suggests, when a person refuses to forgive themselves or others. For instance, Wei tortures himself with regret over how he could have treated Liang and Sheng differently, but he has no power to change the past. He can only try to make better, more responsible choices in the present. Likewise, Suyin intuitively understands that she cannot undo her mistake, but must look for a way to make things right in the present. And she hopes, with a feeling bordering on desperation, that Kai Ying will be willing to forgive her again.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (VI)

As the train leaves yet another small town, Wei asks Tian if he ever found Ai-li. Tian says that he went to Luoyang after she failed to arrive in Guangzhou, only to discover that she'd already left her boardinghouse. He rented her old room. He reported her missing and asked her Communist Party friends about her. But in two weeks of desperate searching, he never found a trace of her. To this day, he thinks it would have been easier if they had married and then grown to hate each other; her sudden disappearance made it hard for him to find closure. He hopes this trip will help him to say a proper goodbye to that part of his life. Suddenly realizing that Tian might be one of the few people who could understand the ghosts that compel him, too, Wei begins to tell his own story.

Tian's trip to Luoyang represents yet another failed attempt to return to the past—something he can't do any more than Wei or Tao or anyone else. Ai-li was long gone in spirit by the time he left Luoyang; her physical disappearance only completed the process. He still wants to revisit and change the past, even as he seems to have realized the impossibility of this wish. Only facing his pain and finding hope for the future can calm his grief. By helping Wei, Tian finds solace in companionship—especially as Wei confirms the intimacy and importance of their new friendship by telling his sad tale.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: TAO (II)

In Wei's absence, the task of telling Tao a bedtime story falls to Kai Ying. She only reads to him from books, where his grandfather often told stories from memory or made them up. Wei thinks about his grandfather's soothing voice as he taught Tao about history, and he realizes suddenly how much Wei must have missed being a teacher. He realizes how lucky he is to be his grandfather's last student. Sometimes, Wei would read from his secret books, the ones the Communist Party forbids, like *The Arabian Nights* or [The Three Musketeers](#). Suddenly, Tao worries that he might never learn where Wei hides these treasures.

Tao wants Sheng back, but not badly enough to risk losing Wei. He longs for the return of normalcy. He regrets not apologizing to Wei for his harsh words before his grandfather left, but Tao didn't know what to say. Now everything is different yet again. Tao watches Kai Ying choosing a book. She teaches him right and wrong, how to behave, and how to take care of himself. He used to ask why he needed to learn how to take care of himself, since he had his mother, father, and grandfather to take care of him. They wouldn't always be there, his mother told him. Now he longs to tell her that he's not ready to care for himself yet. He wants to ask why his father and grandfather both left before he was ready.

The issue of the bedtime story emphasizes yet again that Kai is trying to do something impossible. She cannot keep things the same as they were before; Wei's and Sheng's absences make a very big difference in the family's life and trying to ignore this only seems to magnify everyone's suffering. Nor can she keep the family together by herself. She needs the rest of the family to support her efforts. She needs Sheng and Wei as much as they need her.



Again, Tao's musings show that he doesn't really hate his grandfather, that Wei's absence is nearly as painful as Sheng's. Tao can muddle through his current difficulties at school and in his recovery better when he has a loving, supportive family. Earlier, he took pride in telling himself that he wasn't a baby that needed constant care. But now he realizes that no one ever grows out of needing the love and support of others—not Tao, not Sheng, and not even the elderly Wei. However, Kai Ying's insistence that Tao needs to learn to care for himself also suggests that she doesn't want Tao to become exactly like his grandfather: dependent entirely on others without caring for them in return.



STORIES, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (IV)

It's been three anxious, exhausting days since Wei left. Kai Ying knows even Auntie Song is worried; she stops by several times a day for news. Now, as she tries to pick a book for Tao, he asks her to tell him a story about her life instead. She isn't sure what to say—storytelling has always been Sheng's and Wei's expertise, not hers. But she tries anyway. She tells Tao that the name of the city where she grew up, Zhaoqing, means City of Happiness. Now, her city of happiness is Guangzhou, because that is where she lives with Tao, his father, and his grandfather. Tao asks if his mean words made Wei leave, but Kai Ying assures him that his grandfather loves him too much to stay hurt, no matter how many mean words Tao used.

Tao wants Kai Ying to take Wei's place, to tell him a story from memory rather than read it to him. He wants her to maintain the illusion that nothing has changed, something she has been trying—and failing—to do since Sheng's arrest. And, because the task is impossible, she fails at it here. But she shows her strength in other ways: unlike Wei, Sheng, and Tao, she left her home in Zhaoqing and found a new family in Guangzhou.



As she tucks him into bed, Kai Ying tells Tao a story, one her father told her when she was about his age. Once, she tells him, a magical white **pearl** fell from heaven and turned into a beautiful lake. But the pearl was so beautiful that the white jade dragon and the golden phoenix followed it to earth, turning themselves into the mountains that surround the lake. Then, people built the city of Zhaoqing around the lake and mountains. The end. Immediately, she realizes she told the story badly; it was too short and plain. When Tao tells it back to her, embellishing it in all the right places, she realizes he inherited Wei's and Sheng's storytelling gifts. As he finishes, Kai Ying promises to take the family to see Zhaoqing's mountains when Wei and Sheng have returned. They'll even take Suyin, Song, and the baby. Tao smiles in delight.

Kai Ying tells a magical story about love and devotion—a story that resonates with the Lee family, who struggle to maintain their connections even as circumstances threaten to tear them apart. But she tells it in her own, realistic, simple style, not as the grand myth or legend it would become in Wei's hands. Tao wanted Kai Ying to take on his father's or grandfather's role, but when he retells her story, he shows off the storytelling talent he shares with Sheng and Wei. Just a few pages earlier, he longed for their return because he didn't feel ready to take care of himself. But as he learns to face the world, it becomes clear that he's stronger, more resilient, and readier than he realizes. And when Kai Ying imagines the family trip to Zhaoqing, she includes everyone who has become important to her and Tao, not just their blood relatives but their adopted family members Song, Suyin, and Meizhen. Their futures have become inextricably intertwined.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: TAO (I)

Much to Tao's surprise, despite Sheng's and Wei's absences, normal life continues. Kai Ying still cares for her patients, he still goes to school, Auntie Song still tends the garden, and Suyin and her baby become comfortable in the house. His world has become a world of women. Only when he sees the strong, tall **kapok tree** in the courtyard does he feel close to his father and grandfather.

Tao's definition of "normal" changes as he realizes that he cannot escape pain and suffering or return things to the way they were. His life gets easier as he accepts the places of continuity instead of focusing on the areas of change. And in Wei's absence, the family finds equilibrium by welcoming Suyin and the baby. The kapok tree stands over it all, gently reminding Tao of his absent father and grandfather.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING

A few days after Kai Ying discovered Suyin stealing food, she comes down in the morning to find the girl waiting in the kitchen. Suyin apologizes for taking the food, explaining her terror at the prospect of ending up on the streets again. She takes all the stolen food out of her sack and places it on the table. Realizing she can't imagine how hard Suyin's life must have been, Kai Ying silently fills the bag all the way and hands it back to the girl, telling her to keep it so that she will never feel worried. Then, she opens the courtyard gate to her first patient.

Like Wei, Suyin realizes that she's made a terrible mistake. Ignoring it won't help, nor can she undo the original action of stealing the food. Instead, she redeems herself in Kai Ying's eyes by choosing honesty—and Kai Ying chooses to forgive. And even without all the details, Suyin discloses enough about her past to remind Kai Ying that there's a lot to be grateful for, despite her own difficulties.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (I)

The train arrives in Luoyang just after dawn. As Wei steps down, he notices the dry, cold, mountainous terrain. He pulls his padded jacket tighter around himself. Tian descends behind Wei, scanning the platform with desperate hope in his eyes. For a second, Wei hopes that Ai-li will appear, bringing a happy resolution to Tian's sad tale. But of course, she doesn't. Tian leads Wei to the street.

Luoyang has been a place of darkness and desolation in Wei's imagination, so he is surprised to discover that it's just a city like any other. A woman, passing by with her child, makes him homesick for Tao and Kai Ying. Tian takes Wei to a noodle shop, ordering for him because he struggles to follow the sing-song tones of the local Mandarin accent. Tian learned Mandarin when he moved to Luoyang years earlier.

After lunch, Tian takes Wei to the public security bureau to ask about Sheng. Wei once again feels overwhelming gratitude for Tian, who did not judge him harshly about the letter or Sheng taking the blame. Many people wait at the bureau. At the counter, Clerk Hu gives Wei a form to fill out and tells him to return the next day; it will take time—days, weeks, maybe even months—to locate Sheng's file. Wei tries unsuccessfully to intimidate the clerk until Tian guides him from the office. By the time they arrive at Tian's old boardinghouse, it's cold and dark. Wei teeters on the edge of despair, trying not to think too far into the future, trying to concentrate on just the very next step. He falls into a deep, dreamless sleep on his narrow cot.

WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: TAO (II)

After three days without news from Wei, Tao is tired of waiting. After school, he leaves the protection of his grandfather's favorite courtyard spot, on the bench under the **kapok tree**, heading out of the gate with two coins stolen from Kai Ying's dresser in his pocket. He won't risk Mr. Lam's sweetshop, as he's afraid of being escorted home again like before. He plans to go to the shop on the far side of the park, even though Sheng once told him a warning story about a little boy who went to the park alone and never came out. But now, Tao tells himself, he's old enough. And if he wanders off, it's his father's and grandfather's fault for leaving him unattended. Telling himself that he will be safe if he stays on the path, he enters the park.

It seems that both Wei and Tian are romantics at heart, and neither can give up all hope that Tian will get a fairy-tale happy ending. But, of course, they live in a world where bad things happen all the time and people must learn to muddle through as well as they can on their own—or with the support of their chosen families.



Wei expected Luoyang to be a hellish, nightmare landscape but it is a town like any other, suggesting that bad things happen everywhere, and the Communist Party's abuses reach every corner of the country they control. The differing accents remind Wei of just how far he has traveled from home. But the care Tian shows towards Wei softens Wei's loneliness just a bit, highlighting that the nourishing relationships of family can be found or forged in many ways and places.



To redeem himself, Wei needed to take on the difficult journey to Luoyang alone—to show Kai Ying and Sheng that he feels sorry for what happened and also to prove that they can trust him to fulfil his responsibilities to the family going forward. But his isolated and sheltered life leaves him unprepared for the task he set himself. Luckily, he has Tian as a guide and support while he develops the strength to take care of himself. Wei's journey to Luoyang thus highlights the necessity of movement to a person's growth, as well as the necessity of relationships to support a person through life.



A series of losses characterizes Tao's recent life experience: Sheng, Little Shan, and Wei have all, in one way or another, abandoned him. Hurt and angry, Tao sets out to prove that he doesn't need their care anyway, but of course, he still does. In a way, his attempt to prove his maturity represents his last attempt to run away from the painful truth rather than to face it: he wants to prove that his losses don't hurt him when of course they do, and he must acknowledge that pain for it to become manageable and for it to teach him anything.



People fill the park in the late afternoon sunshine, their presence giving Tao confidence. But soon the path leads him into a more densely wooded area. He feels nervous when the path splits and he doesn't know which way to go. A soldier appears behind him, asking where Tao is headed. Tao says he's going to the store to buy things for his mother, nervously fingering the coins in his pocket. Then, he realizes the man isn't a soldier at all. The man offers to show Tao something, and Tao runs away as the man opens his coat, holding his genitals in his hand.

The transformation of the dangerous stranger from a soldier—a representative of the government and a symbol of protection—into an exhibitionist suggests Tao's distrust of the Communist Party, which has broken his family apart. It also metaphorically condemns the party for failing to protect China and its people from danger and harm during its early rule. And, on a broader level, the journey shows Tao how much growing up he still must do before he can actually fend for himself in the world.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: SONG

When Song hears a knock on her door, she opens it to find Suyin. Suyin and Kai Ying are looking for Tao, and Suyin wants to know if Song has seen him. Song feels a stab of worry. Then she hears voices in the courtyard. Assuming Kai Ying has found Tao, she and Suyin go outside to find Kai Ying holding a telegram from Wei. As they read the news of his safe arrival in Luoyang, the gate opens again and a sweaty and tearful Tao rushes in. Wordlessly, he limps to his mother, places two coins in her hand, and goes inside.

The arrival of Wei's telegram almost outweighs Tao's return home from his trip. This links the two events together and suggests that Tao's short, local trip is just as important to his character development and growth as Wei's longer quest is to Wei's development. And, since the book dwells on the similarities between Wei, Sheng, and Tao, the boy's return auspiciously foreshadows his grandfather's and holds out the promise that one day, his father will walk back through those gates, too.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: TAO (III)

After his trip to the park, Song walks Tao to school in the morning and Suyin walks him home in the afternoon. Secretly, Tao likes coming home with Suyin, who doesn't make a fuss over him. She doesn't make him talk if he doesn't want to, and she helps him out—taking his bag or slowing her pace when his leg is tired—without making a fuss about it. In crowded areas, she holds on to his sleeve to keep him close. She doesn't know how much he appreciates that.

With his trip across the park, Tao intended to prove to himself and his family that he could be independent. But it had the opposite effect, underlining his dependence on others for safety and protection—after all, he remains an inexperienced young child. And that's how Song treats him. But not Suyin, who watches over him protectively, but also respectfully, without encroaching on the small measure of independence and privacy he possesses. She takes on an increasingly familial—and increasingly welcome—role in Tao's life, because she treats him more like Wei treated him.



On this afternoon, unexpectedly, Suyin asks where Tao went on the afternoon he disappeared. Tao says he was just taking a walk, but Suyin points out that he looked like he was running away from something when he returned. After a moment, he decides to answer her question, but he realizes she's no longer at his side. He turns to find her frozen on the corner, staring down the street. She doesn't say what she's looking at and when he follows her gaze, he just sees a busy street filled with people: a grandmother and grandchild, two boys in front of a store, an arguing couple. Finally, Suyin shakes herself and tells Tao that the two boys are her brothers.

As she's shown Tao respect, Suyin has earned his trust and started to earn his affection. Now, she and Tao each entrust the other with one of their deepest secrets, and this shared knowledge confirms and strengthens the bond between them. This allows Suyin to become closer to the Lee family on the whole, and continues to suggest that like Auntie Song, she'll become a chosen member of the family.



Later that afternoon, Tao stands outside Suyin's room, full of curiosity about her family and renewed empathy for her loneliness. When she invites him, he joins her and the baby in the room. They talk a little about the baby, about how Suyin needs to give her a name. She asks Tao for ideas, but the only thing he has ever named was a stray cat that wandered into their courtyard when he was younger. He named it "Mao," after the Chinese word for "cat"—not after the Communist Party chairman. He cried when it disappeared. Now he worries that Suyin and her baby will just disappear, too. Promising to think about names, he backs out of the room.

In this moment, Suyin clearly becomes a member of the household rather than a stranger in Tao's mind. The intimacy of the request to help name the baby reflects this shift in Tao's and Suyin's relationship, while Tao's flash of concern that the baby and Suyin will disappear reflects the recent, traumatic string of disappearances in his life. And it shows that he already considers her a valuable member of his family, one he's afraid to lose.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (II)

Wei wakes up in the boardinghouse, momentarily disoriented. Then he hears Tian's soft snoring, and he remembers that he's in Luoyang. The bed seems the right size for a child, like Tao. The thought of his grandson brings tears to Wei's eyes. When he was Tao's age, China was a different country, a country that could have caught up with the rest of the world. A country the Communist Party hated, condemned, and destroyed. One that Tao will never know except through stories and art. In the dim morning light, the room is even dingier than Wei remembered. He looks around dismally until Tian rises and begins to boil water for their morning tea.

Wei misses Tao. But Tao also reminds Wei of the opportunities Tao—and the country—have lost with the Communist Takeover. Generally, children represent the future. But for Wei, Tao tends to represent the past, either in the form of Wei's regrets about the choices he made with Sheng or in the form of Wei's fears for the future of the country as it rapidly tries to forget its past. But then Tian prepares the small comfort of morning tea. Yet again, in the face of almost overwhelming sorrow and loss, a relationship provides hope.



For breakfast, Wei and Tian share food that Wei bought in Guangzhou on the morning he left. Wei thanks Tian. He now realizes how unprepared for the trip he was and doesn't know how he would have made it without Tian's help. Tian accepts Wei's thanks, saying he knew that there was a reason for him to return to Luoyang just then. He's glad to know that something good will come out of his trip. As Wei watches Tian clear the table, he thinks about how much time he's spent trying to save the past. Now he looks to the future, ready to give whatever remains of his life for Sheng's benefit.

By offering some of his own food to Tian, Wei makes a reciprocal gesture confirming the importance of their relationship. Tian assures him that they have both benefitted, albeit in different ways: Wei has received the help he desperately needed to navigate the world outside the villa, while Tian has found peace and closure in helping reunite Wei with Sheng. In this small way, Tian defies the Communist Party's ability to break up relationships.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: TAO (IV)

Tao hears a noise and looks up to see Suyin standing in his doorway. She wants to know what he thinks of the name Meizhen—the name Kai Ying uses when she thinks Suyin can't hear her—for the baby. Tao, happy that Suyin trusts his opinion, says he likes it.

With Tao ready to accept Suyin and her baby into the family as valued and important members, their adoption is complete. Sheng and Wei will return to find an expanded and stronger family unit.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: SUYIN

Once or twice a week, Auntie Song or Kai Ying send Suyin on errands. Now that she lives there, she no longer looks on the Dongshan neighborhood as some sort of paradise. She sees the cracks in the walls and knows that the residents have problems, just like the families in Old Guangzhou. She feels both sad and relieved at this loss of innocence. But she's also grateful: she doesn't know what would have happened if she hadn't reached the villa before Meizhen was born.

Kai Ying wants a lean piece of pork—a key ingredient in most of her medicinal soups—and Suyin buys it from a vendor who once took pity on her when she was a beggar. Back then, the vendor gave her a bag of soup bones, even though Suyin had no way to make soup. She'd gnawed on the bones and sucked the marrow from them anyway before giving the leftovers to a hungry dog. Sometimes, Suyin wonders if anyone at the market recognizes her. They would have to have a keen eye to see the starving, pregnant beggar anymore in the healthy young mother.

Then, Suyin walks toward Old Guangzhou. Seeing her brothers made her long for her mother, and if she hurries, she thinks she might be able to catch a glimpse of her leaving the apartment for work. Suyin hasn't set foot in her neighborhood in eight months. She hides behind a pillar across the street from her family's apartment building and tries to calm herself as she watches the morning foot traffic pick up. When her mother appears at the door, looking older and thinner, but smiling, Suyin begins to move, starts to call out. But then she sees her stepfather following her mother out of the door. The ugly memories of her rape come flooding back. Nauseated, she sags against the pillar. She knows she can never go home again.

Suyin realizes that the neighborhood has its share of troubles—no one can escape pain and suffering. Still, she's safer and happier here than she's been in a long time because she's finally found a loving and supportive family who appreciate what she contributes and who take care of her in turn.



As Suyin remembers her period of homelessness, it becomes clear how perilously close to death she came. Although people took pity on her, without knowing Suyin and understanding her context—without the kind of intimate knowledge only available through close relationships, in other words—no one could give her what she really needed. Now, safe with the Lees, she has become a different person in both spirit and physical appearance.



The love Suyin feels with the Lees makes her nostalgic for her blood family, and she makes one final attempt to return to them. But seeing her stepfather reminds her that she can never go home. She can never return to the past—to the time before her stepfather raped her, changing her life forever. She can only find hope and peace by facing the truth of her experiences and choosing to invest in a family that truly cares for her wellbeing and happiness.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (II)

The long, dark, lonely nights are the hardest for Kai Ying. In the light of day, she can maintain the illusion that things are normal. But at night, she feels the full weight of her anxiety. The family has had no news since Wei's telegram arrived last week. She tries not to let herself hope for news about Sheng. Sometimes, she can almost feel his body next to hers, and it frightens her to consider that she may never be close to him again. She wonders if they'll recognize each other; the past year has put their lives on separate trajectories for the first time since they met. She has no herbs that can fix this pain or bring back the time they've lost.

Kai Ying has been trying to pretend that nothing has happened—she doesn't talk about Sheng's arrest, she does her best to ensure that Tao will make a perfect recovery, and she even pretends that nothing has changed after she learns of Wei's role in Sheng's arrest. But things have changed, as she invariably acknowledges in the dark of night or when she leave the villa on errands. Trying to avoid her pain only makes it worse.



Kai Ying hears Meizhen crying briefly, then silence. She loves having a baby in the house; it makes her hopeful for the future. She wonders how different her life would be if her second baby had lived. It—her miscarriage happened so early she never knew if it was a boy or girl—would have been three now. She tries to remind herself of how much she has to be grateful for, but still feels uncharacteristic self-pity.

Meizhen and Suyin give Kai Ying hope for the future because they remind her that good can come from the darkest circumstances. Their survival against terrible odds reminds Kai Ying that she, too, can survive what life gives her. And, as chosen family, they enrich her life and fill in the gap left by her miscarriage.



WAITING, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (III)

Each day for days, Wei sits on a hard bench at the public security bureau, waiting for news of Sheng. His back aches and he feels perpetually cold in Luoyang's frigid northern climate. Tian keeps him company most of the time, but occasionally he leaves to go on walks. Wei can't blame him—he, too is tired of waiting—but at this moment, he wishes his friend would return to ease his loneliness. Wei closes his eyes, but his despair and the noisy hallway prevent him from conjuring up Liang. The length of the search worries him—if Sheng were there in Luoyang, Wei wonders, wouldn't it be easy to find him?

The inhumanity of the Communist Party bureaucracy comes into focus as Wei endures a dayslong wait for news. He doesn't even know if his son is alive, and the Party clearly doesn't care about the pain and suffering that causes him—in fact, as Comrade Cheng told Kai Ying earlier in Guangzhou, that secondary suffering is one of the points of the punishment. The whole family suffers for the counterrevolutionary's supposed crime.



From Clerk Hu, Wei knows that the process involves locating Sheng then getting permission for him to have a visitor. And he knows there are other people ahead of him in line. After their first encounter, Wei changed tactics; now he's scrupulously polite to Clerk Hu. Tian teases him about this, but he, like everyone, recognizes the importance of respecting Party authorities. Wei continues to be amazed by how easily he fell into friendship with Tian. He tells Tian an adage about the wise adapting themselves to circumstances like water to a pitcher. He confides that he spent most of his life as the pitcher. Only now, in his old age and these dire circumstances, can he see the wisdom of being the water and molding himself to fit the shape of his circumstances.

At first, Wei tended to treat Clerk Hu as he has treated everyone else in his life—as someone who exists to take care of Wei's needs. But by leaving the villa, he learns that the world doesn't revolve around him. And the more he acknowledges that truth, the better he becomes at adjusting himself, and the easier the task—and the waiting—become. In taking this journey in his 70s, Wei makes up decades of lost wisdom and experience that he denied himself when he shut himself off from the world.



On the morning of the fourth day, Clerk Hu brings Wei the news that his request to see Sheng has been approved. As Wei takes a yellow form from Clerk Hu's hand, he realizes how much he had come to fear or expect Sheng's death. He feels relieved just to know that his son lives. For the first time in almost a week, he feels warm. By the time he's gathered his wits enough to say, "Thank you," Clerk Hu is halfway back to his desk.

Wei's journey teaches him about himself, the world, and his place in it. In leaving the villa, he redeems his past mistakes of isolation, selfishness, and pride. It's a mark of just how far he has come that he feels gratitude—rather than the useless guilt that keeps him trapped in the past—when he receives permission to visit Sheng. Finally, he sees a glimmer of hope for the future.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (I)

Wei has permission to visit Sheng the following afternoon. Clerk Hu, more helpful than he's been all week, tells Wei that it will take place at the correctional facility in nearby Ruyang. The town lies close to the quarry and a public bus travels between it and Luoyang. Tian goes with Wei to check the bus schedule. They discover that a bus leaves every other hour, and that a short walk from the depot will take him to the facility. Tian tells Wei that he will be returning to Guangzhou the following day; by the time Wei boards his bus, Tian will be on a south-bound train.

Wei apologizes for taking so much of Tian's time, but Tian insists that the trip has accomplished what he needed it to. He has accepted that the Ai-li he loved no longer exists. Wei, acknowledging how much he himself has lived in the past, tells Tian to go home and live his life looking toward the future. Then Wei asks why he found it easier to talk to Tian, a stranger, than to think of what to say to Sheng. Tian replies that Wei's trip speaks for itself. And, he assures his friend, the rest of the words will come at the right moment. As they walk toward the boardinghouse, Wei can't escape the feeling that he's trading one son for another.

Having seen Wei through to this crucial juncture, Tian prepares to depart. Since he fills a familial role for Wei, it's appropriate for him to leave before Wei reunites with his biological son, Sheng. But, more importantly, Wei began this journey alone and he must end it alone, too. Being able to take the last steps on his own will show that he has learned how to fend for himself in the world—and thus that he has become capable of taking care of his family, not just letting others take care of him.



Tian's grief arises from the love he still feels for Ai-li, but which she long ago stopped reciprocating. Finding a mutually supportive relationship with Wei—and, crucially, helping Wei to reunite with the family member he lost through the Communist Party—helps to heal that grief for Tian. He finds redemption in returning to Luoyang as a helper, not just as a victim of circumstance and fate. One possible answer to Wei's question is that he found it easier to form a relationship with Tian because he was not burdened by his guilt over the past, as he is with Sheng. And forming that relationship has given Wei the confidence he needs to trust that he can make things right with Sheng.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: SUYIN

Every afternoon during Meizhen's nap, Suyin goes to the kitchen to watch Kai Ying work. The more she learns, the more fascinated she becomes with the herbalist's art. Kai Ying teaches her about the basic ingredients and lets her help package some patients' daily doses. When Kai Ying praises Suyin's work, Suyin realizes how much she's missed being in school. She thanks Kai Ying for the lessons, but Kai Ying protests that she owes Suyin a debt of gratitude for helping manage Tao after Wei's sudden departure.

Suddenly, Suyin begins to spill out her family history. She tells Kai Ying about her two younger brothers, how her mother raised them all for several years on her own before marrying Suyin's stepfather. Kai Ying asks if Suyin's family lives in Guangzhou and if they know about the baby. Suyin says that she left when her pregnancy began to show and hasn't been home since. Kai Ying's questions make her worry that Kai Ying will try to send her home. The words tumble from her mouth as she describes her rape, but Kai Ying's arms surround Suyin in a protective embrace. Kai Ying promises Suyin that she will always have a home in the villa. And the thought of a safe home makes Suyin cry in relief and gratitude.

Kai Ying's love and care haven't just restored Suyin's physical health, but they have given her hope for the future once again. And the more Suyin acts like a member of the family—taking on responsibilities to support others, not just allowing them to help her—the more she becomes one of them, highlighting the idea that reciprocity forms the foundation of strong relationships.



Both to keep Kai Ying from sending her away and as an indication of how much safer she feels with the Lees than her own family, Suyin suddenly lays out her sad history. Kai Ying's response shows that Suyin didn't need to worry, though. She has already become an integral part of the Lee family, like Song did before her. In light of the cruel and terrible things that can happen to a person, Suyin finds herself lucky indeed to be surrounded by a family—the Lee family—that loves and supports her.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (II)

Wei and Tian share a bittersweet breakfast, promising to meet again in Guangzhou. Wei finds himself surprised at how hard he finds saying goodbye to a man he's known for less than a week. Tian turns back to wave before boarding the train car, and Wei watches through the window as he chooses a quiet seat near the back. When the train pulls away, Wei can no longer see Tian at the window, but he waves anyway.

When Tian left Ai-li at the Luoyang train station years earlier, her failure to look back and wave goodbye signaled the end of their relationship. Wei and Tian have known each other for far less time, but forged a more resilient bond, based on their shared experience of suffering and their willingness to offer each other. Wei waves even though he doesn't know if Tian sees him, determined to show how much he cherishes his friend.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: TAO

One morning before school, Little Shan approaches Tao and asks for a truce. Tao thinks about it. Little Shan betrayed Tao to Lai Hing, his worst enemy. Chairman Mao sends people away for less. Mao took Sheng away for less. Since his fall from the **kapok tree**, Tao's life has been so unsettled that he sometimes finds himself wondering how he's even standing upright. He remembers Wei telling him that best friends are hard to come by. Someone like Wei is hard to come by. Tao wants Wei back, but until then, Little Shan will have to do. He agrees to a truce.

As Wei comes closer and closer to redemption in Luoyang, things in Guangzhou begin to fall back into a sort of balance that feels somewhat familiar. For the first time since Sheng's arrest, Tao finds his footing as he looks within himself for the resilience necessary to forgive Little Shan. And as he forgives his friend, he realizes that he's also forgiven his grandfather—and even his father—for abandoning him.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (I)

Kai Ying tries to keep to a regular schedule to give some order to her life in the week of silence she endures after Wei's first telegram. She spends the best part of these days teaching Suyin about herbal medicine. She never realized how fulfilling teaching can be. On this afternoon, Kai Ying goes upstairs after their lesson and retrieves the bag of tiny **pearls** she took from Herbalist Chu's shop. She brings them downstairs and pours them into the palm of her hand, telling Suyin that they represent the time it will take her to learn the basics of herbal work—24 months. She's willing to teach Suyin if Suyin wants to learn. Suyin closes her hand around one of the pearls and says she does.

Since Sheng's arrest, Kai Ying has been trying to maintain the illusion that nothing has changed. But she cannot, and trying to avoid dealing with the pain of Sheng's arrest, Tao's fall, and the rest only made things harder. Now, however, as she begins to accept the new shape of her life and her family—which now includes Suyin and Meizhen, and which will remain incomplete until Sheng's release—she finds peace and even a small measure of joy. In this moment, she remembers lessons she learned when she came to Guangzhou to study herbal medicine: life changes constantly, but the person who remains open to those changing realities has a better chance of finding contentment and happiness.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (III)

Wei boards the noon bus bound for Ruyang, the permission slip in his jacket pocket. On his lap sits the folded wool sweater he's determined to give to Sheng, whether he's allowed to or not. Wei looks out the window and thinks idly of the treasures of Chinese history and culture that come from the area around Luoyang, the cradle of Chinese civilization. But these thoughts don't bring him the excitement they once would have. At the correctional facility, guards scrutinize his permission slip, then show him into a cold, windowless room. It has five rows of wooden tables with chairs on either side. An older woman waits at one across the room.

When the door opens, Wei's heart leaps. But it's not Sheng. Instead, it's a girl not much older than Suyin, with a shaved head, bruised face, and hunched posture. The guard tells her and the older woman that they have 15 minutes together. Wei looks away, trying to give the pair as much privacy as possible. He stares at the table, the scuffs and marks carved into it slowly transforming in his mind's eye into a map of China's great river systems. One looks like the Yellow River, which represents the spirit of the Chinese people. He studies the mark, wondering who made it, with what, and why.

When Wei looks up from the table, he sees the old woman comforting the girl. Then, a male guard approaches Wei to say that there was a mix-up: Sheng left for the quarry before the guards learned about the visit. He isn't here. The permission slip is for today only; Wei will have to reapply for another visit. Across the room, the girl screams when a guard wrenches her away from her mother.

As Wei boards the bus to visit Sheng, his ruminations prove how much he has changed. No longer does he care to live in the past; no longer does he find more excitement in the cultural heritage of China than he does in the thought of talking to his son for just a few minutes. Living in the past has cost Wei much joy and happiness in the present, a mistake he feels determined not to repeat. Thus, despite the bleak nature of the room, he feels hopeful rather than guilty for the first time in months.



The anonymous female prisoner offers a stark reminder of the Communist Party's cruelty—even though readers never know the nature of her crime, they know that Sheng has been locked up in the same place for the crime of speaking truth to power. Wei cannot help but make his reflexive comparison between the harsh realities of life under Communist rule and the former glory of China.



The anonymous prisoner's experience enhances the reader's sense of Communist Party cruelty, but the guard's callous disregard for ensuring that they help Sheng and Wei keep their appointment confirms it, too. The Party clearly respects no person, no authority, no values like love or family connection.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: SONG

Song looks at the garden, imagining the crops that will spring from the bare earth where she and Tao recently planted seeds. She prays to the goddess Kuan Yin that Wei will be home before the chives shoot up, and that Sheng will be back by the fall harvest. She looks forward to the harvest, even while she cautiously recognizes that nature both gives and takes away. She remembers her second spring in the villa, when incessant rains flooded the garden. When they stopped, she went to the garden to investigate, but her feet quickly got stuck in the mud. A teenaged Sheng pulled her out, laughing as mud spattered his nice clothes. He showed more of Liang's easygoing temperament than Wei's serious one. The memory of the first green sprouts that came up despite the flood brings tears to Song's eyes, as she considers nature's—and Sheng's—resilience.

Song's life has taught her to meet trial and difficulty with strength and hope. Her garden mirrors the lesson with its promise that periods of growth and abundance follow even the most hopelessly barren seasons, like when incessant rains flooded the patch and drowned most of the seeds. But a few survived, rewarding Song's hope for the harvest. Sheng played an important role in helping Song keep her hope, as he showed her how to handle a difficult situation with ease. Moreover, his actions promise that Song will never be alone again like she was in her marriage to Old Hing. At the villa, there will always be someone to lend a supporting hand.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (IV)

Wei returns to Luoyang, all too aware that he will have to wait days for his second request to be processed. He feels tired, hungry, and defeated. The boardinghouse room seems even drearier without Tian, but he imagines his friend encouraging him and tries to smile instead of weeping. Luckily, Clerk Hu seems to take pity on him, processing his second request much faster, and within two days, Wei finds himself on another bus to Ruyang. He feels homeless, and he worries that his money will run out before he sees Sheng.

Wei closes his eyes; this time, he hears Liang's voice. She asks him if he remembers the time when Sheng was little, and he insisted on flying his dragon kite even though there was no wind. He ran up and down the street until he was exhausted. Wei told him that the wind would return soon if Sheng could just wait patiently. Liang reminds Wei to take his own advice. He sits still, wanting to reach out for Liang but knowing that she will disappear if he does. Then the bus jerks to a stop. He's in Ruyang.

Even in this bleak moment, Wei refuses to allow himself to be consumed by despair. As he earlier conjured up the image of Liang when he needed strength and companionship, he now mentally calls Tian to his side. Wei draws strength from the realization that he has friends and support beyond his deceased wife.



When he conjures Liang in his mind, she reminds Wei to be patient. Of course, the lesson comes from Wei himself, since Liang has been dead for many years. But the way that he uses these imagined interactions to feel close to her shows how Wei's transformation is tied to nurturing his relationships. Wei can—and does—face the world on his own. But he doesn't want to feel alone. And thanks to the love of his family members, he doesn't have to.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (II)

Kai Ying hears footsteps on the second floor while she inventories her stock of herbs. She's the only one at home, so she wonders if they belong to the ghosts Wei told her about. She feels a little silly, but she goes looking for them nevertheless. When she comes to Wei's room, she goes inside and opens the curtains. In the bright daylight, she looks closely at the room for the first time. Like much of the villa, it's worn down and neglected, a shadow of its former, grander self. She tries to imagine what it would have looked like when Wei was a boy, before the Communist Party takeover, before he lost his university work and Liang. Suddenly, she realizes how lonely he must have been here over recent years. Before she leaves the room, she opens a window to let in fresh air.

Sheng writes a hurried letter to Kai Ying, which he will give to Wei during their visit. In it, he explains that the leader of his work team dislikes him and started intercepting and destroying his letters to and from home out of spite. Sheng was desperate over the silence from home until another inmate told him what was happening. He says he would have made a different choice if he had realized how hard the distance would be, and he asks for her forgiveness. He worries about her constantly. Only the thought of returning to her and Tao gets him through the long arduous days and terrible conditions. He reminds her of their trip to Zhaoqing as newlyweds, how they got stuck on separate boats crossing the lake and how sweet it was to reach the other side and be reunited. He begs her to hold on to hope.

Kai Ying's evident wish to see the ghosts really seems to say more about her desire to see Sheng and Wei again. The lives of the family members are so deeply entwined and so rooted in the villa that no one can be fully excised. Even though he's physically absent, Wei's presence remains in his room, in much the same way that his father remains part of the family through the portrait that hangs on the living room wall. In Wei's room, Kai Ying reflects on how much more his life has been changed by the Communist Revolution than hers. And in putting herself in Wei's place, she feels a sudden flash of empathy and understanding, which pushes her closer to forgiving him.



Sheng's letter underlines the distance the Communist Party has placed between him and his family as it answers some of the family's biggest questions, like why they haven't heard from him in months. It turns out that Sheng shared their suffering, unsure at first what the sudden silence from home signified. Sheng's punishment makes him reflect on the importance of his family; it seems that, like Wei, he didn't fully appreciate the importance of those connections until he lost them. But despite his pain and suffering, he clings to hope that his and Kai Ying's love—that the connections among all the family members—will be strong enough to carry them through this time.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (V)

As he waits in the visitor's room—alone this time—Wei traces the carved line of the Yellow River on the desk. He drapes the sweater for Sheng on the back of the chair. Finally, the door swings open. A gaunt, hard-faced Sheng shuffles in. Only then does Wei first think that Sheng might not want to see him. But Sheng's eyes soften as he looks at his father. Wei touches the sleeve of Sheng's tunic, to assure himself that his son is truly there. He clears his throat and explains the family's worry when Sheng suddenly fell silent. Sheng says his team manager has been destroying his letters to and from home.

Sheng asks how Kai Ying, Tao, and Song are holding up. Wei assures Sheng that everyone misses him desperately, then he fills him in on Suyin's arrival and Tao's fall. When Sheng wonders aloud why Tao would suddenly climb the **kapok tree**, Wei reminds him that they both climbed it as boys, too. When the guard turns away to light a cigarette, Sheng slips his letter to Kai Ying across the table. Wei apologizes for the grief he has caused by writing his letter and says he deserves the punishment instead. But Sheng replies that Wei need not ask forgiveness for speaking the truth. He would have said something similar eventually, even if Wei hadn't sent the letter. As the guard tells them that their time is up, Wei begs Sheng's forgiveness for letting so many precious years of Sheng's life slip by unappreciated. Sheng squeezes his father's hand.

For months, Wei has been holding a terrible thought at bay and he can no longer ignore it when Sheng walks into the room: Sheng might not want to forgive Wei, either for writing the letter or for his neglectful attitude toward Sheng earlier in his life. But Wei's relationships with the others have already prove the strength and resilience of the Lee family. And, as Tian promised, his willingness to undertake the perilous and difficult journey it and of itself shows not just his willingness but his ability to make up for his past mistakes.



The kapok tree that guards the courtyard has been a symbol of strength and resilience throughout the book; now it becomes a symbol of the Lee family men as well, a point of connection between Wei, Sheng, and Tao. Accustomed to seeing the distance between himself and his son, Wei has been blind to their similarities, similarities that Sheng points out now. While Wei has tortured himself with his focus on the past, in the present, he and Sheng have grown more alike as both have grown older and wiser. If Wei can live in the present, figuring out how to contend with difficulty and trial, this moment promises that he will find ways to redeem his past mistakes.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (VI)

On the train, Wei opens his eyes from a fitful nap. He longs for Tian's companionship or to be home tucking Tao into bed and telling his grandson a story. He touches the letter in his pocket. It's the proudest accomplishment of his long life. He will never feel totally absolved of the guilt he feels for stealing precious time from Sheng and his family. But the letter eases the ache a little.

Wei's priorities have shifted dramatically over the course of the novel. As a scholar, he prioritized his intellectual work over his family and focused on China's glorious past without realizing the treasures he had in the present: his loving family. Bringing the letter home for Kai Ying is a way he can serve his family, rather than letting them serve him.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: KAI YING (III)

For the first time in the five months since Tao's fall, Kai Ying stands in the courtyard directly in front of the **kapok tree**. At this time of year, it has bare, skeletal limbs; it will be months before its vibrant flowers reappear. She reaches out and touches the scar where Wei gashed it. It has grown so faint that only someone who knows where to look for it can see it. In the kitchen, she hears Tao and Suyin deep in animated conversation, and she smiles. The gate opens and she turns, surprised that a patient would come by that late in the afternoon. Instead, she sees Wei.

Standing in front of the kapok tree symbolizes Kai Ying's readiness—after months of resistance—to accept how radically her life has changed. Of course, by now it has changed for the better in some ways: Suyin and Meizhen have joined the family, giving Kai Ying an apprentice and a surrogate daughter and giving Tao an older sister. She looks at the scar on the tree's trunk, realizing that although it will never go away, time has softened it. Likewise, this era will leave marks on the family. But in time, the wounds will heal, the scars will diminish, and the pain will fade into the past. Wei enters the courtyard at just this moment, carrying a tiny promise of Sheng's return with him, and his presence promises that this period of trial and pain will come to an end soon enough.



THE CITY OF GHOSTS, NOVEMBER 1958: WEI (VII)

When he descends from the train, Wei wonders if he looks as exhausted as he feels. He must step aside from the late afternoon crowds to catch his breath. But he feels more like himself the closer he gets to home. When he pushes the gate open, the sight of Kai Ying by the **kapok tree** fills him with both relief and fear. As she moves toward him, he quickly assures her that Sheng is alive and well. He explains why the letters stopped. But, he says, he has brought one directly to her. When she turns to take it from his hand, he pulls her into an embrace. After a moment, her stiff body relaxes, and she whispers "Thank you" into his ear.

Wei demonstrates how much he has grown and changed when he successfully navigates the crowded city streets. He's still the same, retiring man he's always been, but he no longer hides from difficult things. He approaches Kai Ying with caution because he knows that he cannot demand her forgiveness. But much as his journey told Sheng of his love, it also told Kai Ying how much he values his family and how much he will do for them. Thus, she forgives him.



Later that evening, Wei knocks on Tao's door. Looking at him, Wei wonders how Sheng will feel when he returns home to find his little child turned into a boy. He regretfully considers that he'll never get to see Tao as a man, even though he can see his character beginning to grow. He hopes someday Tao will understand how important these months have been for Wei, how much they helped him grow. He steps into the room. Tao makes Wei promise never to leave again without warning. Then, he asks to hear the story of Huoyi and Chang'e. Wei looks out the window where the **kapok tree** stands silhouetted against a moonless sky. He notes that there's no moon tonight, but Tao says, "There's still the story."

Before his trip, Wei thought about events mostly as they affected him—how Sheng's absence or Tao's fall amplified his feelings of guilt, for example. But as he's grown into an attitude of greater responsibility in his family relationships, he has developed more empathy, too. Now he can think about how Tao's life intersects with his own, feeling regret that he will not know his grandson as a grown man, while also considering how these months of absence and growth will affect Sheng. Tao proves the resilience of family relationships when he welcomes Wei back gladly, all anger and momentary hatred forgotten. Tao asking for Chang'e and Huoyi's story suggests that like these two characters, the family will eventually be reunited.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Duprey, Annalese. "A Hundred Flowers." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 5 Oct 2023. Web. 5 Oct 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Duprey, Annalese. "A Hundred Flowers." LitCharts LLC, October 5, 2023. Retrieved October 5, 2023. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/a-hundred-flowers>.

To cite any of the quotes from *A Hundred Flowers* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Tsukiyama, Gail. *A Hundred Flowers*. St. Martin's Griffin. 2013.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Tsukiyama, Gail. *A Hundred Flowers*. New York: St. Martin's Griffin. 2013.